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KOLKATA, LATE CITY, 18 PAGES

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KPSC job scam: Karnataka HC sets up SIT probe
Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, September 21

THE KARNATAKA High Court on Monday directed that further investigation into the alleged scam related to the recruitment of 400 veterinarians by the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) be conducted by a Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by DGP Alok Kumar. Justice M Nagaprasanna passed the order while refusing
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

Pres. Trump hasn't so far noticed the free movement of gold, silver and bronze across competing nations.



Arrests, withdrawals, 'intimidation': testing time for Opp in bypoll

Cong's Nandigram candidate in jail, Kabir alleges harassment in Rejinagar

Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra
Kolkata, September 21

WITH THE BJP facing its first electoral test in West Bengal since it came to power in the Assembly elections earlier this year, the Opposition finds itself in a tough spot in two key constituencies — Nandigram and Rejinagar — amid candidate withdrawals, arrests and allegations of police pressure on Opposition workers.

The developments in the two seats, which will see by-polls on October 6, have prompted Opposition leaders to allege a pattern of pressure on their candidates and



A BJP poll graffiti in Nandigram. The ruling party says Opp making excuses. PARTHA PAUL

workers. The BJP, however, has rejected the allegations, with its leaders accusing the Opposition of making excuses ahead of the contest.

BJP state president Samik Bhattacharya took a dig at the
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Members of the IIT-Bombay Faculty Forum march in support of Prof Suryanarayana Doolla, Monday

IIT-Bombay removes prof named in student suicide from dean post

Faculty members protest, say 'vilification'

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, September 21

AMID MOUNTING student protests following the death by suicide of 20-year-old student

Sahil Wakode, IIT-Bombay on Monday suspended "with immediate effect" Prof Suryanarayana Doolla from the post of Dean of Administrative Affairs. The institution's move, how-

ever, failed to satisfy the protesting students, who sought Doolla's suspension as a professor, too. Doolla was the invigilator in the classroom where Wakode was allegedly found using a mobile phone during an exam on Friday — the BTech student
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Mahadev betting app case: ED chargesheets EaseMyTrip promoter

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 21

THE ENFORCEMENT Directorate has chargesheeted EaseMyTrip promoter Nishant Pitti in the alleged Rs 5,000-crore Mahadev online betting app money laundering case, accusing him of "facilitating" the movement of proceeds from il-

legal betting into the equity market under the guise of foreign portfolio investments, officials have said. Pitti told *The Indian Express* that he was "neither aware of any chargesheet nor been summoned by the jurisdictional court".

The chargesheet, filed before a Raipur court on September 10,
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

LAYS DOWN GUIDELINES

SC raises bar on re-arrests, stresses Art 22

Magistrate's nod required if seeking re-arrest of person released for not being given grounds of arrest, says Bench

Amaal Sheikh & Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, September 21

UNDERLINING THAT when an accused is released due to violation of his fundamental rights, he is not "enlarged on bail" but released from illegal and unconstitutional detention, the Supreme Court on Monday laid down strict guidelines for re-arresting a person if he was earlier released for not being provided grounds of arrest.

The bench of Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and Atul S Chandurkar said the safeguards provided under Article 22 cannot be "tinkered with".

Article 22 is a fundamental right under the Constitution that provides for an accused to

E. EXPLAINED

More guardrails

The SC ruling raises the bar for the state in arresting an individual, even in serious offences, and reiterates that procedural norms are sacrosanct when liberty is curtailed. The ruling lays down that the police would face negative consequences for violating constitutional safeguards.

be produced before a magistrate within 24 hours of arrest, to be informed about the grounds of arrest, and to get
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **SUZUKI CUP**, an India-Japan T20I cricket match to celebrate 75 years of diplomatic ties between the two countries, will be played in Japan.

INSIDE

SONIA VOTER ROLL CASE: COURT SETS ASIDE DISMISSAL OF FIR PLEA [PAGE 10](#)

CHINESE PRESIDENT XI JINPING TO VISIT U.S. SEPT 23-25 [PAGE 14](#)

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Har Pal Aapke Saath

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Bengal bypolls

Opposition, but also struck a note of caution. “The so-called main Opposition party has no name... Their candidate (from Nandigram) covered hundreds of kilometres and met the Chief Minister while their party was in the dark. This proves that there is no Opposition. It is not a welcome situation in a democracy,” he said.

The Nandigram tangle

In Nandigram, the candidate of the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress (TMC) faction, Sanchita Dey Pradhan, withdrew from the contest, following which Mamata extended support to the Congress candidate Milan Pradhan. Within hours, Pradhan was arrested in connection with cases related to the 2007 anti-land acquisition agitation.

The Nandigram bypoll was necessitated after Adhikari resigned as MLA from the seat to retain the Bhabhanipur seat, where he defeated Mamata.

Pradipta Mukherjee, spokesperson of the Mamata faction of the TMC termed the development as the BJP’s “fascist tendency of the BJP to stifle Opposition voices”. “They (BJP) have the people mandate but are now using state machinery to oppress the Opposition,” he added. In Rejinagar, meanwhile, Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) chief Humayun Kabir, whose resignation has necessitated the bypoll, has alleged police harassment against party workers and said he would not campaign on the ground. His son, Golam Nabi Azad, is the AJUP candidate here.

After appearing before the police for questioning at Berhampore police station on Monday, Kabir told The Indian Express over the phone that he had decided to campaign through social media instead. “It is very clear. The police are trying to harass me and my party workers. To prevent further arrests and harassment of my party workers, I have decided that I will not campaign on the ground. I will also not allow my son, who is the candidate, to campaign. Instead, I will use social media. But I will not bow down,” he said.

The Rejinagar seat fell vacant after Kabir resigned as MLA to retain Naoda. Kabir, a former TMC MLA, left the party and formed the AJUP ahead of the polls. He has also attracted controversy over his move to construct what he has described as a replica of the Babri Masjid in Murshidabad.

Why was Kabir questioned?

The police questioning followed a viral audio clip in which two people can allegedly be heard discussing a plan to switch off CCTV cameras around the site of a Babri Masjid replica being constructed in Murshidabad and put up BJP flags in order to trigger communal tension. The police said one of the

voices in the recording belongs to Sarfaraz Nawaz Chowdhury, who is a resident of Tungi village in Naoda has been arrested. Chowdhury. Investigators believe the other voice belongs to a political leader from Murshidabad. The police issued a notice to Kabir based on information obtained during Chowdhury’s interrogation.

The police action against AJUP functionaries has intensified in recent days. On September 20, four senior party office-bearers — Manjur Rehman, Nasim Sheikh, Haq Mallick and Abdul Halim — were arrested in connection with various old cases.

On September 19, Independent candidate Saiful Islam was arrested in connection with a 2021 election clash case. A day earlier, Ashik Iqbal, the AJUP state secretary, was arrested allegedly with fake currency notes. Kabir has accused the BJP and the Democratic Trinamool Congress, a breakaway faction led by Ritabrata Banerjee, of working in tandem to target AJUP workers by providing names to local police.

Mamata’s Rejinagar hurdles

The Rejinagar contest has also seen uncertainty within the TMC. Its candidate, Rabiul Alam Chowdhury, initially announced that he would withdraw from the race, citing internal difficulties and concerns over the introduction of the party’s new “footballer” election symbol. He later reversed the decision following intervention by Mamata and the party leadership and is now back in the contest.

The Congress has fielded Mohammed Abdullahil Kafi, while the BJP has nominated Sakharav Sarkar. State minister Gourf Shankar Ghosh has been appointed the BJP’s election in-charge for the constituency.

Sarkar said the BJP’s campaign was centred on development and employment. “I am campaigning. I am talking about setting up good industries and factories in the area. There is a need for a college in the area. There should be a proper bridge. Our pitch to the public is development and employment. Those opposing us are playing the religion card,” he told The Indian Express.

Ghosh, meanwhile, dismissed Kabir’s allegations and said the BJP would win Rejinagar. “He (Kabir) knows he will lose. Now, he is making such excuses. The BJP will win in Rejinagar,” Ghosh said.

Rejinagar, where Muslims account for roughly 65% of the electorate, is particularly significant in the bypoll battle. Adhikari has described the contest as a “test” of whether minority voters want to support the government’s development agenda, a remark that has drawn criticism from the Opposition. The results of the two bypolls will be announced on October 9.

Mahadev betting app case: ED chargesheets EaseMyTrip promoter

is the sixth in the case. The Mahadev betting app case relates to an alleged illegal online betting network operated through a network of websites and apps, with the ED investigating the generation and laundering of betting proceeds. The agency has alleged that the proceeds were routed through a complex network of shell entities, benami accounts and other channels before being invested or used to acquire assets.

While submitting its latest chargesheet, the ED said it had provisionally attached Pitti’s DEMAT shares worth Rs 59.6 crore under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). The attachment order was issued when the ED filed its chargesheet, officials said.

The ED also sought the court’s permission to “confiscate” the shares, describing them as “proceeds of crime” under the anti-money laun-

dering law, officials said. Pitti told *The Indian Express* he had “nothing to say on the matter”.

“I have always cooperated with and shall continue to cooperate with all law enforcement bodies. I shall submit detailed evidence to establish my bona fide conduct, in accordance with the procedure prescribed by law,” he said.

So far, the ED has arrested 14 people and attached assets worth Rs 1,885 crore. Police sources claim the racket is still operational, “although under different names”.

The Raipur Zonal Office of the ED issued a Provisional Attachment Order (PAO) on March 24 this year, attaching 20 immovable properties — including 18 in Dubai and two in New Delhi. “The foreign assets are located in prime areas of Dubai. Some of the attached properties are also located in Burj Khalifa,” the ED said in a statement in March this year.

CORRECTION & CLARIFICATION

PAGE 10, 21.09.2026

● Under the headline ‘Indian-German climber, Nepali Sherpa guide die in avalanche’, an unrelated report was carried wrongly. The error is regretted.

SC raises bar on re-arrests, stresses Article 22

legal representation.

“Any breach or non-compliance would entail immediate release of the arrested person because such arrest is unconstitutional. We cannot tinker with the most important safeguards provided under Article 22,” the court said.

The bench also directed high courts across the country to grant “suitable mandatory compensation” when arrests violate procedural safeguards.

Detailing the procedure for seeking re-arrests in such cases, the bench said the accused should first be provided written grounds of arrest, and an application should be filed before a magistrate explaining why a re-arrest was necessary and why the grounds were not given the first time. It also said that the investigation should be assigned to another officer, and a departmental inquiry should be ordered into the previous arrest.

The court said the power to re-arrest must not be “left to the discretion of the very same authority who had violated the said provision of the Constitution... It must have the judicial imprimatur”.

It said the magistrate can allow re-arrest only when satisfied “that for bona fide reasons, the grounds of arrest could not be furnished to the arrestee at the first instance but furnished subsequent to his release”, and

that the accused needs to be re-arrested.

“To rule out any foul play or collusion, such an application must have the endorsement of the immediate superior authority. This is because the immediate superior authority should know that the concerned officer has committed an unbecoming act of violating a constitutional provision for which necessary remedial steps will have to be taken,” the bench said in its 69-page ruling, adding that the magistrate must decide such an application within a week.

The superior officer giving endorsement “shall hand over the investigation of the case to another officer, further directing departmental enquiry for such a serious lapse.” An adverse finding “would entail departmental action with entry in the service book of such officer(s),” it said.

“Article 22(1) applies across the spectrum including of fences under the BNS or under special enactments. It is not a mere formality or a matter of procedure. It is a mandatory binding constitutional safeguard. When there is violation of the Constitution, question of prejudice or demonstrable prejudice does not arise. The safeguards adumbrated in Article 22(1) are not mere procedural safe-

guards; these are fundamental principles which are required to be followed in the event liberty of a person is sought to be curtailed,” the court said.

Article 22(1) provides for the accused to be informed about the grounds of arrest.

The bench was hearing an appeal filed by an accused in a POCO case in Punjab in May. The accused was released by the local magistrate on the ground that he was not provided the reasons for his arrest, but the magistrate allowed the police to arrest him again, complying with procedural safeguards. The police filed a fresh application the same day seeking his arrest, which was, however, dismissed by another magistrate.

The accused then moved the Punjab and Haryana High Court, challenging the magistrate’s decision to allow the police to arrest him again. After the HC, on May 29, allowed the police to arrest him again, the accused moved the SC.

The Punjab government had argued that given the serious nature of the allegations, police “should not face fetters” while arresting an accused. To this, the SC said that the violation of the Constitution “cannot be countenanced”.

“It has to be dealt with strictly. It is not dependent on the nature or gravity of the offence, en-

compassing within its sweep all offences,” the bench said.

Over the past three years, the SC has raised the bar for the state, reiterating that communicating the grounds of arrest is mandatory. In *Pankaj Bansal v Union of India*, the SC, in October 2023, held that all arrests under the stringent PMLA require that a written copy of the grounds of arrest be furnished to the arrested person “as a matter of course and without exception.”

A later order in *Ram Kishor Arora v Directorate of Enforcement* (December 2023) diluted the rule, holding that such grounds need not always be supplied in writing, and treated the *Pankaj Bansal* ruling as prospective in nature.

However, in May 2024, in *Prabir Purkayastha v State (NCT of Delhi)*, the SC reaffirmed that an arrested person must be provided the grounds of arrest in writing at the earliest. The position was finally settled in *Mihir Rajesh Shah v State of Maharashtra* (November 2025), where the court held that written grounds of arrest must be furnished across all offences and statutes, in a language the arrestee understands, and directed that failure to do so would render both the arrest and subsequent remand illegal. Monday’s judgment builds on that line of reasoning.

isers said the deal with Shanghai Yude, that also supplied temporary power at the previous edition of the Games, does not include Japan’s regular public electricity supply and is restricted only to Games operations.

There are Chinese suppliers inside the competition venues, too. Shandong Taishan Sports Equipment is supplying equipment across nine sports — boxing, wrestling, gymnastics, taekwondo, karate, wushu, kurash, jujitsu and archery.

Shenzhen Transtech Display Technology is an official supplier of LED screens across venues.

The Chinese presence also extends into newer parts of the Games. Tencent Technology (Shenzhen) Company Limited is an official supplier for esports solutions, with esports returning as a medal sport after its debut at Hangzhou. Sportswear company 361° is a “prestige partner” of the Games, making Aichi-Nagoya its fifth consecutive Asian Games partnership after Guangzhou, Incheon, Jakarta-Palembang and Hangzhou.

Meanwhile, the host — Japan — also has its share of companies on the ground. The major areas that Japanese companies are involved in include transport, communication and other Games operations.

In Japan’s Asiad, China’s growing footprint

venue technology, LED screens and sporting equipment.

The most prominent is the China Media Group-International Media Port (CMG-IMP), the host broadcaster appointed by the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games Organising Committee (AINAGOC) and approved by the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA).

CMG-IMP is producing the international television footage and providing facilities and services to rights-holding broadcasters, including the beauty shots of Nagoya and Aichi prefecture. According to the OCA, 3,858 personnel are working for the host broadcaster, which is providing live coverage of 28 sports while leaving out 15.

This is the first time that the Shanghai-based operation has been named the host broadcaster for an event held outside China. Hong Kong-based outlet Bastille Post reported that the CMG is also taking some of the production away from Japan, and doing it remotely from China.

The broadcasting contract itself has an unusual history. AINAGOC’s first host-broadcast contract went to ISBHAO, a consortium involving Spain’s International Sports Broadcasting and China’s Yahao Sports Culture Media. This contract was later terminated, and AINAGOC conducted a new selection pro-

cess. CMG-IMP eventually won the new contract for a reported sum of 5.156 billion yen (approx Rs 314 crore).

AINAGOC and OCA did not respond to a questionnaire sent by The Indian Express on the host broadcaster’s contract as well as the broader Chinese involvement in the Games’ delivery.

OCA president Sheikh Joaan bin Hamad Al-Thani of Qatar told Chinese state media CGTN on Saturday: “What we have seen is impressive. The assessment would be at the end of the Games, we will see how things go in the next 17 days but what I have seen is really, really impressive.”

Then there is Zhejiang Dafeng Industry, based in China’s Zhejiang province, which is an AINAGOC Tier 2 official partner and “responsible for the planning, production and operation of the opening and closing cer-

emonies of the 20th Asian Games as well as digital content creation, the design and production of the cauldron, performances and cultural programmes”, according to the OCA statement earlier this year.

Dafeng, the OCA said, was listed on the Shanghai Stock Exchange in 2017. The company was also involved in the Hangzhou Asian Games in 2023.

The same pattern -- of companies involved in the Hangzhou Asian Games also being a part of the Aichi-Nagoya operations -- appears elsewhere. Beijing-based Starting Future Technology is an official supplier for venue technology operations. Its previous event experience includes the Hangzhou Asian Games and the Harbin Asian Winter Games.

Shanghai Yude Energy is a partner for temporary power supply at the Games. The organ-

KPSC jobs scam: Karnataka HC sets up SIT

to transfer the probe to the CBI in the case that is now being investigated by the State CID and involves the suspended KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar as one of the accused.

The court has directed a “de-novo” (from the beginning) investigation into the allegations. The SIT probe is to be completed within 100 days and progress reports placed before the court once every 30 days, it said. The CID and the local police have been told to hand over all the probe material to the SIT.

The bench said: “In the peculiar facts obtained in these cases, I do not deem it appropriate to permit investigations at the hands of the CID or the local police. I am equally not persuaded that entrustment of investigation to the Central Bureau of Investigation is the only available course. In exercise of the jurisdiction of this court under Article 226, I deem it appropriate to constitute a special investigation team.”

The High Court’s order came as it pronounced its verdict in two separate petitions seeking a CBI probe into KPSC recruitments — one by a veterinarian, Dr S Manjunath, in the recruitment of 400 Veterinary Officers; and another by BJP MLA Basanagouda Patil Yatnal seeking a CBI probe of the recruitment of Sahukar’s daughter allegedly with a forged income certificate

to the post of industrial extension officer.

On Saturday, *The Indian Express* had published the findings of its investigation into the KPSC scam: these scandals were part of a larger pattern of irregularities during the tenure of Sahukar, who was handpicked by the BJP for the KPSC in 2019 and shielded by the Congress that came to power in Karnataka in 2023. This newspaper also reported that the alleged irregularities flagged by job aspirants included marks withheld and top scorers targeted for bribes; interview panels manipulated; tabulated records altered; answer sheets tampered with; and, question papers leaked to select candidates. In Monday’s order, the High Court noted that a Public Service Commission is not merely a recruiting agency of the state but also a “Constitutional sentinel at the gateway to public employment”. The Commission represents a Constitutional promise that neither money nor muscle, neither proximity to power nor pedigree, will steal a march over merit, it said.

The court observed: “Recruitment malpractice, therefore, is not a mere procedural aberration capable of being brushed aside as an irregularity in an examination. When marks are manipulated, answer scripts or OMR sheets are tampered with, selections are purchased,

or nepotism and favouritism creep into the process, the fraud is not merely upon an unsuccessful candidate; it is a fraud upon the Constitution itself.”

The bench has also directed the SIT to extend cooperation to the Enforcement Directorate, which has registered an ECIR (complaint) in the case.

The bench underscored that a Constitutional institution entrusted with selecting the servants of the State must remain “like Caesar’s wife — above suspicion”. Justice Nagaprasanna said, “Once the purity of the fountain of recruitment is polluted, what flows from it cannot inspire public confidence.”

The bench said: “Recruitment to public service must be fiercely protected from tentacles of corruption, manipulation, nepotism and favouritism, lest the Constitutional guarantee of equality of opportunity under Articles 14 and 16 will be reduced from a living assurance, into an empty parchment promise.”

It said: “A deserving aspirant displaced by corruption loses more than a job; he loses faith in the Constitutional assurance that public employment is equally accessible to all.”

The bench also highlighted how thousands of youth spend the most productive years of their lives preparing for these examinations. It said: “When a post is sold, an OMR sheet is

IIT Bombay

died by suicide later that day.

Monday’s decision on Doolla was communicated to the students in an email by IIT-Bombay Director Prof Shireesh Kedare around noon. “The Deanship of Prof. Suryanarayana Doolla is suspended with immediate effect. Any further action will be taken after investigation,” Kedare said in the email.

Soon after the decision became public, the IIT-Bombay Faculty Forum released a statement in support of the professor. The Forum also held a march inside the campus in solidarity with the professor and entered the convocation hall where Director Kedare and other members of the administration were holding an open house meeting with the students to discuss their issues.

Doolla, who was earlier Dean of Student Affairs, has been named in the FIR registered by Mumbai Police on the basis of a complaint by Wakode’s parents, who alleged that their son was subjected to caste-based discrimination by the professor.

The action against Doolla was among the 18 demands submitted by students to the institute administration late Sunday night, following three days of protests on campus. At the time, Kedare had assured students that the institute would work towards fulfilling their demands.

IIT-Bombay’s Board of Governors discussed the demands Monday but has not issued any official statement on whether all of these would be accepted.

In the evening, Director Kedare and other senior faculty members from the administration held an open house, which was also among the 18 demands. The session lasted three hours, with students raising issues faced by them on the campus.

IIT-Bombay also issued an apology for statements made in its earlier communication regarding Wakode’s death, meeting another key demand of students. In its initial communication, the institute had referred to Wakode’s alleged use of an AI tool during the examination.

In a subsequent post on X,

the institute said: “We apologise for the statements contained in our earlier communication concerning the circumstances surrounding the unfortunate demise of Sahil. The details and circumstances leading up to the incident remain subject to investigation by the appropriate authorities. In view of the ongoing investigation, it was inappropriate to have set out or characterised details relating to the events preceding his demise before they had been duly established through the appropriate investigative process.”

The students had also demanded an independent investigation into the circumstances leading to Wakode’s death and an apology for what they described as “defamation”. They contended that proceedings before the disciplinary action committee should have remained confidential until a conclusion was reached.

In its statement, meanwhile, the Faculty Forum expressed distress over what they said was “vilification” of their colleague’s reputation. The statement highlighted Doolla’s record, stating that he “continues to be a faculty member in good standing”, who “has won several accolades and awards, including two awards for excellence in teaching, which are decided purely on student feedback”.

“During his long tenure as Dean (Student Affairs), he was instrumental in setting up several initiatives for the welfare of the student community of our campus,” the Forum said in the statement signed by its president Prof Rajkumar Pant.

However, one faculty member, Sociology professor Suryakant Waghmore, took to social media against the forum. “I do not identify with the statement of the Faculty Forum and there are several others who may not come on record. The Faculty Forum should allow the institutional and legal measures to prevail and not interfere in these matters,” Prof Waghmore said.

Earlier, a group of faculty members had gathered at the Nandan Nilekani Main Building of the institution in support of Doolla.

Naga film Angh wins Platform Award at Toronto Film Fest

Win secures direct pathway to contest at the Oscars 2027

Alaka Sahani

Mumbai, September 21



Nagaland filmmaker Theja Rio at the Toronto Film Festival

KOHIMA-BASED THEJA Rio’s debut feature *Angh* has won the Platform Award at the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), securing a direct pathway to compete for the Oscars 2027 in the International Feature Film category.

Speaking about the landmark win, Rio said: “I’m aware that it’s rare for a debut film to receive this kind of recognition, and all I can say is that we made *Angh* with a lot of love for the place I come from, for my people and for our culture.”

By winning TIFF’s top prize, *Angh* can bypass the traditional single-country submission requirement under a new rule allowing non-English-language films to qualify for Best International Feature Film category by winning a top award at one of six major international festivals.

The news came soon after it was overlooked by the Film Federation of India, which chose Marathi film *Gondhal* as India’s official entry to the Oscars.

The Platform jury, headed by Pablo Trapero, in its statement said: “The Platform Prize goes to *Angh*. For its refreshing perspective, strength of filmmaking, and deeply resonant portrait of a world. We praise filmmaker’s vision, audacity and courage.”

Set against the backdrop of 1960s Nagaland, *Angh* follows an ageing Konyak village chief and his son, who remain among the last people holding on to their ancestral faith and way of life as their world undergoes remarkable change.

“At the heart of the film is a relationship between a father and son, but it is also about letting go, our relationship with home and transient nature of life. These are some of the most universal emotions,” said Rio,

Angh was shot on 16mm, with cinematography by Adam Pietkiewicz (Baby Reindeer), who also received the TIFF Variety Artisan Award.

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Completion Period 06 months (Six Months)
Earnest Money Deposit Rs. 5,18,400/- (through e-payment).
Cost of Tender Document NIL
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable) Rs. 3,540/- (inclusive all taxes & duties through e-payment).
Date of sale of Tender (online) 22.09.2026 (from 15:00 hrs) to 15.10.2026 (upto 17:00 hrs)
Date & Time of submission of Tender (online) 16.10.2026 (upto 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online) 19.10.2026 at 15:00hrs.
For financial eligibility criteria, experience with respect to similar nature of work, etc. please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concorindia.com, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderwizard.com/CIL only. Further, Corrigendum/ Addendum to this Tender, if any, will be published on website www.concorindia.com, www.tenderwizard.com/CIL and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall not be issued for the same.
Group General Manager (Projects), Phone No.: 011-41222500

**Kolhapur Municipal Corporation,**
Workshop Department

Public Tender Notice No. 64
Second Extension for Time Limit for Serial Nos. 1 to 35
Tenders have been invited via Public Tender Notice No. 64 for the procurement of spare parts, purchase of accessories, repairs, etc., for the maintenance of various types of vehicles in use by the Kolhapur Municipal Corporation. These are invited from manufacturing companies, authorized dealers of companies in the local market, etc. The submissions must include detailed information, incorporating discounts on the respective company's price list, all taxes, packing, forwarding, handling charges, etc., for the tasks from Serial No. 1 to Serial No. 35 A second extension of the time limit from September 22, 2026 to September 30, 2026, is being granted for this. Detailed information regarding this will be available to view on the website www.mahatender.gov.in
Date: September 21, 2026
SD/-
City Engineer
Kolhapur Municipal Corporation

PASCHIM BARDHAMAN ZILLA PARISHAD
NOTICE

This is bring to the notice of the land owners of the proposed project area of the Gourangdi ABC Coal Mine, WBMDTCL Phase-III in the Mouza(s) Panuria (JL No.10), Daskeari (JL No.03), PS- Barabani, District- Paschim Bardhaman that in terms of the West Bengal Development and Trading Corporation Ltd. vide Memo no. MDTC/GABC/2026-27/67 Dated 07/09/2026, decision taken in the meeting of the District Level Land Purchase Committee on 11/09/2026 in this regards, the Paschim Bardhaman Zilla Parishad will purchase land for WBMDTCL as per requirement and placement of fund in the government approved rate i.e.
1. Non-Agriculture (Bastu/ Viti): Rs 37 Lakhs per acre (including 50% incentive/solatum)
2. Agriculture Land (Other than Bastu/Viti): Rs 24 Lakhs per acre (including 50% incentive/solatum)
The legal owners of the land willing to sell their encumbrance free land to the Zilla Parishad/WBMDTCL are requested to apply in plain paper mentioning land details and photocopies of "Pracha" to the Paschim Bardhaman Zilla Parishad within 15 days from the date of publish of this notice.
SD/-
District Magistrate
Paschim Bardhaman &
Chairman
District Land Purchase
Committee Paschim Bardhaman

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
e-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender is being invited for "selection of reputed Bidder/Contractor/Agencies for Washing of Linens at ESI Hospital Budge-Budge, P.O. Doulatpur, 89T Road, via Vivekananda Pally, P.S. Maheshtala, Kolkata-700139. NIT, Terms and conditions & other bid documents will be available in the website www.tenders.wb.gov.in. Sd/-SUPERINTENDENT, ESI HOSPITAL BUDGE-BUDGE.
ICA-T18028(3)/2026

E-NIT

Corrigendum notice of e-NIT No. 04/15th CFCG(U8 & T4) /D.H-II/P.S.26-27, Memo No.- 441(35) D.H-II /P.S. Dt.-10/09/2026. Tender ID: 2026 ZPHD 5023521 1 to 12.
With reference to the above NIT the following changes have been made. Please read Last date of application as 26/09/2026 up to 13.00 Hrs. Contact the office of the u/s and visit www.tenders.wb.gov.in for details.
SD/-
E.O
Diamond Harbour-II P.S
Sarisha: South 24-Parganas

e-TENDER NOTICE

e-NIT no. WB/TMPS/EO/625/NIT-05/26-27 Dt. 11.09.2026 for SI. no. 1 to 9 for different schemes at EO,T.M. Panchayet Samity. Thakurpukur Maheshtala Block, 39, Biren Roy Road (East), South 24 Parganas invites E-Tender for the work for the same as details below:
Name of Work - SI. no. 1 to 9 for different Schemes. Thakurpukur Maheshtala Panchayet Samity.
Bid Submission date Started on 23.09.2026 at 02.00 P.M. (As per server clock) and Bid Submission End date 05.10.2026 at 02.00 P.M. (As per server clock). Technical Bid Opening date 07.10.2026 at 02.00 P.M. (As per server clock) details on NIT & Tender Documents may be download from: <http://tenders.wb.gov.in>
SD/-
Executive Officer
Thakurpukur Maheshtala Panchayet Samity, South 24 Parganas

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
PWD TENDER NOTICE

IPGME&R-SSKM Hospital----False ceiling for Air Conditioning of Non AC Zone to avoid water seepage at G+10 Trauma Care Centre of IPGME&R-SSKM during the year 2026-27. (Civil works). Earnest Money : Rs. 28,000.00. e-NIT No. WBPWD/KSHD/EE/NIT-14 OF 2026-2027. Tender ID : 2026- WBPWD_5073796_1. Bid Submission Start date (online): 25/09/2026 at 1:00 P.M. Bid Submission Closing date (online) : 09/10/2026 upto 1:00 P.M. Corrigendum if any will be published in website only. Details of NIT & tender documents may be downloaded from: <http://wbtdenders.gov.in> Sd/- Executive Engineer-I, PWD, Kolkata South Health Division.
ICA-T18040(3)/2026

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
OFFICE OF THE MPO-CUM-SUPERINTENDENT
ESI HOSPITAL MANICKTALA
BAGMARI ROAD, KOLKATA-54
e-Tender Notice

The tenders are being invited by the MPO-Cum-Superintendent, ESI Hospital Manicktala, Kolkata-54 for selection of agency for "Reagent and Kits". Tender schedule with detailed terms and conditions will be available in the website <https://wbtdenders.gov.in>. Sd/- MPO-CUM-SUPERINTENDENT, ESI HOSPITAL MANICKTALA
ICA-T18030(3)/2026

**केनरा बैंक Canara Bank**

Premises & Estate Section, Circle Office
5th Floor, 21, Camac Street
Kolkata- 700016
Tel : 033-22831501

TENDER FOR SUPPLY, INSTALLATION, TESTING, COMMISSIONING OF SPECIALISED KITCHEN EQUIPMENTS AT STAFF TRAINING FACILITY AT NEW TOWN, KOLKATA

Applications are invited for SUPPLY, INSTALLATION, TESTING, COMMISSIONING OF SPECIALISED KITCHEN EQUIPMENTS AT STAFF TRAINING FACILITY AT NEW TOWN, KOLKATA under Circle Office Kolkata in West Bengal. The applications along with details can be downloaded from Bank's website www.canarabank.bank.in/tenders. Last date for submission of offers is 12.10.2026, 3.00 P.M. The Bank deserves the right to accept or reject any or all of the offers without assigning any reasons thereof. Further communications, corrigendum, amendments if any will be hosted in Bank's website only. Incomplete applications shall not be accepted.
Place : Kolkata
Date : 22.09.2026
SD/- Assistant General Manager
Circle Office, Kolkata

E & N F Rly JCCS Ltd. - SDAH
NOTICE OF SPECIAL GENERAL MEETING (SGM) TO ALL SHAREHOLDERS

DATE : THURSDAY, 24 SEPTEMBER 2026.
TIME : 10:00 HRS TO 17:00 HRS.
VENUE : DR. B.C. ROY AUDITORIUM, DRM BUILDING COMPLEX, SDAH, E RLY, KOLKATA.
AGENDA : TO INCORPORATE AMENDED BYE-LAWS. A DRAFT OF THE PROPOSED AMENDMENTS IS AVAILABLE FOR INSPECTION AT THE SOCIETY'S REGISTERED OFFICE DURING OFFICE HOURS.
• All Shareholders are invited to attend. •

**OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER-IN-CHIEF (CIVIL), ODISHA**
NIRMAN SOUDHA, UNIT-V, BHUBANESWAR
E-mail ID:cebbuildings_orissa@yahoo.co.in | cebbuildings@rediffmail.com
Tel.-(0674)-2391523

INVITATIONS FOR BIDS (IFB)
File No-B-I-Rev.-01/2026 Lr. No.- 34635 Bhubaneswar 19th Sep., 2026
Invitation for Bids
Bid Identification No. CE-Bldg-1-38/2026-27
1. The E.I.C. (Civil), (I/c) Chief Engineer, Buildings-I, Odisha on behalf of Governor of Odisha invites bids from reputed Indian firms/Contractor registered with the State Government and bidders of equivalent Grade/Class registered with Central Government/MES/Railways for the infrastructure works detailed in the table below on turnkey basis (i.e. Architectural planning with detailed design, vetting & execution).
2. Nature of work Construction of Annex Building with Training, Administrative Support Facilities and 500 Seater Auditorium of ROTI, Gothapatana, Bhubaneswar on Turnkey Basis.
3. No. of work 01 No.
4. Bid Cost Rs. 10,000/-
5. Class of Contractor Super Class
6. Availability of Bid Documents From dt.05.10.2026 to 05.30 PM of dt.26.10.2026 in the website
7. Pre-bid meeting Dt.13.10.2026 at 11.30 AM
8. Last date of online submission of bid Dt. 26.10.03.2026 up to 5:30 PM
9. Last dt. Of Submission of hardcopy (Cover-III). Dt. 30.10.02026 up to 5:30 PM
10. Date of Opening of Bid Dt. 31.10.2026 at 11:30 AM.
11. The Bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can be seen from the website :<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. Any addendum /corrigendum /cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website only.
SD/-
Engineer-in-Chief (Civil), (I/c) Chief Engineer, Buildings-I, Odisha Bhubaneswar
OIPR- 34001/34117/1/26-27/0073

Format C-2
(For political party to publish in website, newspapers, TV)

Declaration about criminal antecedents of candidates set up by the party
(As per the judgement dated 25th September, 2018 of Hon'ble Supreme Court in WP(Civil) No. 536 of 2011 (Public Interest Foundation & Ors. Vs.Union of India & Anr.)
Name of political party : **BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY (BJP)**
*Name of Election : **LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY BYE ELECTION - 2026**
Name of the State/UT : **WEST BENGAL**

1.	2.	3.		4.	
Name of candidate	Name of constituency	Pending criminal cases		Details about cases of conviction for criminal offences	
		Name of Court, case No. & status of the case(s)	Sections of the Acts concerned & brief description of offence(s)	Name of Court & date(s) of order(s)	Description of offence(s) & punishment imposed
SHANKHARAVH SARKAR	70-REJINAGAR	Ld 3rd Court at Berhampore Berhampore– P.S Case No. 576/24 Dated 18/04/2024, G.R. 1921/24 Charges have not been framed	U/S - 341/323/ 504/ 506/34 of I.P.C.	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE
		GRO Berhampore Berhampore– P.S Case No. 1107/22 Dated 25/08/2022, G.R. 3667/22 Charges have not been framed	U/S - 188 of I.P.C.	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE
		GRO Berhampore Beldanga- P.S Case No. 1050/2022 Dated 12/08/2022, G.R. 3450/22 Charges have not been framed	U/S 188 of I.P.C & 30 P. Act.	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE
		Ld J.M. 1st Court at Berhampore Berhampore– P.S Case No. 551/2022 Dated 25/04/2022, G.R. 1706/22 Charges have not been framed	U/S 188 of I.P.C & 30 P. Act.	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE
		A.C.J.M. at Kandi G.R. 701/2023 Charges have not been framed	U/S 158/186/188/336 of I.P.C, 353/332/ 447/ 354/506/34/18 Highways, Act and 34 P.Act.,	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE
		GRO Berhampore Berhampore– P.S Case No. 47/2022 Dated 06/01/2022, G.R. 109/22 Charges have not been framed	U/S - 186/188/189/ 332/353/506/34 of I.P.C & 54 (b) DM Act.	NOT APPLICABLE	NOT APPLICABLE

*In the case of election to Council of States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party


Shashi Agnihotri
State General Secretary
BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY (BJP)
WEST BENGAL

NANDIGRAM BYPOLL

Cong candidate moves HC, seeks protection from arrest in 5 cases



Congress workers staged a protest in Kolkata a day after the party's Nandigram bypoll candidate was arrested on September 18. FILE

HC extends relief to Mamata camp account freeze till Jan

Press Trust of India
Kolkata, September 21

THE CALCUTTA High Court on Monday extended its order allowing the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the TMC to make daily expenses from three bank accounts till January next year, noting that the EC is yet to decide which of the two factions will hold the party symbol.

The Calcutta High Court had appointed a special officer on July 9 to manage the day-to-day expenses of the Mamata Banerjee camp from three bank accounts of the party, which had been debit-frozen by the police.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya extended the order dated July 9 till January 29 next year, and the matter will be heard again on December 14, 2026. The court directed that in the meantime, if the Election Commission passes an order relating to the recognition of the two TMC factions, the parties in the matter will be at liberty to move the court for vacation or variation of this court's order.

The court said that the EC passed an interim order on September 17 only to address issues related to the ensuing assembly bypolls in two seats -- Nandigram and Rejinagar.

The court noted that the EC's September 17 order will be effective till final determination of the dispute between the two factions in accordance with the provisions of the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968.

Justice Bhattacharyya observed that the order was for the purpose of the ensuing by-elections to Rejinagar and Nandigram seats, to be held on October 6 and "The same is in the nature of interim directions, pending substantive determination by ECI." The court held that the main issue of which faction will hold the party symbol is yet to be decided by the ECI.

Pradhan sent to judicial custody till October 5 in a 2007 case

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, September 21

THE CALCUTTA High Court will on Tuesday hear a plea by Congress' Nandigram Assembly bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan seeking protection from coercive action in five cases filed against him.

On Monday, the legal counsel of Pradhan mentioned the matter before the single bench of Justice Saugata Bhattacharya for an urgent hearing. Pradhan, who is already in jail after his arrest in connection with three other old cases, has sought protection from coercive action in the five new cases and the disclosure of further arrest warrants against him.

According to Pradhan's counsel, the Congress candidate was arrested on September 18, and later remanded to judicial custody till October 3 by a Haldia court in three cases

dating back to the Nandigram land agitation of 2007. The Khejuri police on Saturday submitted another arrest warrant against him in a fourth case, and Nandigram police on Sunday filed another warrant in a fifth case.

His counsel contended that the bypoll in Nandigram is scheduled for October 6, with the last date of campaigning set for October 4. This would effectively end the Congress candidate's opportunity to canvass before the bypoll to the Assembly seat vacated by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

Hearing the submissions, the court allowed the matter to be filed, and the hearing is slated for Tuesday.

Meanwhile, later on Monday, the Contai court in Purba Medinipur district remanded Pradhan to 14-day judicial custody, till October 5, in connection with the case registered at

the Khejuri Police Station in 2007. His counsel Ayan Bhattacharjee told PTI he would also challenge this decision in the High Court.

Pradhan was arrested hours after former chief minister Mamata Banerjee on September 18 announced her TMC faction's support to the Congress candidate in the Nandigram bypoll, after their own candidate withdrew from the race.

The West Bengal Police had earlier said that Pradhan was arrested based on four pending arrest warrants for his alleged involvement in non-bailable cases related to murder, attempt to murder, abduction with intent to murder, causing disappearance of evidence, house trespass, and rioting with arms and deadly weapons, all of which were filed during the 2007 anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram.

—WITH PTI INPUTS

ISF moves HC over 'envelope' symbol to TMC Ritabrata camp

Press Trust of India
Kolkata, September 21

AGGRIEVED WITH the EC's move to change its electoral symbol for the upcoming bypolls, the Indian Secular Front (ISF) moved the Calcutta High Court on Monday challenging the poll body's decision to allot the party's symbol to the Ritabrata Banerjee-led dissident TMC faction, now called the Democratic Trinamool Congress, sources said.

The court is likely to hear the case later this week.

The commission on Friday allotted the 'envelope' symbol, earlier used by the ISF, to the Ritabrata-led TMC camp, and replaced the Nausahad Siddiqui-led party's poll symbol with 'almirah'.

Ending its long-standing alliance with the CPI(M), the ISF has fielded Ali Md Sabe Miraj Khan as its candidate for the Nandigram bypoll scheduled on October 6. "We fought the 2026 Assembly elections with the 'envelope' symbol which we had registered with the EC... How can the EC unilaterally change our poll symbol without consulting us?" Siddiqui said.

'Both sides will have something to say': SC to hear TMC symbol case

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 21

THE SUPREME Court on Monday agreed to hear Mamata Banerjee's petition challenging the Election Commission of India's interim decision to freeze the name and 'Flowers & Grass' election symbol of the All India Trinamool Congress amid the factional feud within the party.

Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the petitioner, sought urgent listing of the matter. Sibal took exception to the Election Commission's decision and said it was taken after the bypolls in two Assembly constituencies — Nandigram and Rejinagar — were announced.

"Extraordinary things have happened. While the notification is on, despite the fact that the proceedings started in June, (and) we filed our reply in July, they don't do anything, and then they issue a notification, and in the middle of the notification, they freeze the symbol. What's going on? We just don't understand how," Sibal told the bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

Chief Justice of India Kant pointed out that the other side



Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction has been allotted 'football' symbol, while the rebel camp got 'envelope'. FILE

will also have submissions to make and asked Sibal to wait till the matter is listed for hearing.

"Both sides will have something to say. When the matter is listed, then argue. We will try to list," the Chief Justice said.

The Election Commission on September 18 ordered a freeze on the name and election symbol of Trinamool Congress and directed the two rival factions to select new names and symbols until the dispute is resolved.

"On due consideration of the totality of information available on record... the Commission is

of the opinion that there are two rival groups in the All India Trinamool Congress, one led by Ms Mamata Banerjee and the other

led by Shri Arup Roy, and each group is now claiming to be the party and therefore the matter requires a substantive determination by the Commission under Para 15 of the Election Symbols (Reservation & Allotment) Order 1968," the Election Commission order said.

The order said there wasn't enough time to resolve the dispute before the bypolls. "In order to place both the rival groups on even keel and to protect their rights and interests, and going by past precedence", neither group would be permitted to use the name All India Trinamool Congress and the party's "flowers and grass" symbol, it said. "Both the groups shall be known by such names as they may choose for their respective groups, including, if they so desire, linkage with their parent party 'All India Trinamool Congress'... both the groups shall also be allotted such different symbols as they may choose from the list of free symbols notified by the EC for the purposes of the current by-elections."

The Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction is now contesting the election on a footballer symbol, and the rebel camp, led by MLA Arup Roy, on an envelope symbol.

SFI, ABVP members clash at Bhangar College

Press Trust of India
Kolkata, September 21

SUPPORTERS OF the Left-backed SFI and RSS-affiliated ABVP clashed at Bhangar College in South 24 Parganas district on Monday after SFI activists protested the presence of BJP leader Sayantan Basu, who has been appointed as chairman of the college's governing body, on the premises.

As Basu's car approached the college's main gate, around 100 SFI and ISF student activists

blocked the vehicle and raised "go back" slogans, witnesses said.

Police had a tough time controlling the situation, and Basu stayed back in the college.

Soon after, a clash broke out between ABVP and SFI-ISF supporters.

SFI state committee member Subhajit Sarkar alleged that police under the BJP-led government were "brutally torturing" Left and democratic forces in Bengal while shielding the BJP and RSS camps at the

direction of Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

"They are thrusting BJP leaders on autonomous college governing bodies in Bengal. How come Sayantan Basu, who is neither an MLA nor an MP from the area, was picked as the governing body president?" the SFI leader asked.

However, ABVP state leader Shubhbarata Adhikari accused the SFI and ISF activists of assaulting "rashtravadi (nationalist) and patriotic" forces on the college campus and pursuing

their own agenda.

"ABVP students were assaulted today. We will not take this lying down," he said.

Talking to PTI, Basu said the SFI and ISF were trying to create lawlessness in academic institutions, citing the situation at Jadavpur University where, he alleged, ABVP members were being attacked.

"I did not back out and stayed on the Bhangar College campus. I want to develop the college constructively. The SFI and ISF cannot stop us," he said.

RSP withdraws candidate from Rejinagar bypoll

Kolkata: The Left Front constituency RSP on Monday withdrew its candidate from Rejinagar bypoll after the Election Commission allegedly denied it the use of its traditional 'spade and shovel' symbol.

Senior RSP leader Manoj Bandopadhyay said the party was informed after the scrutiny of nominations on Saturday that it could not use the symbol it had traditionally contested elections with and would instead have to

fight on the 'bucket' symbol. "What else is the way out? The EC has not given us our traditional symbol...," he said. The party withdrew its candidate Bikash Chandra Mishra over the move, he said. PTI

DELHI TRANSPORT CORPORATION
(GOVT of NCT OF DELHI)
I.P Estate New Delhi-110002

PUBLIC NOTICE
DTC EMPLOYEES SUPERANNUATION PENSION TRUST
It is hereby notified that Life Certificates of 226 Pensioners/Family Pensioners have not been received for more than three years. The concerned Pensioners/Family Pensioners/Legal Heirs/Nominees are hereby given a final opportunity to submit Life Certificate or relevant claim/death documents within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice to the Pension Cell, DTC.
In case of non-receipt of any response within the stipulated period, further action regarding the pension liability shall be taken as per applicable rules.

SNO.	NAME	DESIG	TNO	SNO.	NAME	DESIG	TNO
1	I.A. Khan	CSO	156	114	Smt Ram Wati	Driver	14409
2	Swatantar Chopra	PRM	195	115	Smt Shakuntala Devi	Driver	14664
3	Smt Jawala Devi	Forman	460	116	Darshan Singh	Driver	14758
4	Desh Raj	Forman	689	117	Smt Jasmeel Kaur	Driver	14997
5	Smt Shail Sharkar Mathur	Forman	875	118	Smt Krishna Devi	Driver	15030
6	Smt Ram Payari	SWEEPER	936	119	Gian Chand	Driver	15038
7	Baldev Raj	Forman	1081	120	Smt Savitri Sharma	Driver	15069
8	Smt. Santra Devi	A.FITTER	1392	121	Smt Parmali Devi	Driver	15088
9	Smt Daya Gulati	AE(M)	1432	122	Randhir Singh	Driver	15239
10	Bishan Singh Vats	MGR(M)	1457	123	Chhuttan Lal	COND.	16078
11	Smt Bimla Satija	AAO	1581	124	Ajay Pal Singh	ATI	16151
12	Smt Swaran Kanta	SR.PO	1681	125	Suninder Singh	ATI	16239
13	Smt Krishna Kumari	AAO	2023	126	Smt Sudesh	COND.	16561
14	Smt Mamta Chopra	SR.CLERK	2033	127	Smt Murti Devi	COND.	17016
15	Smt. Radha Devi	A.I	2148	128	Smt Prem Wati	COND.	17023
16	Smt Chameli Devi	TR.SUP	2430	129	Umed Singh	TR.SUP	17401
17	Balbir Chand Sharma	PHAR.	2515	130	Ram Chander	ATI	17493
18	Balwant Singh	AE	2548	131	Satya Narain	COND.	17816
19	Smt Santosh	S/CLERK	2573	132	Smt Shanti Devi	COND.	17825
20	Smt Chandrawati	SWEEPER	2667	133	Smt Sudesh	ATI	18017
21	Jagdish Raj	Foreman	2710	134	Smt Kamlesh	COND.	18121
22	Smt Vidya Wati	TR.SUP	2819	135	Joginder Singh	ATI	18275
23	Smt. Yashoda Rani	TR.SUP	2905	136	Ishwar Singh	ATI	18666
24	Smt Daropri Devi	TR.SUP	2930	137	Smt.Harbhajan Kaur	COND.	19093
25	Braham Singh	TI	3323	138	Smt Krishna Devi	TI	19190
26	Om Parkash	ATS	3428	139	Ram Kishan	COND.	19776
27	Smt Krishna Devi	TR.SUP	3440	140	Smt Savitri	ATI	20102
28	Smt. Sheela Rani	TR.SUP	3507	141	Smt Basanti Devi	COND.	20195
29	Smt Sukh Devi	TR.SUP	3633	142	Smt Phul Wati	COND.	20386
30	Kunti Nandan Sharma	AE	4047	143	Jagminder Singh	ATI	20467
31	Smt Kela Devi	SK	4054	144	Smt Premo Devi	COND.	20700
32	Smt Gaimda Devi	AE	4161	145	Kumari Kirti	COND.	20735
33	Krishan Lal	A.Forman	4222	146	Shiv Raj Singh	COND.	20980
34	Smt Razia Begam	ELECT	4228	147	Jai Bhagwan	ATI	21325
35	Smt Surjeet Kaur	MECH	4238	148	Sh Daya Nand Sharma	ATI	21334
36	Smt Roop Wati	FITTER	4330	149	Ram Bharat Singh	TTC	21380
37	Rajinder Singh	ELECT	4413	150	Sukhbir Singh	TI	21562
38	Smt Jyoti Sen	A/B/FITT	4641	151	Smt Satto	TI	21682
39	Smt Khilya Devi	FITT	4720	152	Kishan Singh	COND.	21724
40	Sahib Singh	A.Forman	4754	153	Smt Asha Devi	COND.	21944
41	Suresh Kumar	ELECT-II	5356	154	Khacheru Singh	TI	22177
42	Smt Sharda Devi	S/CLEANER	5366	155	Ahmed Ali	ATI	22652
43	Smt Onkar Rani	A/Forman	5626	156	Sukhbir Singh	COND.	22764
44	Smt Shanti Devi	MECH	5801	157	Smt Sunita Kumari	TI	22934
45	Rattan Singh	A/Forman	5822	158	Krishan Lal	TTC	22948
46	Smt. Veera Wati	FIT	5835	159	Smt Sita Devi	COND.	23044
47	Smt Sheetal Kaur	B/FITTER	5908	160	Smt Om Wati	SR CLERK	23281
48	Jagdish Chander	S,CLEANER	5947	161	Jamuna Dass	COND.	23335
49	Smt Laxmi Devi	B/SMITH	6015	162	Ram Kumar	COND.	23446
50	Smt Kailasho Devi	FITT	6417	163	Satya Narain	COND.	23708
51	Vasdev Tripathi	MECH	6678	164	Smt Ranjeet Kaur	A.E	24054
52	Smt Prem Pyari	A/Forman	7028	165	Megh Singh	Driver	25050
53	Hari Dutt	B/FITTER	7064	166	Smt Urmila	Driver	25097
54	Balbir Singh	VUL	7073	167	Smt. Kiran Bala	COND.	27024
55	Smt Barli Devi	A/Forman	7221	168	Lala Ram	SR/CLERK	27355
56	Smt Gulab Rani	MECH	7270	169	Smt Shakuntla	COND.	27634
57	Smt Madhu Bali	A.FITT	7319	170	Rajbir Singh	Driver	28337
58	Smt Maya	VUL	7991	171	Smt Laxmi Devi	Driver	28802
59	Surjit Singh	A.Forman	8482	172	Krishan	Driver	29006
60	Smt Asha Devi	MECH	8774	173	Raj Kumar	Driver	29035
61	Ram Parkash	S/CLEANER	8884	174	Smt Indra Wati	Driver	29136
62	Smt Mariyam	B/SMITH	9230	175	Smt. Rajwanti	S/HAV.	29242
63	Smt Jaldhari Devi	HELPER	9243	176	Smt Kamlesh Devi	Driver	29354
64	Atraj	MECH	9303	177	Raj Singh	S/CLEANER	29468
65	Smt. Kaushalaya Devi	S.FITT	9476	178	Balwant Singh	Driver	29485
66	Smt Lachham Kanwar	Driver	9817	179	Sohan Pal Singh	Driver	29656
67	Het Singh	Driver	9838	180	Smt Maya Devi	MO	30954
68	Smt Amarjeet Kaur	Driver.	9865	181	Vishwa Nath Kushwaha	FITTER	31507
69	Smt Usha Sharma	Driver	10025	182	Mohinder Singh	Driver	31636
70	Smt Maheshwari	Driver	10046	183	Rajender Singh	SI/ATTN	31786
71	Hari Chand	Driver	10284	184	Ramesh Chander	Driver	31992
72	Smt Mohender Kaur	Driver	10380	185	Smt Krishna Kumari	COND.	32005
73	Janardhan Singh	Driver	10432	186	Smt Parkashi	ATI	32518
74	Gidowari	Driver	10847	187	Shri Ram	A/FITT	33099
75	Balbir Singh	Driver	10849	188	Smt Bala Devi	COND.	34072
76	Duli Chand	Driver	10874	189	Smt. Geeta Devi	A/FITTER	35009
77	Kartar Singh	Driver	10887	190	Nafe Singh	ATI	35344
78	Dalel Singh	Driver	10907	191	Smt Dhan Kaur	Driver	36689
79	Smt Surjeet Kaur	Driver	11186	192	Smt Raj Bala	Driver	38347
80	Dharam Singh	V/EXAM	11194	193	Ram Phai	Driver	38383
81	Iqbal Singh	Driver	11211	194	Mohinder Singh	T.MAN	38771
82	Bhagwan Singh	Driver	11297	195	Dalbir Singh	COND.	39521
83	Ram Nath	A.T.I	11337	196	Mangu Ram	Driver	40364
84	Smt Santra Devi	Driver	11510	197	Yash Pal	S/CLEANER	40512
85	Smt Chandro Devi	Driver	11702	198	Gulab Chand	A/FITTER	42664
86	Charanjil Lal	Driver	11703	199	Tej Ram	Driver	42825
87	Ramji Lal	Driver	11846	200	Ram Punit Rai	Driver	42891
88	Smt Shanti Devi	Driver	12246	201	Jagbir Singh	Driver	43992
89	Smt Saroj	Driver	12301	202	Smt Raj Devi	S/CLEANER	44206
90	Smt Krishna Devi	Driver	12323	203	Smt Shashi Devi	MICHINIST	44911
91	Baldev Singh	Driver	12427	204	Amrik Singh	Driver	45177
92	Smt Yashoda Bai	V/EXAMNER	12481	205	Uttam Lal	Driver	46618
93	Ram Kishan	Driver	12529	206	Smt Birmati	Driver	47316
94	Smt Puspaa	V/EXAM	12531	207	Ashok Kumar	Driver	48720
95	Smt Prem Devi	Driver	12726	208	Dharam Pal Singh	Driver	48791
96	Smt Munni Devi	Driver	12788	209	Smt Raj Kumari	COND.	49202
97	Daya Chand	Driver	12800	210	Smt Raj Rani	COND.	50402
98	Smt Birma Devi	ATI	13020	211	Mahabir Singh	Driver	50489
99	Smt Bimla Devi	Driver	13100	212	Rajender Singh	Driver	50790
100	Smt Reshma Devi	V/EXAM	13113	213	Pat Ram	COND.	51904
101	Smt Sahbow	ATI	13323	214	Smt Kausal	S/CLEANER	52371
102	Suraj Parkash	Driver	13384	215	Smt Prem Wati	Driver	53644
103	Saroop Singh	Driver	13462	216	Balram	Driver	53828
104	Smt Parwati	Driver	13566	217	Onkar Singh	TR.SUP	54430
105	Smt Shakuntala	Driver	13844	218	Ranjeet Singh	Driver	55260
106	Jai Bhagwan	Driver	13854	219	Smt Seema	Driver	55340
107	Dharamvir	Driver	13960	220	Aziz Khan	Driver	55558
108	Sujan Singh	Driver	13975	221	Smt Santosh	Driver	55723



Uttar Pradesh

Healthy Teachers, Stronger Education System

Under the visionary leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Uttar Pradesh's education reforms have evolved beyond the modernization of schools to encompass the holistic well-being of teachers. Through the Chief Minister Teacher Cashless Medical Facility Scheme, nearly 19 lakh+ teachers and education personnel will receive comprehensive health coverage. The state will invest ₹3,000 annually per beneficiary, amounting to an estimated ₹447 crore every year. With access to nearly 1,900 cashless treatment packages, the initiative underscores the government's commitment to ensuring that healthy, secure, and worry-free teachers form the strongest foundation of a robust education system and a brighter future for the state.



19 Lakh+ Beneficiaries, One Commitment to Better Health

- Around 9,17,000 teachers and personnel of the Basic Education Department will be covered under the scheme.
- Nearly 298,000 teachers & staff of the Secondary Education Department will also benefit.
- 7.5 Lakh+ Higher Education Teachers & Their Dependants to benefit from the scheme
- The scheme extends coverage to Shiksha Mitras, instructors, special educators, teachers of Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas, and personnel of aided schools and vocational institutions, ensuring comprehensive health security across the education sector.

Ensuring Health, Honouring Educators

- Nearly 19 lakh+ teachers, Shiksha Mitras, instructors, special educators, cooks, and education department personnel will benefit from the scheme.
- The State Government will bear an annual premium of ₹3,000 per beneficiary.
- An estimated ₹447 crore will be spent on the scheme every year.
- Beneficiaries will have access to cashless treatment under more than 1,900 medical packages at empanelled government and private hospitals.
- Coverage includes treatment for critical illnesses such as cardiac diseases, cancer, kidney disorders, and neurosurgery.
- A landmark initiative that integrates teacher health security with comprehensive education reforms, reinforcing the foundation of a stronger education system.

1,900+ Cashless Treatment Packages for Better Health Security

- Cashless treatment available at empanelled government and private hospitals.
- Access to more than 1,900 treatment packages under the scheme.
- Comprehensive coverage for critical illnesses, including cardiac ailments, cancer, kidney diseases and neurosurgical procedures.
- Eliminates the need for out-of-pocket cash payments at the time of hospitalization, ensuring hassle-free access to quality healthcare.



Cashless
Healthcare for
State Employees
& Pensioners

83

Operational
Medical Colleges

450+

Pharmacy Colleges

75

Districts Free
Dialysis Services

₹5

Lakh Free
Health Insurance

9.5

Crоре+ Beneficiaries
Targeted under
PM-JAY

AIIMS

Operational in
Gorakhpur &
Raebareli

Health, Life & Social Security A New Shield for Teachers

- **Comprehensive Health Security for Educators:** The Mukhyamantri Shikshak Cashless Chikitsa Yojana provides cashless treatment to teachers, non-teaching staff and their dependants, without the burden of upfront payments.
- **₹5 Lakh Annual Cashless Health Cover:** Higher education teachers and their families can avail cashless treatment up to ₹5 lakh per family per year, including critical and complex medical procedures.
- **Hassle-Free Treatment from Admission to Discharge:** The scheme covers hospitalisation, medicines and treatment through discharge, reducing financial stress during medical emergencies.
- **Strong Life & Financial Protection:** The social-security package includes personal accident cover up to ₹1.5 crore, air-accident cover up to ₹3 crore, hospital cash benefits up to ₹60,000 and term-life insurance up to ₹12 lakh, providing greater financial security to employees and their families.

Supporting Teachers, Shaping the Future of Education

Comprehensive Accident & Family Security for Basic & Secondary Education Staff One Cover. Multiple Safeguards. A Stronger Future for Every Family.

- For eligible teachers & personnel earning ₹10,000+ per month
- ₹1 Crore Personal Accident Cover
- ₹1 Crore Permanent Disability Cover ₹1.6 Crore Air Accident Cover
- ₹10 Lakh Group Term Insurance



The Cashless Medical Facility Scheme has relieved teachers of one of their biggest concerns-access to quality healthcare. I sincerely thank Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath for prioritizing the welfare of teachers and transforming this vision into reality.

- Narendra Kumar Maurya

Assistant Teacher, Primary School, Jalhupur, Varanasi



Spiritual Connect

AFTER FINDING favour with a slew of political leaders, including Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and several state chief ministers, the cast and crew of Hindi film Hanuman Ansh, based on the life of spiritual guru Neem Karoli baba, got an audience with Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday, who congratulated them on the film's success. The makers, who also met BJP president Nitin Nabin a day earlier, are said to have spoken about their plans to make a film on the life of poet-saint Tulsidas.

Fresh Start

POLITICAL PARTIES and their leaders may still be speculating about the possibility of the government bringing the delimitation Bills — the Monsoon session of Parliament is yet to be prorogued despite being adjourned on August 13 — but it's business as usual for the Central Public Works Department (CPWD), which has begun sprucing up the premises of the Parliament House. The CPWD usually undertakes any renovation or repair works in the Parliament complex in between sessions. It started work on putting up signage inside the corridors, repairing internal roads and other small improvements this month, it is learnt.

PM, Jaishankar condole death of the brother of Dubai ruler

New Delhi: PM Narendra Modi on Monday condoled the death of Sheikh Ahmed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, the brother of the Dubai ruler, and said his efforts to serve society will be cherished by generations to come. Sheikh Ahmed bin Rashid Al Maktoum was the younger brother of Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice President and PM of the UAE and ruler of Dubai. "Deeply saddened by the passing of His Highness Sheikh Ahmed bin Rashid Al Maktoum. His efforts to serve society will be cherished by generations to come. I convey heartfelt condolences to the Royal Family and the people of Dubai," Modi said on X. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on X, "Deeply grieved at the passing of His Highness Sheikh Ahmed bin Rashid Al Maktoum." PTI

LEADERS SAY PARTY DOES NOT WANT TO BE BRANDED AS 'MUSLIM-YADAV'; UNCERTAINTY OVER ALLIANCE WITH CONGRESS ALSO KEY FACTOR

Samajwadi Party sees UP opening; then what is holding Akhilesh Yadav back?

CAPITAL CONTEXT

BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

WITH THE Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections months away, the SP senses an opening. Anti-incumbency, Gen Z's growing restlessness, a persistent jobs crisis and shifting caste equations have, in the party's assessment, created conditions favourable for it to build on its breakthrough in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. Yet, despite its confidence, the SP has so far refrained from launching an all-out offensive against the Yogi Adityanath government. The hesitation stems partly from an old electoral vulnerability: the perception of it as a "Muslim-Yadav" party. While seeking to retain its traditional support base, SP is attempting to

'THEFT' AT RAM TEMPLE: CHARGESHEET ON OR BEFORE SEPT 26, SOLICITOR GENERAL INFORMS TOP COURT

No discrepancies in silver bricks donation handling: SIT report in SC

105 instances of unauthorised currency removal caught on CCTV cameras: Report

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 21

THE SIT, probing into alleged donation theft at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, found "no discrepancies" in the handling of the "200 kg of silver bricks, 38,288 kg of silver bricks, a silver necklace, Charan Paduka, and a donation related to the Ram-charitmanas" received as donation by the temple administration, according to the Supreme Court order on Monday. In a status report, dated September 16, 2026, the SIT, headed by UP IGP Kiran S, said it had "duly verified" the "particular allegations regarding valuable donations reported in the media and on social media" about these donations, it said. "The involved individuals have been interviewed, and the pertinent materials have been examined by them. No discrepancies were

identified during this verification process," it said, according to the order. The contents of the report were perused by a three-judge SC bench, presided by CJI Surya Kant, and comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana. According to the order, "the report discloses that the receipts generated by the TCS software for 803 valuable articles have been verified, and their relevant records have been found to be with the Trust. These articles are stored in a State Bank of India locker, which was physically checked. In so far as these 803 articles are concerned, no discrepancies were found during the verification." It added that "there are 86 valuable articles in respect of which receipts have not been issued. These articles have been separately identified and physically verified."



Air Marshal (retd) Jeetendra Mishra (left) takes charge as the CEO of Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust in Ayodhya, Monday. ANI

The report also said that "records relating to approximately 944,411 kg of white metal (supposed to be silver) have been sent by the (Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra) Trust to Security Printing and Minting Corporation of India Limited for melting. The report pertaining to the said white metal has also been examined, and the relevant records scrutinised". Solicitor General Tushar

Mehta, appearing for Uttar Pradesh, submitted before the bench that the "SIT is inclined to file the chargesheet on or before 25.09.2026, i.e., before completion of 90 days from the date of the first arrest." "Ninety days are going to be over on September 25. So we will have to file a chargesheet. Otherwise they will get bail," Mehta informed the bench. The SIT report pointed out that CCTV footage from the counting room situated in the

Pilgrim Facility Centre (PFC) building at the temple and other digital data "has revealed 105 instances of unauthorised currency removal or concealment from the counting room, involving assistance from other individuals participating in the counting process". Eight accused have been identified, it said. "The status report further emphasises the estimated amount misappropriated by each accused individual, also noting that existing evidence suggests the suspected misappropriation of currency took place within the counting room during the process of counting and handling the currency," the SC order said. The report said that a forensic auditor was included following SC's direction. The status report pointed out that "the statements of 173 witnesses have been recorded as of 14.09.2026", including trust functionaries, accounting personnel, banking officials, security personnel and Chartered Accountants.

BJP'S SHAKTI KENDRA SAMMELAN IN MEERUT

Yogi, Nabin target SP, Congress: 'Insulted Ambedkar, Dalit icons'

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, September 21

THE BJP on Monday accused the Opposition Samajwadi Party and Congress of insulting Dr BR Ambedkar and trying to divide great personalities on the basis of caste, a day after SP president Akhilesh Yadav claimed that 151 statues of Ambedkar were damaged in Uttar Pradesh since the BJP came to power in 2017. Addressing BJP's Shakti Kendra Sammelan of western UP in Meerut along with the party's national president, Nitin Nabin, UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said, "They (Opposition SP and Congress) will again divide the society in the name of caste. They will commit the sin of dividing great personalities on caste basis... A mahapurush belongs to all, and is not limited to a particular caste. By confining him to a particular caste, they undermine the significance of that mahapurush." Accusing the previous SP government of changing the name of a medical college named after Ambedkar and not allowing events at Ravidas's birthplace, Seer Govardhan, Adityanath said that the "double-engine government" of BJP has allocated funds for installing statues of BR Ambedkar, Sadguru Ravidas and Maharishi Valmiki, and developing the places as well as temples related to them. He also accused the Samajwadi Party of creating hurdles in religious events. "The SP gets as irritated at the mere mention of the name of Lord



Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath with BJP president Nitin Nabin (left) in Meerut on Monday. PTI

Ram. They hate Lord Ram just as Babur did... Now, you have to decide because only the devotees of 'Bajrang' (Lord Hanuman) can give a befitting reply to Babur's followers," the chief minister told the gathering. In his address, BJP president Nitin Nabin alleged that the Congress and SP were speaking about Dalits and backward classes for votes. Accusing the Congress of not respecting Ambedkar and former prime minister Chaudhary Charan Singh, he said the BJP had honoured the two leaders. "While the Congress used to celebrate only the birthdays of members of its own family, the BJP government is grandly celebrating the 650th birth anniversary of Sant Ravidas Ji from Varanasi in UP... The Congress never gave respect to Chaudhary Charan Singh and even worked to bring down his

government," Nabin claimed, and added that Chaudhary Charan Singh was honoured with the Bharat Ratna by the Narendra Modi government. Notably, Jats are a leading farming community in west UP, and Chaudhary Charan Singh is a towering leader among Jats. Accusing the Congress and SP of adopting the British policy of "divide and rule", he said that the BJP would not allow it to be implemented again in UP "under any circumstances". Asserting that the BJP will form government in UP again in 2027, for the third consecutive time, the BJP chief asked the shakti-kendra in-charge to ensure the party's win in all the polling booths of all the 71 Assembly constituencies of western UP. Targeting Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and his ongoing students' out-

reach programme, Nabin said that Gandhi should explain whether he has ever interacted with the youth of Amethi or, after listening to their concerns, provided them with employment. Nabin also addressed a Yuva Samvad programme in Meerut where he called upon the youth to contribute to nation-building by associating themselves with the vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047 as envisaged by PM Narendra Modi. "Live real, not reels, and put the nation first," he said, urging youngsters to channel their energy positively and move ahead with hard work, discipline and consistency. He suggested that a 'Border Darshan' programme should be launched in Uttar Pradesh to instil a deep sense of patriotism and dedication among the youths.

Minister: UP to be divided into four parts, Purvanchal to get Rajbhar CM

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, September 21

UTTAR PRADESH Minister and Suheldev Bhartiya Samaj Party chief Om Prakash Rajbhar has claimed that the state will be divided into four parts soon, and that the Purvanchal region will get a "Rajbhar chief minister". Addressing a public meeting in Ambedkarnagar district on Sunday, Rajbhar referred to his "conversation" with Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "Aane wale dinon mein Pradesh ka chaar bhagon mein batwara hoga. Jis din Purvanchal raj aag hoga, sabse pehle Mukhyamantri koi hoga to Rajbhar ka beta Mukhyamantri Purvanchal ka hoga (In the coming days, the state is going to be divided into four parts. The day a separate Purvanchal state is created, the first Chief Minister will be a son of the Rajbhar community)," he said. He also named the four proposed regions: "Jab Pradesh ka batwara hoga to Purvanchal, Madhyanchal, Bundelkhand, Harit Pradesh. Purvanchal mein sabse jada vote Rajbhar jai hai. Is nate, Purvanchal ka pehla CM Rajbhar hoga (When the state is divided, there will be Purvanchal, Madhyanchal, Bundelkhand and Harit Pradesh. The Rajbhar community has the largest vote base in Purvanchal. Therefore, Purvanchal's first Chief Minister will be a Rajbhar)". Rajbhar's claims, before the 2027 Assembly elections, has revived demands for the division of the state that's been raised several times in the past.

MAHARASHTRA

UCC panel member resigns over differences in seeking feedback

Says panel was to finalise questionnaire, but chairperson already circulated it

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, September 21

TWO DAYS after Maharashtra's Uniform Civil Code (UCC) committee held its second meeting, retired Bombay High Court Judge Justice R C Chavan has resigned from the panel. In his email to the committee, he has cited differences over the process of seeking public feedback and questioned the alleged presence and role of a non-member at the meeting.

The seven-member committee, headed by retired Supreme Court Judge Justice Ranjana Desai, was set up in July to draft rules and recommendations for implementing UCC in the state. The committee has been given six months to submit its report. Justice Chavan sent his resignation on September 19, hours after the committee held an online meeting. The state government accepted it on Monday. Phone calls and messages to Justice Desai seeking her comment did not elicit any response. Justice Desai also headed the UCC panels in Uttarakhand, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat. In his email, Justice Chavan has written that one of the agendas of the meeting was to finalise the questionnaire for public feedback on the UCC. However, he wrote, a questionnaire which was finalised by Justice Desai was circulated, and the committee was told that it would be uploaded once the website was ready. "Three members tried to articulate their views, such as respondents being required to answer only in yes or no, or the need to have the questionnaire quickly examined professionally by professors under the supervision of member Dr Suvarna Rawal. Honourable chairperson had already circulated the questionnaire finalised by her and stated that it would be uploaded once the website was ready. Thus, the third and the last item on agenda of today's meeting was over. Therefore, to save time and internet, I logged out," he wrote. "My attempt to put forth my views, even though the questionnaire finalised by the honourable chairperson had already been mailed, was due to my misunderstanding that our exercise was aimed at gathering the views of the people of Maharashtra, and to generate a consensus to remedy the issues of late marriages, perversions, infertility, unstable marriage, time-consuming dispute resolution mechanism, etc. "Now that it is removed, I realise that the aim is to just



Non-member part of meeting, Justice (retd) R C Chavan wrote

provide an opportunity to people who may care, to share their responses in a yes or no to the questions posed so that analysis of data becomes easy," he wrote. The email also alleged that a person who was not a member of the committee attended the meeting. The non-member said the website prepared by the state officials needed further modifications, and the committee chairperson directed the authorities to make the necessary changes within a week, Justice Chavan wrote. He wrote that he did not know where the person fit in, and added that the non-member's suggestion made him speculate that the state's officials may feel they are not competent. "To solve this problem, I am vacating my seat on the committee by resigning now, so that the government can fill in the blank promptly," he wrote, adding that as a free citizen, he would be free to air his views. "It was a great learning experience on a subject close to my heart," he wrote. The meeting's three-point agenda included confirming the minutes of the previous meeting held last month, and discussion on the website for feedback and opinion on the UCC. The other members of the committee are: retired Bombay HC Judge Justice S G Mehare, former Maharashtra Chief Secretary D K Jain, former Advocate General Birendra Saraf, social activist and Padma Shri awardee Ramesh Patange, and education expert Suvarna Rawal. Earlier this month, Union Home Minister Amit Shah had said in Mumbai that the UCC would be implemented in all NDA-ruled states before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said the state committee was preparing its draft and the implementation process would begin after the report was submitted. He said the government was aiming to table the UCC Bill in the Assembly during the Winter Session in December.



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at party office in Lucknow on Sunday. ANI FILE

claimed, BJP would seek to use for polarisation. SP's plans The SP, however, is attempting to address precisely that vulnerability by expanding its social coalition. A key focus is the Dalit vote, a constituency being sought by the BJP, SP and Congress as the influence of BSP leader Mayawati has declined. Akhilesh has stepped up efforts to expand the party's presence among Dalits across the state as part of an effort to broaden his Pichhda, Dalit, Alp-sankhyak (PDA) social engineering formula. The party's outreach has also acquired a visible symbolic dimension. BJP leaders have pointed to the addition of the colour blue, traditionally associated with BR Ambedkar and the Dalit movement, to the SP's traditional red-and-green palette. The uniform of the Sa-

maajwadi Chhatra Sabha (SCS), the party's student wing, includes blue T-shirts and jeans. Akhilesh was also recently seen wearing a blue scarf, instead of the party's traditional red one, at a meeting of district and city presidents. In November, senior SP leader and Rajya Sabha MP Ramji Lal Suman is expected to lead a Dalit conference in Agra, a district with a sizeable SC population and a significant Jatav presence. Akhilesh is likely to be the chief guest. Training workers The SP chief is also planning a two-day training programme for party workers in Gorakhpur, an important centre in eastern UP, where Nishads and Brahmins have a significant presence. Both communities are being closely watched by political parties amid claims of their discontent with the BJP. Jatavs account for more than

half of the SC population in UP, while SC constitute over a fifth of the state's population. "Akhilesh wants to penetrate the SC vote base and fortunately for him, there is a section in the SCs, particularly government employees, including bureaucrats, who can be influential. This is a strategy Kanshi Ram had used," said a BJP leader from UP. Kanshi Ram had built an organisational network among government employees through BAMCEF — the All India Backward and Minority Communities Employees' Federation — before launching the BSP. The SP chief is also planning a two-day training programme for party workers in Gorakhpur, an important centre in eastern Uttar Pradesh, where Nishads and Brahmins have a significant presence. Both communities are being closely watched by political parties amid claims of their discontent with the BJP. The SP's broader strategy is

to consolidate its PDA base while seeking to tap into discontent among sections of communities that have traditionally supported the BJP. BJP leaders themselves acknowledge the need to retain support among communities such as the Passis, Kurmis, Sakyas and Mauryas. "Akhilesh is trying to strengthen his PDA formula that helped him get 37 seats in 2024 Lok Sabha polls. He wants to cash in on the growing anger against the dominating caste, that is, Thakurs now, under Adityanath, to bring together a new social coalition," the BJP leader said. For BJP, the challenge is compounded by an internal debate over the political risks of what some party leaders describe as a "hardcore Hindutva" line associated with Adityanath. Some in the party fear that an emphasis on this approach could have adverse political consequences as BJP seeks a third consecutive term.

PROF DOOLLA REMOVED FROM DEAN'S POST AFTER PROTEST OVER STUDENT SUICIDE

IIT Madras, Delhi and Bombay faculty lend support to ex-Dean

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 21

HOURS AFTER he was removed as the Dean (Administrative Affairs) of IIT Bombay over the student suicide row, the faculty forum of the institute, as well as that of IIT Delhi and Madras, have come in support of Professor Suryanarayana Doolla.

IIT Bombay professors on Monday took out a protest march on the campus, holding placards and posters expressing solidarity with their colleague. In a statement, the faculty forum said it was “distressed by the vilification of our colleague’s reputation by false and misleading reports that have appeared in the media” and “stands strongly” with Professor Doolla.

“We also reiterate that we are pained by the sad demise of our student due to the unfortunate incident on September 18,” it said. The forum also highlighted that Professor Doolla “continues to be a faculty member in good standing,” indicating that he remains a professor at the institution. About 50 to 60 alumni of IIT Bombay have also extended their support to Professor Doolla.

Meanwhile, IIT Delhi faculty forum issued a statement ex-



Students light candles as they demand justice for Sahil Wakode, who died by suicide on IIT-Bombay campus, on Monday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

tending its support to Professor Doolla saying that the latter was “simply discharging his duties during an examination as per the institute’s guidelines”.

“There is an apprehension among faculty members regarding the conduct of evaluations and maintaining academic integrity due to the circumstances that prevailed at IIT-Bombay,” the statement read.

The IIT Delhi faculty forum also appealed to the student community, their families and others to extend support so that “the faculty can discharge their duties in maintaining the integrity and fairness of the entire IIT system”.

It also condemned the mob-driven behavior, which, it alleges, has affected the IITs’ decision-making on various events in the recent past.

The forum has called on IIT Bombay to extend all required institutional and personal support to Professor Doolla and his family. It has also committed its full support. IIT Madras, too, extended its support, saying, “The death of any student is a loss to the entire academic community... At a time of such grief, we believe it is important that the circumstances be examined fairly and through due process.”

“We note the statement of the IIT Bombay faculty forum

that Professor Doolla, as course instructor and invigilator, acted in accordance with the Senate-approved academic procedures of the institute. Faculty members across the IIT system are entrusted with upholding the integrity of examinations, and they must be able to discharge this responsibility in good faith, following established institutional procedure, without fear of personal vilification,” IIT Madras faculty forum said.

The faculty forum at IIT Madras has also requested that the inquiry into the incident also look into whether institutional procedures for handling academic malpractice give students enough support, counselling and safeguards at moments of acute stress, so that such situations are handled with both integrity and compassion.

“The IIT Madras Faculty Association stands in solidarity with [Professor Doolla], our colleague at IIT Bombay, and equally with the students and families of our institutions, whose wellbeing and trust are the foundation of everything we do,” it said in a statement.

Professor Doolla was the invigilator in the hall where students, including Sahil Wakode, were taking a test.

Schoolgirl molested, friend assaulted while returning from tuition in Bihar

3 held; Govt is sensitive to any ‘chutput ghatna’ that takes places: JDU state chief

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 21

HALF PAST six on Saturday evening, shortly after tuition, a teenage girl went out on a scooter ride with her friend in Bihar’s Jamui. The two teens, both in school, went to the hilly outskirts and clicked photos.

The area, police officers said, is slightly away from the town and around three kilometres from main road connecting Jamui and Lakhisarai. “The sunsets there are scenic,” the officer added. However, the picturesque outing soon gave way to a traumatic encounter when a group of seven or eight young men arrived, assaulted the boy and molested the girl.

The incident, videos of which are now viral, has prompted national outrage, again calling into question law and order in Bihar, even as police moved to contain the damage by apprehending three accused, who are believed to be minors.

Videos show the teens repeatedly apologising to the group, promising they would never return. Some members of the group start shouting and calling for the two to be married. One video shows a man

with his face covered grab hold of the girl, lift her up and run away, all the while touching her inappropriately. It was only when the teenage boy chased him down that the accused let her go.

Videos also show the boy telling them they study together and their families know of their friendship, only for an accused to slap him and say: “If they know, then call them.”

“Initially, the victim did not inform her family or anyone else about the incident,” ADG (Law and Order) K S Anupam said, explaining why it took two days for the police to take action. It was when videos went viral that the Jamui police took cognisance of the matter and began a probe.

The boy’s mother said, “I can’t comprehend how such a thing happened. We are completely blank. We came to know through Instagram; the children did not tell us out of fear.”

An officer posted at the Bihar police headquarters elaborated, “As soon as the matter came to the notice of the police, the Deputy Inspector General of Police, Munger Range, and the Superintendent of Police, Jamui, were directed to take

immediate action. A team from the Weak and Vulnerable Sections division of the Crime Investigation Department was also sent to Jamui to assist the probe.”

Jamui SP Vishwajeet Dayal told *The Indian Express* that initially, no complaint was received, but as the video started reaching the police, they contacted the victims and identified the accused. A woman ASI recorded the girl’s statement at her residence on Monday morning.

“The girl informed her family on night of September 20, and on September 21, the victim’s father submitted a written complaint at the police station. Jamui police have constituted a special SIT under the leadership of Sub-Divisional Police Officer, Jamui, Dipti Monali, and raids are being conducted,” the ADG said.

SDPO Monali confirmed to *The Indian Express* that an FIR has been registered under the PoCSO Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Police also said they have identified most of the youths involved in the incident.

“At the same time, action is being taken to have the viral videos taken down,” the ADG said, since circulating videos involving minors is an offence. Police are looking into whether a patrolling unit was supposed to be present at the time of incident.

As the incident sparked national outrage, JDU state president Umesh Kushwaha said the Bihar government is sensitive to any “isolated incident (*chutput ghatna*)” that takes place.

“Whenever such an isolated incident occurs, our government is sensitive to it. But look at the period before 2005; what kind of Bihar was it? Could people even step out of their homes? What kind of Bihar was it, and what was the situation? Whoever has committed this incident, no matter how big a criminal they may be, will soon be taken into custody,” he said.

Congress’s Rahul Gandhi called the video “deeply disturbing”. “Two students were stopped on a road. Harassed. Humiliated. Molested. A young girl, hands folded, begged to be let go while goons groped her and dragged her away,” he posted on X. “Who gave these men the right to behave like this?... When control is mistaken for culture, and such attitudes are normalised by *Anandbhakts*, mobs start believing they are the law,” his post read.

“Every individual in that video must be identified and prosecuted under POCSO... And Bihar government must answer why a girl is not safe on a public road at 7 pm?” he wrote.

HC orders probe into caste bias charges at NLU Prayagraj, forms panel

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, September 21

THE ALLAHABAD High Court has constituted a two-member committee of judicial officers to inquire into allegations of caste-based discrimination and humiliation made by a Dalit student against the Head of the Department of Law at Dr Rajendra Prasad National Law University, Prayagraj, and to examine how the university dealt with his complaint.

The court has also directed the university to constitute an independent committee to re-evaluate the student’s answer sheets and ordered that the HoD be relieved of all administrative responsibilities until the inquiries are completed.

The student, who is pursuing BA LLB (Hons), has approached the court alleging that the HoD and the warden of the boys’ hostel had used his academic and administrative authority for caste-based humiliation and retaliation.

He also alleged that the varsity administration had

shielded the Head of Department (HoD) by failing to act on his complaint.

The petitioner alleged that the remark was directed at him because the concerned faculty member was aware that he had topped the Constitutional Law I examination. He also claimed that his answer sheets were subjected to stricter evaluation because of his caste and alleged that the HoD had, on earlier occasions, made insulting remarks concerning caste and reservation

In its order dated September 16, a single bench of Justice Vinod Diwakar said the allegations were serious and required examination by an impartial agency. The court constituted a committee comprising Judge, Small Cause Court, District Court, Prayagraj, and Special Chief Judicial Magistrate, Prayagraj to conduct an inquiry and submit a report to the court before the next hearing on September 24.

Until further orders, the HoD has been relieved of all administrative responsibilities.

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After stir, Wardha varsity to restart Women, Film Studies

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, September 21

THE EXECUTIVE Council of Mahatma Gandhi Antarrashtriya Hindi Vishwavidyalaya (MGAHV) has decided to restart programmes under its

Women Studies and Film Studies departments at its Wardha headquarters from the 2027-28 academic session, four years after the courses were shifted to its regional centre in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh. The decision was taken at

the Executive Council meeting at the Wardha campus on Monday. On Sunday, The Indian Express reported on a three-month-long student protest over the shifting of the departments, the freezing of PhD admissions and the discontinu-

ation of several language programmes. The agitation had also led to an FIR against six students. The university, said the decision to bring the two departments back to Wardha was taken in the “larger interest of students”.

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56 BN BSF
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DG and all ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to 6 valiant troopers of 8 Bn CRPF, who made the supreme sacrifice after sustaining grievous injuries while countering an ambush by insurgents in Manipur, on 22 September 1970. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

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Nair has been arrested in a criminal defamation case

Journalist Ravi Nair stays in jail as Gujarat HC gives Adani firm time to respond

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, September 21

THE GUJARAT High Court on Monday allowed Adani Enterprises Ltd to file its response to journalist Ravi Nair’s plea challenging his arrest following the issuance of a non-bailable warrant in a criminal defamation case filed by the company.

On Saturday, Justice M K Thakker had issued a notice on Nair’s plea. On Monday, senior counsel appearing for Adani Enterprises sought time to place “certain legal and factual aspects” on record.

Nair’s counsel, Advocate Abhik Chimni, opposed the request and pressed for interim relief, arguing that the matter was already at the appellate stage and contended that his client should not have to “spend even a day in jail”. He also submitted that Adani Enterprises, being a private complainant, could not seek repeated adjournments.

The court allowed the complainant (Adani) an opportunity to respond. In its order dictated in open court, it said since the complainant was represented after the notice was issued, it had to be given a fair opportunity to place its case on record. The court, however, made it clear that it wouldn’t grant any further adjournment. Adani Enterprises filed a criminal defamation complaint alleging that Nair published and disseminated posts on X containing false and defamatory statements intended to damage the reputation of the company and the Adani Group.

Nair challenged a September 17 order of the sessions court rejecting his plea to cancel the non-bailable warrant and directing that he be sent to jail. He has also challenged a September 3 order in which the sessions court held that he was missing and deliberately avoiding arrest. He further sought restoration of a March 9 order under which the sessions court had suspended his sentence and released him on bail.

Bikes by train, travel by flights: Eleven-member robbery gang from UP reach Keralam, all held

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 21

IT WAS planned down to the last detail. First, a gang of 11 people from Uttar Pradesh’s Meerut would dispatch two-wheelers to Keralam by train. Then, they would fly down to Kochi and Kannur, and steal copper cables from buildings and abandoned BSNL cable terminal boxes.

It was going well, and the gang even allegedly bagged Rs 12,000 worth of loot. Then, police swept in and arrested all of them. On Monday, Kannur City Police Commissioner B V Vijaya Bharath Reddy said they had made the arrests after an alert from the Thrissur City Police.

“We have nabbed five of the gang, who had landed at Kannur airport from Delhi on September 19. They had already sent their bikes to Kannur on September 9. Our patrolling team on Sunday night spotted a five-member gang under suspicious circumstances and found they had concealed cable cutters on their bodies. Upon questioning them, we found the gang had reached Kannur with the intention of robbing,” the commissioner said, adding that the others were arrested for Thrissur.

The officer said that upon questioning the arrested gang, it was found that their target was to steal copper cables in abandoned BSNL cable terminals.

Sonia voter roll case: Court sets aside order dismissing FIR plea

Over her alleged inclusion in 1980 roll prior to getting Indian citizenship

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 21

A DELHI sessions court on Monday set aside a lower court’s order from September last year, which had dismissed a plea for an FIR in a case of alleged forgery related to Congress leader Sonia Gandhi’s purported inclusion in the electoral rolls in 1980, three years before she became an Indian citizen.

Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Dwarka Courts described the magistrate court’s order as “non speaking” (without providing

any reason) and lacking “appropriate reasoning”. He remanded the matter back to the magistrate court, directing that a fresh order be passed after hearing the parties and conducting an inquiry. A detailed order is awaited.

“This court is unable to fathom why the power of the ECI is a bar upon the police to act on fraudulent inclusion and submission of forged documents. The power of the police to probe a cognisable offence in inclusion of deletion of name from a voter list cannot be considered consequently ousted...,” Judge Gogne said.

“The order suffers from non-application of mind and is liable to be set aside. The magistrate had not discussed the implications of the documents presented by the petitioner,” he



Congress leader Sonia Gandhi

said, adding that the magistrate “simply branded the complaint as lacking essentials”.

Judge Gogne’s order came on a revision plea filed by senior

advocate Ajay Burman and advocate Himanshu Sethi against the magistrate court order.

The complainant in the original case, advocate Vikas Tripathi, who was represented by senior advocate Pavan Narang, had sought the registration of an FIR in the matter.

He had moved an application before the magistrate court under Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita Section 175(4). The section relates to the power of any magistrate, upon receiving a complaint against a public servant arising in the course of the discharge of his official duties, to order an investigation.

The magistrate court had noted that the authority to exclude or include someone in the electoral roll rested solely with the Election Commission of India, and had also said that

a civil or ordinary dispute was being projected as criminal.

“Mere bald assertions, unaccompanied by the essential particulars required to attract the statutory elements of cheating or forgery, cannot substitute a legally sustainable accusation as informant is merely relying only upon extract of electoral roll which is photocopy of photocopy of alleged extract of uncertified electoral roll of the year 1980,” it had said.

Narang had contended that documents clearly indicated that Gandhi took citizenship of the country in April 1983. “Her name got included in the electoral roll as a voter in the New Delhi constituency in 1980... which was then deleted in 1982. It re-entered in 1983 when the qualification date was January 1, 1983,” he had argued.

SETS ASIDE KARNATAKA HC ORDER

‘Shocks conscience’: SC orders fresh SIT probe in 2012 rape-murder case

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 21

NEARLY 14 years after the rape-murder of a 17-year-old girl in Karnataka’s Dakshina Kannada district, the Supreme Court on Monday ordered a fresh probe by an SIT, saying that the manner in which the earlier investigation was conducted “shocks” its “conscience”.

Allowing the appeal by the victim’s mother, a bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva set aside the August 30, 2024, Karnataka High Court judgment dismissing the family’s plea for a fresh probe. In 2023, the trial court had acquitted Santhosh Rao, named as accused by police, of rape and murder charges.

In a stinging indictment of the earlier probe, the SC ordered that “no officer who was part of the probe teams of the Belthangady police station, the CID or the CBI who had been associated with the earlier investigation shall be part of the SIT”. It directed the SIT to conclude the probe within three months and file its report before the court concerned.

Writing for the bench, Justice Sachdeva said, “In a case where a minor girl of 17 years of

age is brutally raped and murdered, the manner in which the investigation progressed and various investigating agencies conducted the investigation and gathered and evaluated the evidence shocks the very conscience of the court.”

“The person who was prosecuted was held to be incapable of committing the offence. Clearly, the investigation has been conducted in a manner that causes injustice to the victim. The possibility of the real culprit(s) manipulating the investigation cannot be ruled out. Such lax and improper investigation gives a premium to the Investigating Officers who failed to do their job correctly and diligently,” Justice Sachdeva said.

“Society would be failing in its duty if it does not provide justice to the victim of such a heinous crime...,” according to the judgment.

The victim had gone for her classes on October 9, 2012, but did not return home. The next day, her body was found in a bush near Mannasanka in Dhar-masthala. Two men caught the accused Rao on October 11 and handed him over to police. The family, however, suspected the role of three others, including one who had apprehended Rao.

EXPRESS special

Among first cheetahs at Kuno, Gaurav, the ‘Rockstar’, is gone

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 21

IN 2022, it came to Kuno National Park as part of the first batch of eight Namibian cheetahs brought to India under Project Cheetah. It was among the first to step into the Kuno landscape, make a kill, establish a territory, survive competition with other males and, eventually, father a new generation of cheetahs born in India.

On Monday, nearly four years after making the journey from the African nation to India, Gaurav, the cheetah, breathed its last at the wildlife sanctuary. It was a little over 10 years old.

Gaurav, originally named Elton, was among the eight cheetahs brought from Namibia to Kuno in September 2022. He arrived alongside Freddy, later renamed Shaurya. The two males eventually came to be known as the “Rockstars” of Kuno. Gaurav and Shaurya were released into the free-ranging area of Kuno on March 22, 2023. Within 48 hours, the two males made a successful kill — a landmark moment for Project Cheetah and, according to the Cheetah Conservation Fund, the first recorded cheetah hunt in India in over 70 years.

The pair, subsequently, es-



Originally called Elton, the Namibian cheetah became Gaurav after coming to Kuno in September 2022. CHEETAH CONSERVATION FUND

tablished a territory around their release area and emerged as one of the prominent male coalitions in Kuno. Their time in the wild wasn’t without challenges. Gaurav and Shaurya encountered another male coalition, Agni and Vayu, in what became one of the early tests of the newly introduced cheetahs as they competed for territory. Gaurav survived those encounters.

But in January 2024, Shaurya was found weak and staggering. It died during treatment, leaving Gaurav without its long-time coalition partner. At the time, forest officials said Gaurav would be closely monitored and that its subsequent management would depend on its health and other factors.

Gaurav’s significance to the

programme went beyond its survival in the wild. In April 2025, it fathered five cubs with Nirva, a female cheetah brought to India from South Africa. The litter was notable because it represented the first birth at Kuno involving a Namibian father and a South African mother, bringing together the two African lineages that had been used to establish India’s new cheetah population.

Gaurav was rescued from the wild on September 12 after being observed to be weak and dull. Despite treatment, Gaurav’s condition deteriorated and it died around 4 pm on Monday, the Field Director of the Project Cheetah said. The exact cause of death will be established after a post-mortem examination.

17-year-old Naga boy killed in Manipur ambush

Imphal: A 17-year-old Liangmai Naga boy was allegedly killed in an ambush by armed assailants in Manipur’s Tamenglong district on Monday, adding to a series of violent incidents involving Naga and Kuki communities in parts of Tamenglong, Kangpokpi and adjoining areas.

The incident reportedly occurred at around 10.05 am when the boy, identified as Nk Wiphenbou of Nkou Naga village, was attacked while he was walking alone from Upper Nkou to Malek village, near Tamei Sub-Division. Police retrieved the body and deposited the remains at Tamenglong mortuary. ENS

• BRIEFLY



Policemen and residents at the school, Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

UTTAR PRADESH

Man shoots teacher dead at school in Lakhimpur Kheri, dies by suicide

A MAN walked into a private school in Uttar Pradesh’s Lakhimpur Kheri on Monday and allegedly shot dead a teacher before killing himself. The incident occurred as around 100 students were leaving the school and several guardians were waiting outside. Nishat Fatima (26), had been working as a teacher at the school for the past year, while Saud Ansari (28) ran a furniture shop. The two were known to each other, police said, adding they suspect a failed romantic relationship as the motive behind the murder. “A forensic team is collecting evidence. We are speaking to families of the deceased,” said Lakhimpur Kheri SP Khyati Garg. Preliminary inquiry suggests Ansari entered the school along with guardians who had come to pick up their children. ENS

Man held with 9 kg hydroponic ganja at airport

A MUMBAI resident was arrested at the Ahmedabad airport on Monday by Customs officers after they seized 8.9 kg of hydroponic ganja from his luggage. The man was apprehended after alighting from a flight that had reached from Bangkok, Thailand. A statement by the Customs department read, “During examination of his check-in baggage... the total weight of the seized ganja (marijuana) was found to be 8.913 grams (approximately 8.9 kg).” The passenger has been placed under arrest, and further probe is underway, according to the Customs department. ENS

2 elderly sisters found dead at their Goa home

TWO ELDERLY sisters, aged 70 and 73, were found dead in their house in South Goa’s Canacona on Monday, with police suspecting they could have died by suicide. Police have initiated inquest proceedings in the case. A purported suicide note and a clinic spirit bottle were recovered from a bedroom in the house, police said. In the brief suicide note, the sisters allegedly wrote that they had saved over Rs 15,000 for their cremation and mentioned where the cash had been kept for their last rites. The duo was unmarried and had been living together for several years, police said. ENS

SC notice on Pranit More’s plea to club FIRs in ‘Rs 370 biryani’ row

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 21

THE SUPREME Court on Monday sought the response of the Centre, and the Maharashtra and Haryana governments on a plea by stand-up comedian Pranit More seeking clubbing of FIRs registered against him over the “Rs 370 biryani” comment controversy.

More’s counsel told a three-judge bench, presided over by CJI Surya Kant, that the FIRs in the two states were identical and they should be clubbed. He also said that More had apologised soon after the incident and is ready to face trial.

“I have tendered a public apology. Before the NCW, I submitted my apology, but they did not accept it. I was just the host. I understand the gravity. I am ready to face the trial,” the counsel told the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, on More’s behalf. “I deleted the video before the FIR.”

More was travelling at the time and his public relations team did not take his approval

before publishing the video.

More and web developer Himanshu Jangra had come under the scanner in June after a video clip from a Gurugram comedy show surfaced online. Jangra, who was in the audience, recounted a date during which “he had spent Rs 370 on a plate of chicken biryani”. He stated that when the woman subsequently asked him to drop her home, he sought sexual favours in return for the money he had spent.

More, who was hosting the show, was seen laughing at and validating Jangra’s remarks, saying “peak Gurugram content”.

The video drew backlash, prompting NCW to intervene on June 11. It expressed grave concern over the normalisation of gender-based entitlement, and its Chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar wrote to Haryana’s DGP seeking an Action Taken Report. Following an outrage, More and Jangra issued public apologies, and Jangra deactivated his Instagram account. The company he worked with fired Jangra over his remarks. In August, he returned to stand-up comedy with a tour called ‘Ghayal’.

HC quashes PSA against J&K man

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 21

PREVENTIVE DETENTION can’t become a substitute for ordinary criminal law, the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court has said as it quashed the Public Safety Act (PSA) invoked against a Srinagar resident.

“Preventive detention cannot become a substitute for ordinary criminal law. Nor can the extraordinary power of preventive detention be exercised merely because the authorities entertain a general apprehension regarding a person’s antecedents,” Justice M A Chowdhary said in his judgment on September 17. “There must be

Preventive detention cannot replace criminal law: Court

material from which a rational prognosis of future prejudicial conduct can be made”.

Zubair Altaf Sheikh, a resident of Srinagar’s Soura, was booked under the PSA in September 2025, primarily on the back of an FIR against him in 2022. While he had been bailed out by the court in the case, the same case was used to book him under the PSA for the first time in 2022. The detention, too, had been quashed by the court.

While the respondents’

counsel argued that the PSA detention order is not “founded merely upon the FIR” registered in 2022, and was based on a fresh dossier containing more materials and “fresh inputs received through discrete sources”, Justice Chowdhary said the “court is unable to accept the submission”.

“An antecedent can undoubtedly be referred to for a limited purpose, but where the antecedent is relied upon as a circumstance supporting the conclusion that the detainee continues to pose a threat to the ‘security of the State’, it must have a live and proximate nexus with the present necessity of detention,” the court said.

• FORMER CONSTABLE GETS 10-YEAR RI; VIVEK TIWARI’S KIN ASK HOW COULD A TRAINED CONSTABLE MAKE A MISTAKE WHILE FIRING HIS SERVICE WEAPON

Apple executive shot dead in 2018 — 8 yrs later, ‘only half justice’

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 21

EIGHT YEARS after Apple sales executive Vivek Tiwari was shot dead in Lucknow during a late night police check, a court on Monday sentenced a former constable to 10 years’ rigorous imprisonment.

Prashant Chaudhary was convicted on September 17 of culpable homicide not amounting to murder. The court acquitted co-accused constable Sandeep Kumar, who was out on bail. Speaking to *The Indian Express* after the verdict, Tiwari’s brother-in-law, Vishnu Shukla, said the family will challenge both the sentence and Ku-

mar’s acquittal. “This is only half justice for us,” he said. “How could a trained police constable have made a mistake while firing his service weapon?... It was a clear case of murder.”

Chaudhary has remained in judicial custody since the killing. District Government Counsel, Lucknow, Rakesh Pandey, said, “Chaudhary appeared before the court from jail under tight security. The court sentenced him to 10 years’ imprisonment and imposed a fine of Rs 20,000.”

Tiwari, from New Hyderabad Colony in Lucknow, is survived by his wife, Kalpana, an Officer on Special Duty at the Nagar Nigam, and two children. He was 38. Tiwari and his col-



Vivek Tiwari was shot dead during a late night police check in Lucknow in 2018. FILE

league, Sana Khan, were returning home in his car around 1.30 am on September 29, 2018.

As they reached Makdoo-pur outpost in Gomti Nagar Extension, Chaudhary and Kumar, who were on a bike, signalled to them to stop. When Sana rolled down the window to ask why, Kumar allegedly struck her with a baton. Police claimed Tiwari did not stop and kept driving. Chaudhary allegedly also pulled out his service pistol and fired at the vehicle. The bullet struck Tiwari, causing him to crash into a divider. The two constables then fled the scene.

Sana sought help from the police control room and took Tiwari to a hospital, where he died during treatment. An FIR against the duo was registered the following day at the Gomti

Nagar police station, and they were subsequently arrested.

In the FIR, Sana had said, “...Two policemen came on a bike. We tried to escape them, and they stopped us. Suddenly, I heard a gunshot, the car kept moving and it hit the underpass pillar. Blood was pouring from Vivek’s head. I cried for help and soon, a police team came and took Vivek to hospital. Later, I was told that he was dead.”

The duo, however, had alleged that Tiwari tried to run them down, and Chaudhary fired the shot in “self-defence”.

Then DGP O P Singh had constituted a special probe team to investigate the case. The bullet hit Tiwari’s neck, police had said.

Then Lucknow SSP Kalanidhi Naithani said that the post mortem report confirmed that he had died of bullet injury. The car Tiwari was driving had a broken windshield with a bullet hole in it, while the driver’s seat was drenched in blood.

At the time, Kalpana had questioned the functioning of police and demanded a meeting with the chief minister. “They killed an innocent man. They are saying that he did not stop the car. In that case, they should have fired at the tyre and the car would have stopped. They miss shots when firing on actual criminals but here, they shot my husband with a single shot,” she had claimed.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• **HEALTH**

CCTV at medical stores: Why govt wants them, but chemists don't

Anonna Dutt

New Delhi, September 21

THE UNION Health Ministry has proposed mandatory CCTV surveillance at medical stores as it looks to curb the abuse of prescription drugs. A draft notification by the ministry calls for maintaining the recordings for three months.

The Health Ministry said in a statement that this would ensure stricter control over prescription medicines, especially habit-forming drugs listed under Schedule X of the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945. In the draft notification, the ministry said the step seeks to address concerns over the “unauthorised access to and sale of Schedule H, H1 and X drugs” — all prescription drugs, including strong antibiotics and psychotropic substances.

• **Why was this step taken?**

The measure was first proposed in 2021 to prevent the abuse of drugs by children.

H G Koshia, the head of the Drugs Consultative Committee, Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation, said: “Round-the-clock surveillance will, in a way, create fear among medical store owners and pharmacists so that they are not inclined to sell these medicines without a prescription for children. The CCTV footage is mainly meant to verify whether there has been a sale to a minor without prescription, not all sales can be verified in this manner.” While routine inspection every three months may be difficult, the data can be retrieved when there is a complaint.

The committee decided to implement the app-based system and CCTV surveillance plan earlier this year.

• **GOTA PRESCRIPTION?**

SCHEDULE H: Medicines that can't be sold without a prescription from a registered medical practitioner. Examples include many antibiotics and steroids.

SCHEDULE H1: Subject to additional record-keeping requirements. Examples include certain antibiotics and anti-TB medicines.

SCHEDULE X: More tightly controlled category, with additional requirements. It includes some psychotropic medicines.

mon in children than adults.

Of the estimated 2.3 crore total opioid users (adults and children) in the country, 25 lakh are dependent on pharmaceutical opioids, while the highest 63 lakh are dependent on heroin, according to the study.

• **What do chemists say?**

The All India Organisation of Chemists and Druggists raised several objections, some of which are:

First, it would put a financial burden on pharmaceutical stores, especially the smaller ones. Second, power failures and issues with connectivity in rural places pose serious hurdles. Finally, and most importantly, it would violate patient privacy, the organisation said.

“Stores might have to shell out nearly a lakh to put the system in place. How can a store with, say, sales of Rs 5,000 to 10,000 do that?,” said Rajeev Singhal, general secretary of the organisation.

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9 Karol Bagh	28 सितंबर शाम 6:00 बजे	23 Sept 6:00 PM	
9 Noida	5 अक्टूबर दोपहर 3:00 बजे	12 Oct 11:00 AM	
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9 Lucknow	30 सितंबर सुबह 11:30 बजे	24 Sept 8:00 AM	
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• **CORPORATE**

Why a 2021 top court verdict on Cyrus Mistry has been invoked in Tata dispute

George Mathew

Mumbai, September 21

THE SUPREME Court's judgment in the Tata-Cyrus Mistry dispute in 2021 has assumed fresh significance amid the escalating battle over the control and governance of Tata Sons, the principal holding company of the Tata Group.

Senior advocate Abhishek Manu Singhvi, appointed by Tata Trusts, which collectively own about 66% of Tata Sons, referred to the judgment on Sunday. He argued that the court had “clearly given Tata Trusts the primacy” in their relationship with Tata Sons. Singhvi also highlighted the court's decision to uphold the special Articles of Association (which lay down rules for a company's governance) on the Trusts' rights.

The observation comes at a sensitive juncture. Tata Trusts are challenging the validity of the September 17 decision of the Tata Sons board to reappoint N Chandrasekaran as its executive chairman. They con-

tend that the Articles require the affirmative support of the Trusts' nominee directors for certain decisions, and that neither a general board majority nor the chairman's casting vote can override that requirement.

The legal question is whether the principles upheld by the SC affect the interpretation of the present Articles of Association.

• **What was the Tata-Mistry case?**

The dispute began after Cyrus Mistry was removed as executive chairman of Tata Sons in 2016. The Mistry family and the Shapoorji Pallonji Group, which held about 18.37% of Tata Sons, challenged his removal and alleged oppression and mismanagement.

The litigation eventually reached the Supreme Court after the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) ordered Mistry's reinstatement.

In 2021, a three-judge SC bench headed by then Chief Justice S A Bobde overturned that verdict and ruled in favour of Tata

Sons. The SC held that the mere removal from the position of chairman could not, by itself, amount to oppression or prejudice, and rejected Mistry's reinstatement.

• **What did SC say about Tata Trusts' special rights?**

The Tata Sons Articles of Association gave the two principal Tata Trusts — Sir Ratan Tata Trust and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust — special rights, including the ability to nominate directors. The Mistry side challenged the voting powers of Trust nominees.

However, the SC held that directors nominated by the Trusts had the right to affirmative voting because, in addition to their responsibilities towards the companies they represented, they had duties towards the Trusts' beneficiaries. These voting rights effectively gave the Trust nominees veto powers on specified matters, including strategic plans, major investments, and changes affecting the Trusts' shareholding.

In the present Tata Sons confrontation,

this assumes significance. The question now is how those rights operate when the two Trust nominees themselves disagree.

• **Why is this relevant now?**

The present dispute turns on the interpretation of the same basic governance architecture. Article 104B gives the Tata Trusts the right to nominate one-third of the Tata Sons board while they hold the prescribed shareholding. Article 121 requires matters decided by a majority of directors to also receive the affirmative vote of a majority of Trust-nominated directors.

There are currently two Tata Trusts nominees on the Tata Sons board: Noel Tata and Venu Srinivasan. Srinivasan supported Chandrasekaran's reappointment, while Noel Tata opposed it. Four others voted in favour. Tata Sons treated it as a valid decision, while Tata Trusts disagreed.

• **What is Tata Trusts' argument?**

Their argument is that where the articles prescribe an additional condition —

Why does Article 371 exist in so many different forms? What role has it played in the governance of different states over the years?

areas led Parliament to provide another layer of political representation.

The 22nd Constitutional Amendment of 1969 allowed the President to create a committee within the Assam Legislative Assembly comprising members elected from the tribal areas covered by the Sixth Schedule. It created a mechanism through which representatives from protected tribal areas could have a distinct voice.

MANIPUR: When Manipur became a full state in 1972, the political relationship between its predominantly tribal hill areas and the Imphal Valley had to be addressed.

Article 371C was thus inserted to provide for a special committee of the Legislative Assembly consisting of members elected from the hill areas, with a special responsibility for the Governor to report to the President on their administration.

ANDHRA PRADESH: Tensions between the Telangana and Andhra regions produced political agitations and led to the Six-Point Formula of 1973 that intended to address grievances over education, government employment and regional development.

Thus came Article 371D, providing for equitable opportunities in education and public employment across different parts of the state. Here, it was born out of a regional equality and employment dispute, not an ethnic or cultural autonomy movement.

SIKKIM: Insertion of Article 371F was essentially for integration of the erstwhile independent state into the Indian union. In 1975, following political developments and a referendum, Sikkim became India's 22nd state. Article 371F was to manage that transition.

MIZORAM AND ARUNACHAL PRADESH: The 1986 Mizo Peace Accord between the Government of India and the Mizo National Front paved the way for Mizoram's statehood. Article 371G was thus inserted to protect Mizo religious and social practices, customary law and procedure, customary administration of justice, and ownership and transfer of land. Parliamentary laws concerning these matters do not automatically apply unless the Mizoram Assembly agrees.

For Arunachal Pradesh, which became a state in 1987, Article 371H took a different approach, giving the Governor a special re-

sponsibility for law and order.

GOA AND KARNATAKA: Article 371I, inserted when Goa became a state, is comparatively modest: it simply requires the Goa Legislative Assembly to have at least 30 members.

In 2012, Parliament added Article 371J for the Hyderabad-Karnataka region, now Kalyana Karnataka, to address regional backwardness through a development board, equitable allocation of funds and opportunities in public employment and education.

• **Article 371K and Ladakh**

Ladakh is seeking something that does not neatly fit any existing 371 provision. The proposed Article 371K would apply to a UT without a legislature. The emerging proposal envisages a directly elected UT-level body with legislative, executive, budgetary, planning and financial powers.

The MHA has said the body would have legislative powers over land, culture and language, forests, environment and natural resources, as well as other subjects reserved for the UT under Article 240.

Ladakh's leaders are also seeking control over law and order. Existing Article 371H gives the Governor special responsibility for law and order in Arunachal Pradesh. Ladakh's leaders want the opposite. Similarly, the land protection sought by Ladakh resembles the philosophy of 371A and 371G, under which certain Parliamentary laws relating to land and customary practices do not apply automatically. But Ladakh is simultaneously seeking a much more substantial democratic governing institution.

• **What will be written into 371K**

If the provision merely creates an elected body and lists subjects over which it can legislate, its protection would be relatively limited. Manipur is an example where hill tribes have argued that Article 371C has failed to deliver on its promise of meaningful autonomy and protection.

If Ladakh's 371 protects the proposed elected body's control over land, natural resources, recruitment and administration, it would be considerably stronger. If it places law and order and the bureaucracy under the elected executive, the Ladakh head of government would be more powerful than the J&K chief minister.

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• **POLICY**

Article 371 A to J, and what K can do for Ladakh



DEEPTIMAN TIWARY

THE CENTRE has proposed inserting a new provision, Article 371K, in the Constitution to provide special constitutional safeguards for Ladakh. The proposal follows an “in-principle understanding” reached between the Ministry of Home Affairs and representatives of the Apex Body, Leh (ABL) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) to create a directly elected Union Territory-level body with legislative, executive, financial and planning powers.

• **What is Article 371?**

Article 371 was not originally created to give special constitutional protection to the Northeast or tribal regions. At Independence, India did not consist only of the provinces directly administered by the British, but also hundreds of princely states, which had acceded to India under very different historical and administrative circumstances. The Constitution classified these territories separately as Part B States, including Hyderabad, Mysore, Jammu and Kashmir, Rajasthan and others.

The Constitution-makers were concerned about these newly integrated states immediately functioning within the same framework as the former British provinces. The original Article 371, adopted in 1950, was therefore a transitional provision for Central supervision.

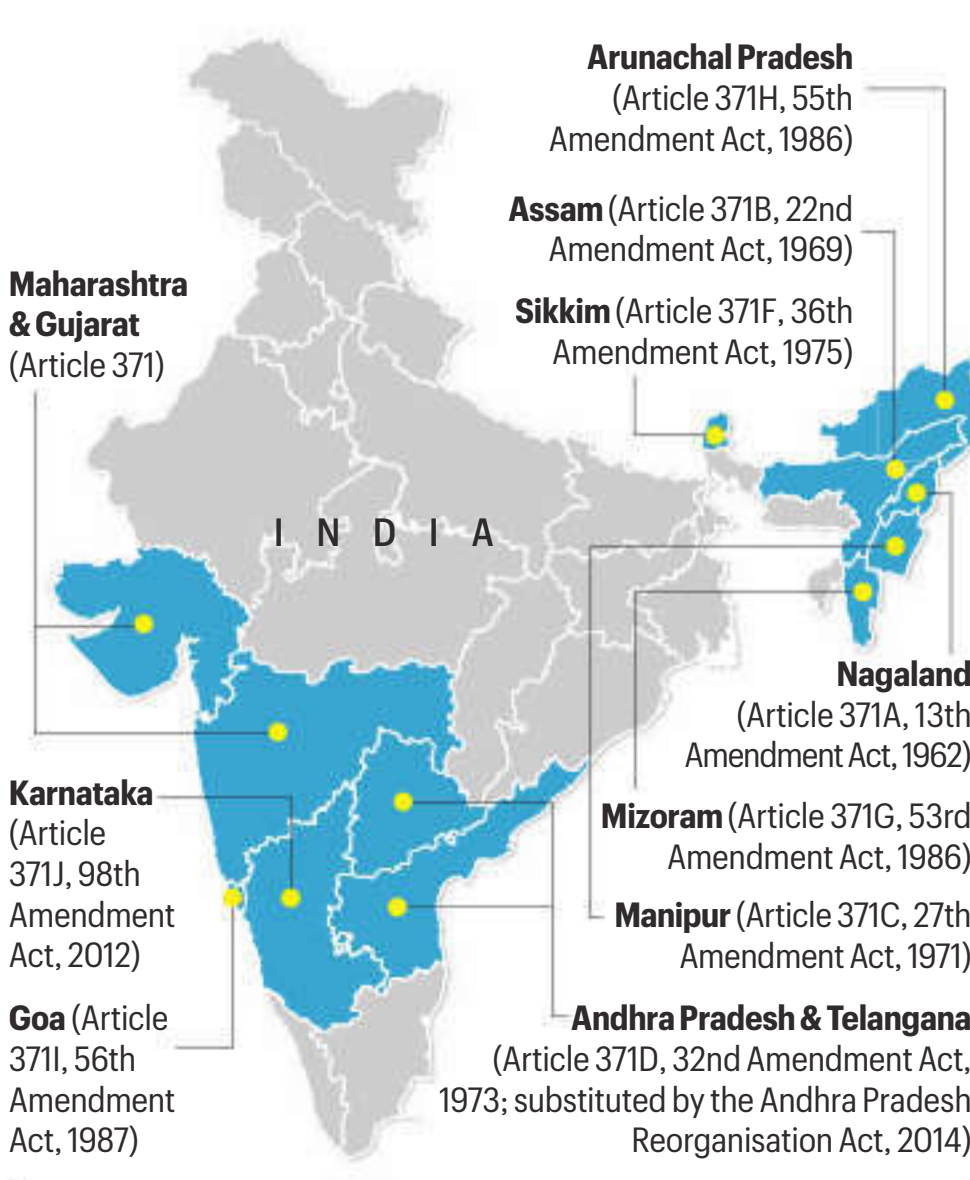
It placed the governments of the Part B States under the general control of the President for 10 years, or for such longer or shorter period as Parliament might prescribe.

However, six years later, the States Reorganisation Act and the Seventh Constitutional Amendment of 1956 abolished the old Part A, Part B and Part C classification of states and created a more uniform structure of states and Union Territories (UTs).

In doing so, the original Article 371 disappeared. Parliament replaced it with one that today provides special arrangements for Maharashtra and Gujarat, particularly for equitable development of regions such as Vidarbha, Marathwada, Saurashtra and Kutch.

• **So how did Article 371 become associated with special protection?**

• **SPECIAL PROVISIONS FOR STATES**



India's constitutional system was designed to be flexible enough to accommodate regions whose historical circumstances, social structures or political demands were different from the rest of the country. Thus, Parliament repeatedly created bespoke constitutional arrangements.

NAGALAND: After Independence, the Naga political movement challenged India's claim over Naga areas. The conflict eventually led to the 16-Point Agreement of 1960, which became the basis for the creation of Nagaland as a separate state.

One of the understandings was that Naga religious and social practices, customary law and procedure, and ownership and transfer of land and its resources would receive special protection. When Nagaland was created in 1963, these arrangements were incorporated into the Constitution through the insertion of Article 371A.

ASSAM: Article 371B, inserted in 1969, arose from a different concern. Assam contained large tribal and hill areas that already had special arrangements under the Sixth Schedule. Growing demands from these

• **Unique provisions**

India's constitutional system was designed to be flexible enough to accommodate regions whose history, society or political demands were different from the rest of the country.

• Thus, Parliament repeatedly created bespoke constitutional arrangements.

• **WILDLIFE**

Conservation, compensation: Tackling Himachal monkey menace

Saurabh Parashar

Shimla, September 21

THE RECENT death of a 63-year-old woman in Shimla has again brought forth the issue of human-wildlife conflict. The woman suffered grievous injuries, including spinal damage, after being attacked by a pack of rhesus macaques on the roof of her house on August 30. She succumbed to her injuries on September 5.

The incident highlights the legal and administrative position of rhesus macaques, or rhesus monkeys. The Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972, listed the rhesus macaque as a protected species under Part I of Schedule II, but the Wild Life (Protection) Amendment Act, 2022, removed it.

• **What changed after 2022**

Chief Wildlife Warden of Himachal Pradesh, Alok Prem Nagar, told *The Indian Express*: “State forest departments are now no more responsible for looking after the monkey menace. A monkey is now like a stray animal, which falls under the purview of civic bodies.”



Shimla records 50-55 cases of monkey attack every month. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

A senior Indian Forest Service (IFoS) officer said there were many reasons why urban local bodies (ULBs) like Shimla Municipal Corporation (SMC) were “not fully competent” to tackle the monkey menace independently. “First, the lack of funds. Second, absence of expertise and trained manpower to capture monkeys, and sterilising the captured monkeys,” the officer told *The Indian Express*.

• **Sustained sterilisation**

• Official numbers show that Himachal Pradesh's estimated rhesus macaque population fell from 3,17,512 in 2004 to 2,26,086 in 2013, and then to 1,36,443 in 2019-20.

• The state forest department attributes much of this decline to sustained sterilisation. Starting 2006, the state had sterilised 1,86,448 monkeys by March 2024.

According to the officer, state forest departments earlier used to receive funds from the Centre to control the monkey menace. Now, with the rhesus monkey no longer a protected animal, the officer added, this is no longer the case.

Shimla Municipal Commissioner, Sachin Kanwal, told *The Indian Express*: “We are in the process of training our manpower on how to capture the monkeys. Whenever a situation arises, we take the assistance of the forest department concerned.”

Deputy Conservator of Forests (Wildlife) of Himachal Pradesh, Shah Nawaz Ahmad Bhat, said that the forest department had not given up its responsibilities. “We do intervene, but largely in and around the forest areas. Whenever Municipal Corporation officials approach us for capturing a monkey and sterilising it, we do provide our assistance. But we charge money from ULBs,” he told *The Indian Express*. The cost of sterilisation per monkey is Rs 700.

• **Conservation dilemma**

As per SMC officials, Shimla records 50-55 cases of monkey attack every month.

Wildlife expert Shaminder Boparai said that opinion was divided on whether monkeys “should be treated like vermin or a protected animal”, despite the fact that their population increases rapidly.

“The public feeding of wild animals, including monkeys, are forcing animals to come out of the forest in search of easy food,” Boparai told *The Indian Express*.

• **A question of compensation**

Last week, a Shimla-based NGO held a protest outside the SMC Commissioner's office demanding a compensation of Rs 5 lakh for the deceased woman. The NGO also demanded stricter action against those found feeding monkeys in Shimla.

The change in legal status, however, has also affected compensation. Under Himachal Pradesh's wildlife compensation policy cited by officials, severe monkey-attack injuries attract a compensation of Rs 75,000, permanent disability Rs 1 lakh, and death Rs 4 lakh. Since rhesus macaque is no longer covered by the Act, officials indicated that the woman's family is unlikely to qualify under this framework.

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Economic reforms and broader alliances are Canada's best response to Trump's trade war.
— *Financial Times*



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Democracy needs renewal. Our idea of Swaraj offers some answers



DESHKAAL
BY YOGENDRA YADAV

WHAT SHOULD be a new constitution for the 21st century? For us, the question raises the spectre of mutilation of the Constitution of India. But once we think of constitution with a small "c" — not simply as the name of a founding text, but as the basic arrangement of power — we can appreciate the pressing nature of this question across the globe. The crisis of democracy in the US and the extreme right-wing wave in Europe have put the rather sorry state of democracy across the globe in the spotlight. Once we refer to the verb form of the constitution — to constitute, or the act of constituting — the idea of a new constitution opens up the possibility of reimagining the future of democracy.

India has a surprisingly salient place in answering this global question, and not just as a case study of democratic degeneration. India can also be a source of ideas for democratic regeneration.

The concept of Swaraj can help enrich the democratic ideal. The dominant idea of democracy as self-rule is limited to how the people relate to rulers: The idea that citizens should have an equal right to choose those who rule them and then hold them accountable. But it does not draw our attention to what these citizens must do to one another, what the *demos* must look like. The idea of Swaraj, as interpreted by Gandhi, involved a conceptual twist: Swaraj is not just rule of the self, but also rule over the self; it is not just about how people relate to rulers, but also about how they relate to one another and to themselves. On this reading, the building of a political community bound by shared

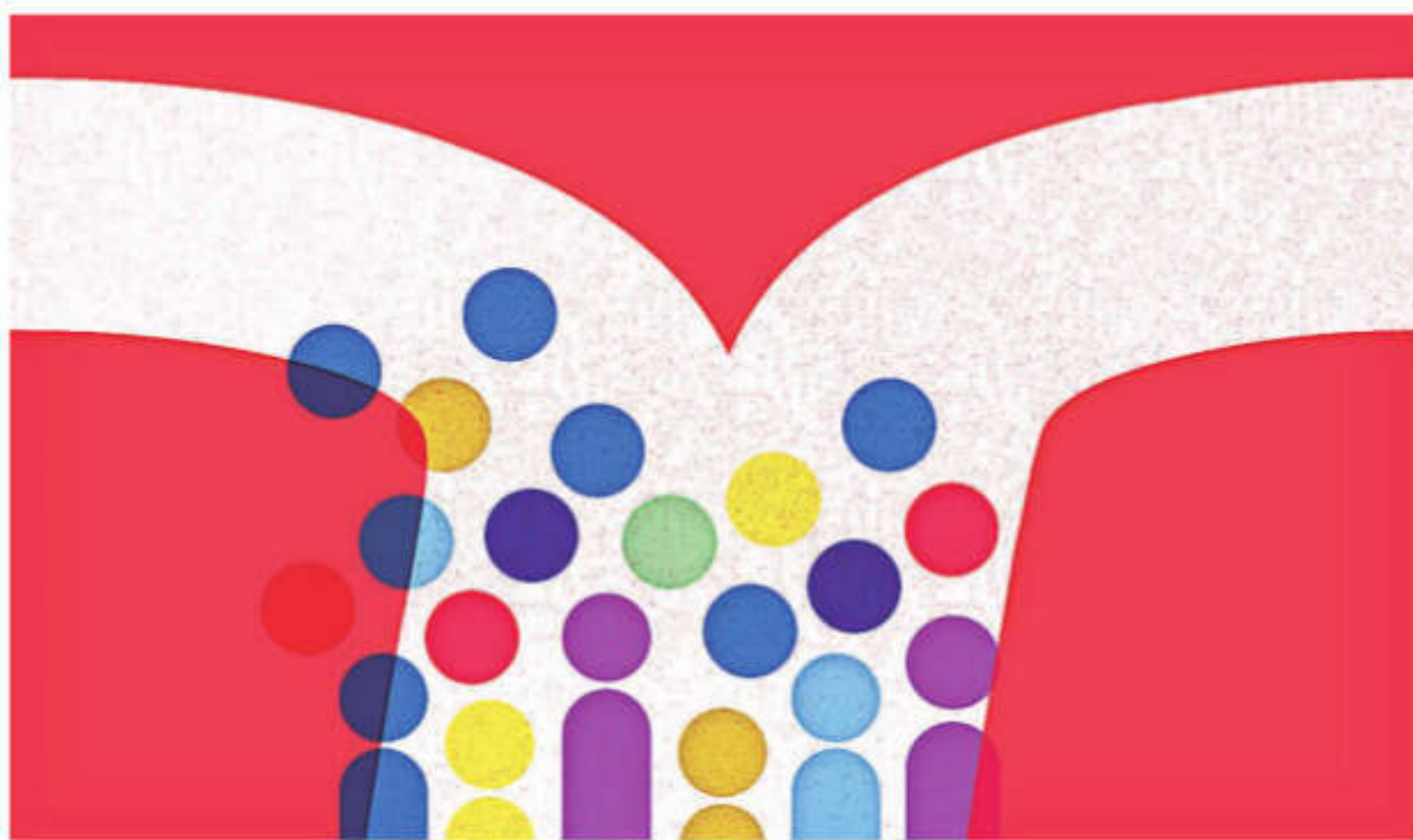


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

norms, an open dialogue and self-regulation is central to the idea of democracy. In a similar vein, Dr Ambedkar underlined fraternity as a precondition for a successful democracy.

Democracy is thus not just about good institutions but also about robust practices. Constituting democracy is not just about sowing the seeds, but about regular cultivation. In *Cultivating Democracy*, anthropologist Mukulika Banerjee draws our attention to how the activity of cultivating crops encourages democratic practices of "nurture, patience, vigilance and hope". A culture of democracy requires building community bonds or fraternity, crafting a shared vision, rearticulating the vision for every new generation, investing in developing political leaders and placing a premium on the tiny class of "idealists" who participate in this game of democracy not as entrepreneurs but as missionaries.

Several 20th-century Indian political thinkers can help us rethink the institutional design of

There is a radical mismatch between the level at which a problem presents itself and the level at which power to redress it is located. There is a case for building the architecture of democracy from the bottom up

democracy in the 21st century. They were all radical democrats, but deeply sceptical of the arrangement of democracy in post-Independence India. Ambedkar's insistence on the "preconditions of democracy", MN Roy's advocacy of party-less democracy, Jayaprakash Narayan's plea for the reconstruction of Indian polity and Rammanohar Lohia's proposal for *chaukhanbaraj* (four-pillar democracy) may not have gained acceptance in their own times. These ideas cannot be adopted today in their original form. But their critique invites us to think of reconstituting some of the taken-for-granted furniture of modern democracies.

Let us note four of these design defects. One, modern democracies operate at a scale too vast to make the idea of self-rule meaningful. Nation-states or even their federal units are simply too unwieldy to allow any meaningful self-rule. Two, there is a radical mismatch between the level at which a problem presents itself and the level at which the power to redress it is lo-

cated. There is a case for building the architecture of democracy from the bottom up, starting with the village or local councils and going all the way up to global governance, following the principle of subsidiarity — what can be decided at a lower level must not be left to a higher level. Three, the calendar of democratic accountability — elections every five or four or even two years — is at once too short and too long. It's too short to allow long-term policy designs and too long to check arbitrary use of power. And four, the threshold of a simple majority of seats in an election is too low to hand over the keys to the brute power of the modern state. The majoritarianism we see all around us is not a perversion but the natural unfolding of the institutional design of what we call democracy.

These thinkers also drew our attention to three systemic defects of democracy. One, the social hierarchy of caste and class that negates the promise of one person, one vote. The caste system and the capitalist economic system allow and encourage the concentration of social and economic power that is simply incompatible with the idea of self-rule by equal citizens. Two, the present system of corporate-controlled mass media negates the possibility of democratic public opinion. It serves to under-inform and misinform the public and allows for an easy democracy capture. And three, the fossilised oligarchies that constitute political parties across the world serve as high barriers to entry to politics and end up perpetuating the rule of a tiny elite, unresponsive to the electorate. Just as the 20th century could not imagine a democratic constitution without a bill of rights, we cannot imagine a constitution for the 21st century without a chapter on institutional mechanisms to check the concentration of economic power in corporates, information flows in mass media, and political decision-making in political parties.

The writer is a member of Swaraj India and national convener of Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. The article is based on his presentation at the conference on "A Constitution for the 21st Century", organised by the McQuillan Institute at Boston, September 11-12

When the House ceases to hold power to account



A SURYA PRAKASH

THE COUNTRY'S democratic institutions — the two Houses of Parliament and the state assemblies — are caricatures of what they used to be when they were established. When it all began in the 1950s, the Houses of Parliament and state assemblies were vibrant bodies that met for around 100 days a year or more, and MPs and MLAs articulated their constituencies' concerns. Question Hour and Call Attention Motions kept the government on its toes, and ministers viewed an approaching session with some trepidation. Today Parliament and the assemblies hardly meet, and the disruptive nature of politics has hollowed out these institutions. As a result, they no longer serve the purpose for which they were established.

The two Houses of Parliament met for an average of 127 days per year during the 1950s, and this rose to 138 sittings in the following decade. Now, this average was just 55 days during the 17th Lok Sabha (2019-2024). The percentage of time lost to disruptions has spiralled to over 25 per cent.

There are fewer days for Question Hour, Call Attention Motions, debates on the Demands for Grants of various departments and legislative business. In earlier decades, MPs would pin down ministers during Question Hour, and the Speakers would pull up ministers who were unprepared or tried to mislead the House. Today, since the House hardly meets, most ministers are given a walkover.

The performance of state assemblies is even more abysmal. The average sittings of state assemblies per year, around 80 days or more six decades ago, has crashed to less than 25 days. Article 174(1) of the Constitution stipulates that there shall not be a gap of six months between two sittings. Most chief ministers merely ensure that they fulfil this constitutional formality.

This is borne out by PRS Legislative Research. The UP Assembly, which met for 45 to 50 days a year six decades ago, now meets for 15-20 days. The Karnataka Assembly met for around 75-80 days in the 1970s. Now, its sittings average 25 to 33 days per year. The Tamil Nadu Assembly is down from 64 days per year to 32 days. Punjab and Haryana are down to 10-15 days from 40; Bihar is down from 60 days a year to 30. The numbers for Maharashtra, Gujarat and Tripura have fallen by 50 per cent as well.

The problem extends to every aspect of the work of a legislative body, including committees and law-making. Studies show the attendance in committees is just about 50 per cent. The less said about the attitude of MPs to law-making, the better. Here are a few examples: On August 30, 2012, the Lok Sabha passed the AIIMS (A) Bill concerning the establishment of six such premier hospitals for Rs 4,900 crore, in just a minute-and-a-half. On September 3, 2012, the Lok Sabha passed three bills, including the Protection of Women Against Sexual Harassment at Workplace Bill (a law that affects millions of working women), without debate. One bill about three new high courts in the Northeast was moved at 12:03 and passed at 12:05. The next day, the House passed the NIMHANS Bill in two minutes.

In the Monsoon Session this year, two bills were cleared in three minutes each. Three other bills took four minutes each. These examples of "law-making" in Parliament should shock the conscience of every parliamentarian.

The list of perquisites given to parliamentarians is very long, but one item should alert citizens — special, privileged allotment of firearms to MPs by the Customs Department. Four decades ago, Parliament was informed that over 15 months, as many as 38 MPs were allotted guns seized by the Customs Department. RTI activist Ambrish Pandey found that 82 MPs were allotted weapons between 2001 and 2012, including 13 who were facing criminal charges like murder, attempt to murder and kidnapping.

In the 1950s, it cost Rs 36,000 per day to run Parliament. In 2004, the cost jumped to Rs 1.23 crore per day and in 2012 to Rs 2 crore. Now, PRS Legislative Research estimates the cost to be a staggering Rs 9 crore per day.

Irrespective of which party or alliance is in power at the Centre and in the states, the parties occupying the opposition benches do not allow the Houses to function. The chaos caused by slogan-shouting results in adjournment.

The fall in standards is precipitous. People must demand that the salaries, allowances and perks of our representatives be cut by 50 per cent until a semblance of accountability is restored. One looks forward to such a resolution being adopted at the next conference of presiding officers.

Surya Prakash is the author of What Ails Indian Parliament

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Beyond declarations

BRICS OFFERS India an important platform to engage with emerging economies and discuss issues ranging from development to global governance ('India's BRICS diplomacy is more than one summit's result', *IE*, September 21). Yet differences among member countries can make collective action difficult. India's challenge is to use the grouping for practical cooperation while maintaining its wider strategic partnerships.

Sodsi Raj, Dhenkanal

Stable engagement

INDIA'S ECONOMIC interests require working with both the US and China while reducing excessive dependence on either ('India will de-risk, not decouple, from US and China', *IE*, September 21). Supply-chain diversification should therefore be accompanied by stronger domestic manufacturing, technology capacity and alternative markets. Trade and investment ties with Europe, Japan, South-east Asia and BRICS can broaden India's options. At the same time, stable diplomatic engagement with Washington and Beijing remains important. Critical sectors such as semiconductors, energy, defence equipment and telecommunications need carefully planned sourcing strategies.

A Myilsami, Coimbatore

AI in the classrooms

THE RAPID spread of AI in education makes it necessary to rethink what students are expected to learn ('What we need to learn, before AI learns too much', *IE*, September 21). Simply banning such tools is unlikely to work. Schools and universities should teach students how to verify AI-generated information, cite sources and use these systems responsibly. Assessments can place greater emphasis on oral explanations, classroom work, projects and original reasoning. Teachers, too, need training in detecting misuse. Clear institutional guidelines on privacy and academic integrity would help. AI should support learning, not replace curiosity, judgement and independent thought.

S Durga Arunkumar, Coonoor



AJAY MATHUR

FOR DECADES, India's diplomatic ties with Nepal during natural calamities followed a well-known script. When cloudbursts, landslides, or flash floods devastated the Himalayan nation, New Delhi acted as a friendly "first responder". However, after the recent catastrophic flash floods, Nepal's leadership has moved away from a paradigm of ad-hoc relief to a framework of climate justice and financial liability. Kathmandu has appealed to the UN-backed Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage while calling on developed countries to deliver compensation and concessional climate finance, and pressing regional neighbours, including China and India, for cooperation on preparedness, data sharing and resilience. It has clarified that it is not seeking damages from any single country, but the expectation placed on its neighbours is unmistakable. Prime Minister Balendra Shah will take this case to the UN General Assembly on September 24.

This shift presents India with a dilemma. As a leading voice of the Global South, India has historically argued that the Global North bears sole responsibility for funding climate loss and damage. Yet, as a rising regional power whose emissions footprint and infrastructure investments are tied to the Third Pole's fragile ecology, India can no longer rely on global support alone. New Delhi must evolve from a donor during crises into a co-underwriter of regional climate justice.

Global climate finance mechanisms are unsuited for fast-moving, compounding ecological dis-

India can construct regional institutions that deliver the substance of loss and damage funding without getting bogged down in fault-based compensation terminology

asters. Consider the UN Green Climate Fund's (GCF) track record. A \$499 million project designed to protect vulnerable Nepalese communities from glacial lake outburst floods sat in the GCF pipeline for over seven years. By the time bureaucratic approvals cleared, the waters had already broken. Similarly, while the UN Loss and Damage Fund was created to address irreparable climate impacts, its capital reserves remain a drop in the ocean compared to actual costs. Nepal faces a reconstruction bill of nearly 10 per cent of its GDP. Downstream and mountain nations are applying the Common But Differentiated Responsibilities principle locally, pointing out that adjacent, high-emitting economic engines share an immediate physical footprint in their backyard.

For New Delhi, this is an uncomfortable precedent. India's per capita emissions remain low, its historical contributions to global warming are minimal compared to the West, and it is itself a climate change victim. Accepting direct "liability" or paying explicit "climate damages" could expose India to similar claims from other countries, while weakening its leverage against the Global North. Rejecting Kathmandu's appeals, however, carries a geopolitical cost. China is stepping up its climate and green outreach across the Himalayas. An evasive response could turn Nepal's people away from India and give Beijing more room.

India must transcend the false choice between total legal liability and passive humanitarian aid. As a

Nepal's climate call is a test for India

dominant middle power, India can construct regional institutions that deliver the substance of loss and damage funding without getting bogged down in fault-based compensation terminology. Working through frameworks like the New Development Bank, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, BIM-STECC, or a Third Pole Compact, India should champion a South Asian Resilience and Insurance Facility. Operating as a rapid-payout insurance pool, it would release funds upon satellite detection of threshold climate triggers, bypassing diplomatic wrangling. This ensures predictable finances for both Nepalese reconstruction and annual Indian disaster allocations.

India must make joint projects resilience-first, directing part of infrastructure funds to an adaptation fund for climate-proof local works, safer slopes and mountain livelihoods. India's space capabilities should be leveraged to create a real-time, open-access early warning system for the Himalayan belt. Co-owning GLOF monitoring data and lake volume tracking with Nepalese agencies transforms tactical intelligence into a shared regional security asset.

In this new phase of climate geopolitics, countries like India and China stand at a pivotal crossroads. By pioneering localised loss and damage mechanisms, co-underwriting regional resilience, and institutionalising transboundary safety, New Delhi can demonstrate a new paradigm of middle-power leadership.

The writer is professor, School of Public Policy, IIT Delhi



SUANSHU KHURANA

FOR YEARS, the quickest, and perhaps the most fraught, way for Sikh men to make themselves less visibly Sikh in the Western world was to take off their turban and cut off their hair. How Sikh could you be before someone began to stare? Or before it led to a slur or a racial stereotype? The aim, almost always, was to fit in.

Back home, giving up the turban was often understood as rejection of faith, of family and one's history. The *dastar* and unshorn hair are sacred parts of the Sikh identity and among the most visible expressions of the faith. They carry cultural, religious and, for many, emotional significance.

Then came Diljit Dosanjh in his turban, beard, kurta-chadra-kanthi (the traditional folk outfit), pairing it with luxury sneakers and sparking bullet belts or bandoliers representing traditional martial and warrior aesthetics, proudly singing in Punjabi, speaking in Punjabi and making his Sikh identity inseparable from his image as a global star. He did not have to speak or sing in English to be a global popstar — he could still command the biggest global stages, speak at the Recording Academy and attend the Met Gala.

For many, what had once been a source of self-consciousness and baggage, was suddenly part of the charm of a unique identity — "*wakhra swag*".

Which is why the spectacle at London's Wembley Stadium last week, where Dosanjh performed, was a sight to behold, with so many people wearing the "*turtlay wali pag*"

(a turban with a fan-shaped crest) now associated with him. Dosanjh — the first Punjabi artist to headline Wembley Stadium — had a "turban camp" at Wembley, where anyone and everyone, regardless of gender, nationality or ethnicity, could have a turban tied free of cost and become Punjabi for the night. People from India, Pakistan, Afghanistan and Bangladesh, and many others from the Western world, happily stepped into this Punjabi-ness for the night.

What Dosanjh has done, then, goes beyond taking Punjabi music and culture to

There is a remarkable confidence in how Dosanjh has made his Punjabi identity inseparable from his music

a wider audience. When he comes on stage and says, "Punjabi *aa gaye oye*", as he did under the Wembley arch as well, it isn't just a declaration to whip up a crowd; he's talking about how the community has arrived on a global platform. He has placed the refrain in the historical context too, while speaking of the *Komagata Maru* incident of 1914 when 376 Indian passengers were denied entry into Canada. They had to stay on the ship for nearly two months before being sent back to India. After a sold-out show at Vancouver's BC Place stadium, Dosanjh said on The Tonight Show with Jimmy Fallon: "You didn't allow us to come, now we are here."

There is a sense of *saanjha* Punjab (a shared Punjab) in that line, a Punjab whose shared heritage predates the Radcliffe Line. That connection came through powerfully at Wembley when Dosanjh sang "Saanso ki

mala' by Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan — the Pakistani singer's paean to Krishna, written by the 20th-century Urdu poet Tufail Hoshیار-puri. He also sang 'Laung gawacha', a folk song both sides still sing. Many Pakistanis — Pashtuns and Punjabis, some in turbans — sang along.

There is a remarkable confidence in how Dosanjh has made his Punjabi identity inseparable from his music. What he has done with the turban is also what he has done with his identity. He has taken its many strands and carried them to places where they were unfamiliar and ridiculed, and turned Punjabiness into something that others want to step into. That may well be one of his most enduring acts.

The writer is deputy associate editor, The Indian Express. suanshu.khurana@expressindia.com

Houthis seek control of Yemen highlands as Trump is said to have called off strikes

Washington has so far rebuffed pleas from Saudi Arabia to join the fight

Reuters

Dubai, September 21

HOUTHI FIGHTERS pushed to seize strategic heights in Yemen on Monday to cut off the Red Sea coast from remaining areas held by Saudi-backed forces, after a report that President Donald Trump had called off US strikes on the group at the last minute. A lightning advance by the Iran-backed group this month has extended the wider West Asia conflict to a new theatre and further threatened global energy supplies. Washington has so far rebuffed repeated pleas from Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman to join the fight in Yemen. *The New York Times* reported that the Trump administration had prepared to launch airstrikes on Sunday against the Houthis after fresh pleas from the Saudi crown prince. But the newspaper said Trump called off

France vows response after Iran closes language centre

United Nations: France will summon Iran's ambassador and take appropriate measures in response after Iranian authorities sealed a French language centre affiliated with its embassy in Tehran, the Foreign Ministry said on Sunday. "This new attack against France's cultural presence in Iran, following the assault on two staff members of the French embassy last July, is unjustifi-

able and unacceptable," Foreign Ministry spokesperson Pascal Confavreux said in a statement. Ties between the two countries have been strained for years over Iran's nuclear programme and Tehran detaining several French nationals. Iran's semi-official *Tasnim* news agency reported authorities had closed the French language centre following an order from Tehran prosecutor's office. **REUTERS**

CHINESE PRESIDENT IS SET TO VISIT WASHINGTON FROM SEPTEMBER 23 TO 25

‘Of historic significance’: China on Xi’s visit to US

Xi to have in-depth exchanges on key issues concerning China-US relations: Foreign Ministry

Press Trust of India
Beijing, September 21

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping will visit Washington from September 23 to 25 for summit talks with his US counterpart Donald Trump, marking their second meeting in six months, a development Beijing has described as a "milestone of historic significance". Xi will visit the US for three days at the invitation of Trump, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun announced at a media briefing here on Monday. During his talks with Trump, Xi will have in-depth exchanges on key issues concerning China-US relations, as well as world peace and development, Guo



US President Donald Trump with China's President Xi Jinping at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing. FILE

said. "The reciprocal visits by the two heads of state within a span of six months will mark a milestone of historic significance," he said. The two leaders last met in Beijing in May during Trump's China visit, when they held talks aimed at improving ties between the world's two largest economies. "China will work with the US to enrich the dimensions of

the China-US constructive relationship of strategic stability, strengthen dialogue and cooperation and properly manage differences so as to deliver greater benefits to our two peoples and to further contribute to world peace, stability and prosperity," Guo said. Trump plans to accord a rare airport reception to Xi by personally receiving him on the tar-

mac at Joint Base Andrews, according to the Hong Kong-based *South China Morning Post*. From trade tariffs and technology to AI, military-to-military ties, the conflict in West Asia, the Russia-Ukraine war, the space arms race and US arms sales to Taiwan, a range of issues are expected to figure in the meeting between the leaders. Ahead of Xi's visit, Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer held "candid, in-depth and constructive" talks on economic and trade issues, including AI, on Sunday in New York. In his talks with He, Bessent said the US had proposed a new notification mechanism for AI incidents that could affect national security. "We want a shared vision of common goals and common threats," Bessent said. "We think that just like any cross-border activity, that moving from opaque to more transparency between the No. 1 and the No. 2 AI powers in the world is very important."

CPC expels 2 top generals for discipline, law violations

Press Trust of India
Beijing, September 21

CHINA'S RULING Communist Party on Monday expelled two senior military officials, including the highest-ranking People's Liberation Army (PLA) official, General Zhang Youxia, from the party and the military for serious discipline and law violations. Zhang and Liu Zhenli were expelled from the Communist Party of China (CPC) in accordance with a decision made at a party leadership meeting in Beijing, Xinhua reported. Chinese President Xi Jinping, who is currently serving his



Zhang Youxia (left), Liu Zhenli

unprecedented third five-year term, initiated the anti-graft campaign against "tigers and flies" — big and small officials — when he took power in 2012. Dozens of senior PLA officers, including two defence ministers, have been sacked or punished under the intensified anti-corruption campaign car-

ried out by Xi. Zhang, 75, and Liu, 61, were placed under probe in January this year for serious violations of the ruling Communist Party's discipline and laws. A meeting of the Political Bureau of the CPC Central Committee Monday approved Central Military Commission's reports on handling of Zhang and Liu's cases after deliberation. Gen Zhang was the first-ranking Vice Chairman of the powerful seven-member CMC, the overall high command of the Chinese military headed by President Xi Jinping. Zhang's position in the CMC

made him the highest-ranking uniformed officer in the Chinese military. Zhang was formally detained by military corruption investigators in January. He was accused of corruption and of failing to rein in his close associates, family members and relatives. He was also blamed for not flagging problems to the party leadership at the first instance, the Hong Kong-based *South China Morning Post* reported earlier. Zhang was also a member of the 24-member Politburo. The other senior official, Liu, was a CMC member who served as the chief of staff of the Joint Staff Department.

RUSSIAN ELECTIONS

Pro-Putin party holds Parliament with record 355 seats, anti-war party gains tiny regional foothold

Reuters
Moscow, September 21

THE PRO-Putin ruling United Russia party won a record number of seats in the national parliament, according to near-complete official election results on Monday, while the anti-war Yabloko party appeared to have won a tiny foothold in one regional parliament. President Vladimir Putin had cast the three-day election to the State Duma — the first since Russia launched its full-scale war in Ukraine in February 2022 — as a test of support for the war. Elections for some regional parliaments and governors were held at the same time. In a tightly controlled political system, which critics say does not tolerate genuine dissent, under which many of Yabloko's candidates were barred, few surprises were expected. With over 95% of the vote counted, Ella Pamfilova, chair of the Central Electoral Commission, said United Russia had scored 57.83%, up from the



Senior members of Russia's ruling United Russia party, at the party's headquarters in Moscow on Sunday. REUTERS

49.8% that it won in the last parliamentary election, in 2021. United Russia was set to control 355 seats or nearly 80% of the 450-seat Duma, a total that includes results in individual constituencies. It would also be an all-time high, outstripping its 2016 record of 343 seats. Yabloko, the only registered anti-war party in Russia, failed to win any seats at a national level, but in Novgorod with it appeared to have cleared the 5% barrier by one percentage point to enter the regional parliament.

Moscow oil refinery output halted after drone strike, fires

Moscow: Russia's major Moscow refinery, owned by Gazprom Neft, has halted crude oil processing after fires broke out at its primary crude distillation units following a Ukrainian drone attack on September 20, three industry sources said. Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said on Telegram on Sunday morning that an industrial facility on the refinery's premises had been damaged during a drone raid on the Russian capital. The sources told Reuters on Monday that both of the refinery's primary crude distillation units caught fire after drones crashed onto the site and that it could take several weeks to repair the damage and restore operations. Gazprom Neft did not immediately respond to a *Reuters* request for comment. **REUTERS**

South African investigative journalist goes missing in Djibouti

Johannesburg: South African investigative journalist Micah Reddy has gone missing in Djibouti while on a reporting trip, his family said on Sunday, adding that they have received no information from authorities about his whereabouts since he was last heard from on Saturday. Reddy, the Africa editor for the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ), arrived in the Horn of Africa nation Thursday and had been in regular contact with family and colleagues before communication abruptly ceased, his brother Niall Reddy said Sunday. "We don't have any clear updates on his status," Niall said. The Committee to Protect Journalists watchdog said it was "increasingly alarmed" that over 24 hours had elapsed since anyone was able to reach Reddy or his fixer, Kooki Mahmoud. "CPJ understands their reporting was not focused on Djibouti and urges Djiboutian authorities to establish their whereabouts, confirm safety, and promptly release them if detained," said Angela Quintal, CPJ Africa Director. **REUTERS**

Pakistan says it killed 28 militants; Afghan Taliban, UN report 3 civilian deaths

Reuters
Kabul, Islamabad, September 21

PAKISTAN'S GOVERNMENT said Monday it launched airstrikes in the Afghanistan-Pakistan border region, killing at least 28 militants, with one security official saying two Afghan provinces were targeted. Hours earlier, Afghan Taliban officials accused Islamabad of killing at least three civilians in overnight airstrikes on Afghan territory. The UN Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) confirmed the deaths of three civilians: a man, a woman and a girl. The attacks broke nearly three months of relative calm. Zabihullah Mujahid, chief spokesperson of the Taliban-run Afghan government, said the Afghan side "will respond appropriately to this aggression". A Pakistani official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said the strikes happened in the Afghan provinces of Paktika and Kunar. Pakistan's Information Ministry gave the death toll but its military did not comment. Relations between the



A man retrieves belongings from the debris of a house that was damaged in an airstrike in Kunar province, Afghanistan, on Sunday. REUTERS

former allies have been strained for years, with Islamabad accusing Kabul of harbouring militants who stage cross-border attacks. Conflict escalated this February and hundreds died in airstrikes, drone attacks, and artillery fire in the first half of the year. Afghanistan's Taliban government denies harbouring anti-Pakistani insurgents and says militancy is Pakistan's internal problem. The Taliban's Foreign Ministry said it had summoned Pakistan's chargé d'affaires in Kabul and handed him a protest note.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Supermodel Cindy Crawford's son Presley Gerber dies aged 27



Presley Gerber. FILE

pearances for brands such as Calvin Klein and Dolce & Gabbana. In 2018, he appeared alongside his mother in Pepsi's Super Bowl LII commercial. **REUTERS**

EUROPEAN UNION

EU hits Google with \$463mn fine

GOOGLE HAS been fined \$463 million for breaching the EU's strict privacy rules because it mishandled users' location data, the bloc's data privacy watchdog said Monday. Ireland's Data Protection Commission said its probe found Google did not lawfully or fairly process location data in users' Web & App Activity, a setting that tracks browsing history. **AP**

UNITED KINGDOM

Technical glitch disrupts flights

A TECHNICAL issue disrupted flights in and out of Scotland, Northern Ireland and the north of England on Monday. Though NATS, formerly known as National Air Traffic Services, said the issue at its Prestwick center in Scotland has been fixed, the repercussions will continue to be felt through the day with multiple flights cancelled or delayed. **AP**

• 98% OF SCHOOLS WERE EITHER DESTROYED OR DAMAGED IN WAR; 660,000 STUDENTS HAVE BEEN DEPRIVED OF IN-PERSON LEARNING, SAYS UNICEF

Gaza children return to class after nearly 3 years, but schools in ruins, supplies unaffordable

Nidal Al-Mughrabi, Haseeb & Alwazeer
Cairo, Gaza, September 1

HUNDREDS OF thousands of children in Gaza returned to in-person teaching on Saturday for the first time in nearly three years, albeit in damaged or makeshift school buildings and tents, and with uniforms, notebooks and pens unaffordable for many families. The United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) says 98% of schools in Gaza were either destroyed or damaged during the war, and Gaza education officials say about 660,000 students have been deprived of in-person learning

and regular participation in education. The reopening is a fragile milestone for Gaza after a conflict that has killed around 22,000 students and more than 770 education workers, including 532 teachers, according to Ibrahim Ramadan, the director of education for East Khan Younis. "The last time I have been to school was three years ago. Now, we are starting the school year, it is year of joy, happiness and success," said Moayed Abu Mustafa in Khan Younis. Mustafa said he was determined to learn even though he will sit on the floor in a tent lacking ventilation, he has no

decent shoes, nor a notebook and pen, and lost friends during the war. "Despite all of this we will learn, we will learn even in a tent." Fifteen-year-old displaced student Samar Abu Salmi, who lives with her family in a tent, is also returning to class. "We studied on phones and we haven't seen our teachers... now, we are back pursuing our dream... from one tent to another," she said, speaking in the yard of her new makeshift school. She also lacks much of the essential equipment, which has become unaffordable for her family. "Before the war, everything was available for us -



Palestinian students attend the first day of school year inside a tent classroom in Khan Younis, in southern Gaza Strip. REUTERS

notebooks, pens, goods, clothes, outings, things that we could get cheaply," Salmi said. Despite the devastation in

the enclave, the Ministry of Education, backed by international and local organisations, has moved ahead with the

2026-27 academic year, establishing dozens of temporary schools made of tents, tarpaulins, sheet metal and wood to accommodate pupils. Some are built on sandy ground, others have classrooms with only some mattresses and a blackboard, into which students cram. Others are still housing dozens of displaced families. Attending another school was 14-year-old Yamen Abu Samra. "We used to wake up happy to go to school... Now, when we come to school, we're afraid of stray bullets, rockets, strikes, everything," he said. "Now, I'm sitting in a tent that has absolutely nothing,

just the sun and the heat," he added. At least 540,000 students are expected to attend in-person classes this year in makeshift private schools, temporary learning centres and educational points, with UNICEF support, according to education officials. Online learning will continue for those who can't attend classes or who left Gaza during the war. Israeli forces remain in control of more than 60% of Gaza despite last year's ceasefire, which halted major fighting but failed to end the conflict. Palestinian authorities say more than 73,000 people have been killed in Israel's assault on Gaza, launched after Hamas-

led fighters killed about 1,200 people in southern Israel in October 2023. Stationery trader Khaled Aliyan, 30, said Israeli import restrictions have reduced supplies and hiked prices. "This notebook, which used to cost 3 shekels (\$1), now costs 15 (shekels). All stationery items are expensive," he said. Israel's COGAT military agency, which controls access to Gaza, did not respond to a Reuters request for comment on restrictions on supplies and strikes on schools. Israel has repeatedly accused Hamas of using schools for military purposes, which Hamas denies. **REUTERS**



The covered television positions for CNN on the North Lawn of the White House on Monday. AP

Networks suspend pool coverage of Trump after White House bars CNN

Michael M Grynbbaum & Ali Watkins
September 21

MAJOR TELEVISION networks agreed to suspend their pooled coverage of President Donald Trump after the White House refused to allow CNN to serve as a pool representative Monday.

The move is an extraordinary escalation of an unfolding showdown between the Trump administration and the White House press corps, which began last week when the president barred journalists at CNN, MS NOW and Politico from entering the White House grounds. Those three outlets said Monday they would sue to regain access.

Despite Trump's years of lawsuits and threats against news media, archival news organizations have rarely undertaken this kind of collective action.

Five networks — ABC, CBS, CNN, Fox News and NBC — have long shared the responsibility of providing television coverage of presidential events, splitting the financial costs and distributing footage that is carried by news organizations worldwide. The networks perform their duties on a rotation, and CNN had been slated to provide coverage for Trump's travel on Monday to the UN

General Assembly. It is extremely unusual for a president to travel or hold public events without being accompanied by representatives from the television pool. The president's activities on Monday are still expected to be covered by print, radio and wire journalists, along with still photographers. "Effective today, the TV pool will not be covering events designated as pool coverage of the President," Bryan Boughton, the Washington bureau chief at Fox News, wrote in a note to television pool members Monday, which was obtained by *The New York Times*. (Boughton is the acting chair of television pool consortium; networks rotate chairmanship on a quarterly basis.) "This follows White House's position preventing CNN from fulfilling its assigned pool duties," Boughton wrote. "There will be no replacement pool put in place. All other pool coverage will continue as normal. We will provide updates as this situation develops." The five networks later issued a joint statement, writing: "The public has a vital interest in receiving accurate, independent information about its government. No administration should restrict a news organization because it objects to its reporting."

IN DOUBLE DEFLATION, INPUT AND OUTPUT PRICES ARE ADJUSTED SEPARATELY TO COMPUTE REAL GVA

New GDP series: 28 out of 30 mfg categories used double deflation

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 21

THE NEW GDP series used the ‘double deflation’ method in 28 of 30 categories for the manufacturing sector, the statistics ministry’s ‘Sources and Methods’ document, released on Monday, said. It added that work is on so that double deflation can be used in the remaining two categories too.

The two categories for which double deflation has not been used are ‘production, processing and preservation of meat, fish, fruit, vegetables, oils and fats’ and ‘manufacture of pharmaceutical; medicinal chemicals and botanical products’.

In these two categories, the share of imported inputs is high. This makes it “challenging” to directly map input items with their elementary, item-level output Producer Price Index, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said.

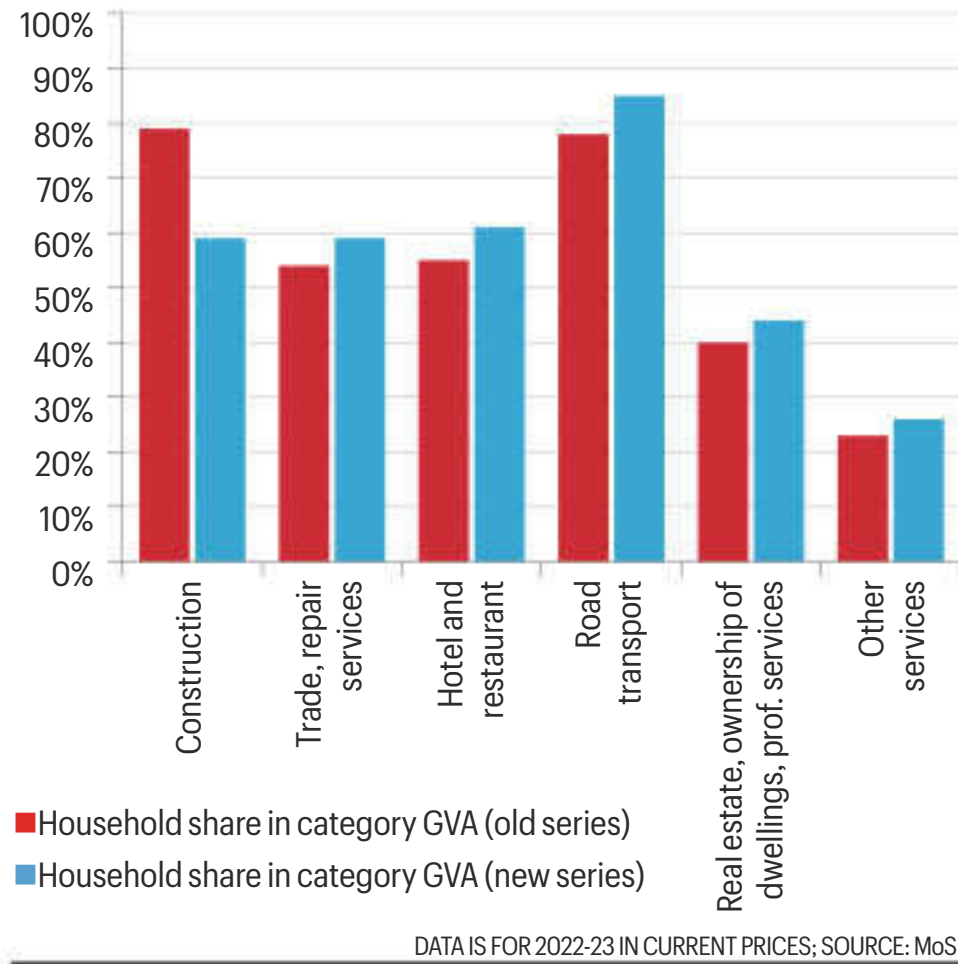
To find the value added by a sector — or the Gross Value Added (GVA) — the value of inputs it uses is subtracted from the value of output it produces. This is GVA in current prices, or nominal terms. To find the

GVA after accounting for changes in prices — or real GVA — the output and input values are adjusted by their respective inflation rates. This is called double deflation.

Prior to the new GDP series, which has 2022-23 as the base year, that was released earlier this year in February, one of the biggest criticisms of Indian data was MoSPI used double deflation only for agriculture and mining and quarrying sectors. For the others, input and output values were ‘deflated’ by the same number, with the Wholesale Price Index and Consumer Price Index being used. This can be problematic when input and output prices change at different rates. As such, double deflation results in better estimates of real growth.

The publication of the ‘Sources and Methods for Compilation of National Accounts Statistics’ comes seven months after the release of the new GDP series with 2022-23 as the base year. This, MoSPI said, is the shortest time it has ever taken to release the full document. Previously, the full document has taken up to three years to be released after the publication of a new GDP series.

• Trade, hotels more informal in new series



The document brings together the concepts, definitions, data sources, methodologies, and compilation practices used in the new GDP series. It does not contain new data and brings together the recommendations of three reports of sub-committees of the

Advisory Committee on National Accounts Statistics. These reports — on methodological improvement for the base revision of GDP, constant price estimates’, and incorporation of new data sources, rates and ratios — were published back in February.

Smaller informal sector

The new GDP series has been criticised for its downward revision of nominal GDP in previous years, which reduced the size of the economy. Specifically, a lower nominal GDP in April-June 2025 has been seen by some as a way to show the faster-than-expected 7.8% real growth in April-June 2026.

Under the new series, the nominal GVA attributed to ‘households’ — the proxy for the informal sector — was reduced by Rs 2.9 lakh crore in 2022-23 compared to the old series. This amounts to a 2.7% decline.

The other two sectors are public sector and private sector.

The downward revision in household sector GVA in 2022-23 was led by construction. Under the new series, the share of the household sector in construction GVA fell to 59% from 79% in the old series, suggesting the construction sector may be more formal than previously thought. On the other hand, some other segments are more informal than what was earlier estimated: trade and repair services, hotels and restaurants, and road transport among them.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

India-NZ FTA to kick in on Oct 20

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, September 21

THE INDIA-NEW Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) will come into force October 20, 2026, opening a new phase in the bilateral economic relationship backed by a New Zealand commitment to facilitate \$20 billion of investment in India over the next 15 years.

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and New Zealand Trade and Investment Minister Todd McClay announced the October 20 implementation date at a video conference, describing the pact as a major milestone in the economic partnership between the two countries.

The FTA follows the signing of the agreement in New Delhi on April 27 and New Zealand’s passage of legislation giving effect to the pact on September 16. The countries have also set an ambitious objective of doubling



Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal with members of New Zealand delegation. X/PIYUSHGOYAL

bilateral trade in goods and services, with Goyal putting the target at around Rs 35,000 crore over the next four to five years.

The date coincides with Vijaya Dashami (Dussehra), which Goyal described as an auspicious occasion for beginning a partnership. He said the agreement would help remove barriers to trade, promote investment and technology sharing and create opportunities for

businesses, farmers, exporters, micro, small, and medium enterprises, professionals and consumers in both countries.

The FTA provides zero-duty access to New Zealand for 100% of Indian exports from the date of entry into force. Key Indian export sectors expected to benefit include textiles and apparel, leather and footwear, engineering goods, pharmaceuticals, agriculture and processed foods. FE

Examining US tariff law on Russian oil purchase, says Goyal

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, September 21

INDIA IS examining the details of the new US legislation that gives President Donald Trump the power to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries buying Russian oil and gas, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

Asked about the government’s backup plan in case Washington imposes additional tariffs on Indian exports, Goyal said, “Details are currently coming; once we have studied them, and at an appropriate time, we will discuss with you.” Trump signed the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 on September 18, giving his administration

a new, Congress-backed instrument to impose tariffs of up to 100% on goods from major buyers of Russian energy.

India and China, among the largest buyers of Russian crude, are potentially exposed to the measure. The law does not automatically impose a 100% tariff on India; it gives the US President authority to determine the countries targeted and the level of tariffs. It will take effect within 30 days, during which the US Trade Representative will identify countries to be targeted and recommend tariff rates. The countries would normally get 180 days to reduce Russian energy purchases or negotiate with Washington, but Trump can shorten the period and impose tariffs sooner. FE

RBI forex swap facility draws \$143.6 bn inflows

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 21

THE RESERVE Bank of India’s (RBI) special US dollar-rupee forex swap facility has attracted \$143.596 billion in foreign currency inflows till September 18, with Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNR(B), deposits accounting for the overwhelming share of the mobilisation.

According to the RBI, latest data reported by authorised dealer banks show that FCNR(B) deposits mobilised under the facility stood at \$132.98 billion, while Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) brought in \$5.32 billion

and External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) \$5.296 billion.

The facility, introduced by the central bank on June 8, was aimed at encouraging fresh foreign currency inflows into the banking system, strengthening the country’s external buffers and supporting domestic liquidity. Under the arrangement, banks could mobilise fresh three-to-five-year FCNR(B) deposits and swap the foreign currency with the RBI at a concessional rate, thus reducing hedging cost for banks.

The RBI decided to close the window for fresh FCNR(B) deposits on August 31.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Govt plans steps to minimise bank strike disruption

New Delhi: Drawing up a contingency plan to minimise disruptions from the September 28-30 bank strike, the Finance Ministry on Monday wrote to the RBI and PSU banks to keep strategic branches open, operate on the coming Sunday, and ensure higher ATM cash stocks, among other measures.

The United Forum of Bank Unions and other unions have called a three-day strike in support of various demands, including a five-day work week and uniform pension in the banking sector.

The strike coincides with the half-yearly closing of banks on September 30. FE



Dimon meets Sitharaman

Jamie Dimon, Chairman and CEO of JP Morgan Chase & Co, interacts with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman during the JP Morgan India Investor Conference in Mumbai, Maharashtra, on Monday. X/NSITHARAMANOFFC

• THE NEW ENTITY TO BE MAJORITY-OWNED BY INDIAN SHAREHOLDERS AND HEADQUARTERED IN THE COUNTRY

Nothing to spin off CMF as standalone Indian company

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 21

SMARTPHONE MAKER Nothing’s Co-founder and Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Carl Pei has said the company will spin off its CMF sub-brand into a standalone Indian company, with the new entity to be majority-owned by Indian shareholders and headquartered in the country. Nothing will retain a stake and continue as a shareholder and partner, while CMF will have its own team, and research and development (R&D) operations in India.

In an open letter, Pei said the move aims to build a global consumer electronics brand from

India, arguing that the country’s next stage of growth in the sector would have to go beyond manufacturing and focus on product engineering, R&D and intellectual property.

“CMF becomes Indian,” Pei said, adding that the new company would be “majority Indian owned, headquartered in India, with its own team and R&D in the country”. Nothing’s engineering capabilities, operating system, supplier relationships, and global brand infrastructure would continue to be part of the partnership. Pei’s announcement comes shortly after the government notified its new Rs 62,500 crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme, which



Carl Pei, Co-founder and CEO of Nothing. REUTERS

seeks to push Indian-owned mobile phone brands, domestic design, and R&D.

The scheme has two target segments: one for mobile phone manufacturing and another

specifically for Indian brands. Under the Indian-brand segment, eligible companies can receive an incentive of 5% on eligible sales, along with an additional 3% incentive linked

to Indian design and R&D. There is also an additional incentive of up to 1.5% for domestic sourcing of key components and sub-assemblies. To qualify as an Indian brand under the scheme, a company must be incorporated in the country, hold its intellectual property and trademark in India, have management control with Indian citizens and have over 51% shareholding held by Indian citizens. It must also have in-house R&D and design capabilities in the country.

The Centre has said the scheme is intended to move India beyond being a manufacturing base and encourage Indian ownership of brands, technology and intellectual property.

Why Tata Sons directors made a big U-turn in 2026

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 21

THE TATA Sons board decision to pursue listing, backed by a majority of four directors, marks a sharp reversal from their stance two years ago, when the same directors favoured keeping it unlisted.

What changed between March 2024 and September 17, 2026 on the issue of ‘Tata Sons’ listing, the holding company of Tata Group? In March 2024, while Ratan Tata was alive, its board considered the public listing issue and, as per Tata Trusts, unanimously decided that it should remain unlisted.

The decision was backed by Harish Manwani, Anita M George, Venu Srinivasan, and Saurabh Agrawal.

On September 17, 2026, the same directors voted in favour of taking steps to pursue the listing of Tata Sons, marking a dramatic reversal of the position in March 2024

The reversal also comes against an explicit decision by the Trusts. In July 2025, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and Sir Ratan Tata Trust unanimously resolved that Tata Sons should remain unlisted. The decision was communicated to Tata Sons for necessary action, and Venu Srinivasan favoured the resolutions. But in a striking shift in stance, he backed the board’s decision to pursue listing on September 17.

On RBI’s directive to Tata Sons over guideline compliance, Noel Tata said in a note to the board, “It does not mention listing. It prescribes no particular step, and it does not say that the company is in breach. What its legal effect is, and what it requires of this company and by when, are questions upon which this board has formed no view.”

When contacted, Tata Sons and the four directors did not comment on their decision. “In March 2024, Tata Sons repaid all debt and sought exemption from listing. Earlier this month, the RBI rejected the application based on the regulations and asked the company to comply with regulations. This is the con-

NSE IPO gets Rs 90k cr bids, subscribed 5.7x

Mumbai: The much-awaited initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) closed on Monday with the issue receiving bids worth around Rs 90,000 crore, reflecting strong demand from institutional and high-net-worth investors. The IPO was subscribed about 5.7 times overall, with investors bidding for more than 50 crore equity shares against around 8.86 crore shares on offer, according to data available on the exchanges.

The issue attracted about 38.5 lakh applications, underlining the broad investor interest in the country’s largest stock exchange and one of the most closely watched listings in the Indian capital market.

The non-institutional investor portion was subscribed 6.55 times, while retail investor portion was subscribed around 1.4 times. The employee quota was subscribed about 2.4 times. Qualified institutional buyers (QIBs) led the demand, with their portion subscribed 12.68 times. QIBs placed bids for around 31.97 crore shares, compared with about 2.52 crore shares reserved for the category.

The listing marks the culmination of a long-delayed attempt by the exchange to enter the public markets. ENS

• LISTING ROW

IN MARCH 2024, the Tata Sons board had considered the question of public listing and unanimously concluded that it should remain unlisted

THE DECISION was backed by Harish Manwani, Anita M George, Venu Srinivasan, and Saurabh Agrawal

ON SEPTEMBER 17, 2026, the same directors voted in favour of taking steps to pursue the listing of Tata Sons, marking a dramatic reversal of the position in March 2024

text,” said a Tata Group source. Tata Trusts Chair Noel Tata wrote to Tata Sons on Friday stating that resolutions okayed by the board Thursday were null and void ab initio and of no legal relevance, and asked the company to give an explanation and correction, as per the sources.

The reversal also comes against an explicit decision by the Trusts. In July 2025, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and Sir Ratan Tata Trust unanimously resolved that Tata Sons should remain unlisted.

The decision was communicated to Tata Sons for necessary action, and Venu Srinivasan favoured the resolutions. But in a striking shift in stance, he backed the board’s decision to pursue listing on September 17. On RBI’s directive to Tata Sons over guideline compliance, Noel Tata said in a note to the board, “It does not mention listing. It prescribes no particular step, and it does not say that the company is in breach. What its legal effect is, and what it requires of this company and by when, are questions upon which this board has formed no view.”

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• BRIEFLY

Core sector growth slows to 4.8% in August

New Delhi: Growth in the output of India’s core industries fell to a three-month low of 4.8% in August. Six of the nine sectors saw slower growth last month, data released by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade on Monday showed. The six core sectors, where output growth was slower in August compared to July, account for over 44% of the Index of Core Industries. FE

Maruti eyes 30% female intake at Manesar by FY29

New Delhi: Maruti Suzuki India aims to increase the female student intake at its Japan-India Institute for Manufacturing at Manesar to 30% by the Academic Year 2028-29, in a bid to enhance women’s participation in India’s automotive manufacturing workforce. The automaker currently has a 9% female student intake at its Manesar institute. It has introduced a fee waiver for female students from the current academic year. PTI

Some RWAs to self-fill income survey as pilot

New Delhi: To ensure participation of rich households in the ongoing National Household Income Survey, the statistics ministry is relaxing the timeline for respondents in gated societies. “Many of them would like to fill the questionnaire at their leisure... So, we are also giving that option to some households in these gated communities on a pilot basis,” Secretary Saurabh Garg said. FE

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▼	US Dollar ▼
74,858.99	23,414.30	₹1,53,337	₹95.82
564.03	6790	Silver ▼	Oil ▼
0.76%	0.29%	₹2,34,992	\$123.86

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA
GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 18, 2026

बैंक ऑफ बरौडा
Bank of Baroda

B. T. ROAD BRANCH
94/1, B. T. Road, Kolkata - 700 090

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable property/ies)

As per Appendix IV read with rule 8(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorised Officer of the "Bank of Baroda" under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated **07.05.2026**, calling upon the **Borrower- Mrs. Sulekha Das, W/o- Ranjit Das and Mr. Subrata Das, S/o- Mr. Ranjit Das, Both of Add-207/135, BT Road, Mallick Colony, PO & PS- Baranagar, Kolkata- 700036 (WB)** to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.5,09,977.00/- (Rupees- Five Lakh Nine Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy Seven Only)** as on **30/04/2026**, together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate plus costs, charges and expenses till date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the Public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under sub-section (4) of section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on this the day of **19th Day of September the year 2026**.

The Borrower's attention is invited to provision of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the **Bank of Baroda, BT Road Branch for an amount of Rs.5,09,977.00/- (Rupees- Five Lakh Nine Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy Seven Only) and plus int. and charges w.e.i. 01.05.2026**.

Description of the Immovable Property

1st Schedule of land: All that piece and parcel of Bastu land measuring about 2 cottahs 2 chittaks 34 sq. ft. be the same little more or less along with newly constructed G+3 storied without lift building standing there on lying and situated in Mouza Baranagar, Khatian no 7530 containing Dg no. 1836/2110 and 1836/2111, J. L. No. 5 R No. 6, Touzi no. 1068/2833, Division-I Sub division 7, Holding no 761, PS.- Baranagar, within Baranagar Municipality premises no 10/3, barrister P Mitra Road, P.O.- Alambazar, PS.- Baranagar, Kolkata 700035 within the ward no 11 of Baranagar, Municipality within the jurisdiction of A D S R O Cossipore, Dumdum in the district of North 24 Parganas together with all casement rightover the common roads, paths in the amenities. **Buttled and bounded:** On the north: Common passage. On the south: Municipal Road, On the east: Municipal Road, On the west: common passage.

2nd Schedule of mortgaged Flat: All that self-contained flat at the 1st floor south side having super built up area of 855 sq. ft. more or less including proportionate share of stair case and landing containing 2 bedrooms 1 dining space with kitchen. Bath & privy and one balcony at premises no 10/3, Barrister P Mitra Road, P.O.- Alambazar, PS.- Baranagar. Kolkata 700035 together with proportional share in land described in the first schedule writtensub and together with proportionate share in and described in the first schedule writtensub and together with common parts and portions and together with all other rights liberties easements appertaining thereto bring Deed No 1-150602908, Book no. 1, volume no 1506-2017, pages no 85381 to 85416 for the year 2017 A.D.S.R.O.Cossipore. Dumdum property stands in the name of (1) Mrs. Sulekha Das, w/o.- Ranjit Das & Mr. Subrata Das, S/o.- Ranjit Das.

Date: 19.09.2026

Place: Kolkata

Chief Manager/Authorised Officer

Bank of Baroda



बैंक ऑफ़ बड़ोदा
Bank of Baroda

TALAPARK BRANCH
29/11A, Northern Avenue, Kolkata-700030

**E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE**

ANNEXURE-A

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES
"APPENDIX- IV-A [See proviso to Rule 8 (6) & or 9(1)]"

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & or 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s), Mortgagor(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of **Bank of Baroda**, Secured Creditor, will be sold on "**As is where is**", "**As is what is**" and "**Whatever there is**" basis for recovery of dues in below mentioned account/s. The details of Borrower/Mortgagor/Guarantor/Secured Asset/s/Dues/Reserve Price/E-auction date & Time, EMD and Bid Increase Amount are mentioned below:

Sr/ Lot No.	Name & address of Borrower/s/ Guarantor/s / Mortgagor (s)	Detailed description of the immovable property with known encumbrances, if any	Total Dues	Date & Time of E-auction	Reserve Price EMD amount Bid Increase Amount	Status of Possession (Symbolic / Physical)	Property Inspection date & Time
1	TANMOY DASGUPTA Address- House No.-168, Bidhan Park, Barasat, North 24 Parganas, Pin-700124 (West Bengal)	All Piece and Parcel of Equitable Mortgage of Bastu Land lying and Situated within Mouza- Murali A.D.S.R. Office Kadambagachi, Touzi No -12, J.L. No - 99, L. R. Dag No - 812, L.R. Khatian No - 265 and 580, Measuring About 01 Cottah 13 Chittacks 00 Sq. Ft. , within P. S – Duttapukur, under Choto Jagulia Gram Panchayat, Municipality City – Barasat - I, District- North 24 Parganas, West Bengal - 743248, property in the name of Mr. Tanmoy Dasgupta, Vide Deed No. I-1788/24. Butted and Bounded as follows: On the North By : 6' Ft wide common Passage, On the South By :Other's Property , On the East By : Land of Bapi Saha, On the West By : Owner's Property and 8 Feet wide road	Rs. 13,41,164.30 and as on 20.12.2025 (inclusive of interest up to 13.12.2025) and unapplied interest thereon and other charges at the contractual rate plus costs, charges and expenses till date of payment	28/10/2026 Time- 2.00pm to 6.00pm	i. Rs.10,59,000/- ii. Rs.1,05,900/- iii. Rs.20,000/-	Physical	Any working Day 3:00pm- 5:00pm Concerned Officer- Mobile- 9903198218 (with prior appointment)

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer/link to the websites link <https://www.bankofbaroda.bank.in/e-auction.htm> and online auction portal <https://baanet.net>. Also, prospective bidders may contact the authorized officer on Mobile 9903198218

Date: 21.09.2026
Place: Kolkata

(Ritesh Kumar Verma)
Authorized officer, Bank of Baroda

WHEREAS, The undersigned being the Authorised Officer of M/s. Cholamandalam Investment And Finance Company Limited, under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 hereinafter called the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rules 3 of the Security Interest [Enforcement] Rules, 2002 issued demand notices on the date mentioned the account calling upon the respective Borrowers, to repay the outstanding amount with interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrowers having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers in particular and the Public in general that the undersigned has taken Physical Possession of the properties mortgaged with the Company described herein below on the respective dates mentioned against each account in exercise of the powers conferred on him under Section 13(4) of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Rules made there under. The Borrowers in particular and the Public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties mentioned herein below and any such dealings will be subject to the charge of Cholamandalam Investment And Finance Company Limited for an amount mentioned against each account along with interest and other charges. Under section 13(8) of the Securitisation Act, the borrowers can redeem the secured asset by payment of the entire outstanding including all costs, charges, and expenses, before notification of Sale.			
Sl. No.	NAME AND ADDRESS OF BORROWER & LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER	DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY	A) DATE OF DEMAND NOTICE B) OUTSTANDING AMOUNT C) DATE OF PHYSICAL POSSESSION
1.	Loan Account No. : ML01KSN00000069231 1. All the Legal Heirs of Bijay Sarkar (Applicant) Chichuria, Purbapar Chichuria, Nakashipara Nadia, West Bengal, Pin - 741126 2. Mausumi Sarkar (Co-Appllicant) C/o, Bijay Sarkar, Chichuria, Purbapar Chichuria Nakashipara, Nadia, West Bengal, Pin - 741126 3. Jay Fashion (Co-Appllicant) West Jagadanandapur, Nakashipara, Bethua Dahari, Nadia, West Bengal, Pin - 741126	All that plot of Land ad measuring more or less 06.6 Decimal forming part of R. S. and L. R. Dag No. 3508, L. R. Khatian No. 6305, Mouza - Chichuriya, J. L. No. 42, P. S. Nakashipara, ADSR - Bethuadahari within the limits of Bethuadahari 2 No. Gram Panchayat, District : Nadia, butted and bounded by on North : Property of Bapi Sarkar, South : Property of Shyamsundar Bhowmick, East : Village Road and West : Property of Shyamsundar Bhowmick.	A) 08.09.2025 B) Rs. 41,34,525.00 (Rupees Forty One Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Five Hundred Twenty Five only) as on 08.09.2025 and interest thereon C) Date of Physical Possession : 17.09.2026
Date : 22.09.2026 Place : Nadia (West Bengal)		Authorised Officer Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Limited	

पंजाब नैशनल बैंक

punjab national bank

...भरोसे का प्रतीक !

...the name you can BANK upon !

APPENDIX IV

[See Rule 8(1)]

POSSESSION NOTICE

(For Immovable property)

Circle Office Kharagpur, SAM Dept, 4th Floor, MS Tower 2, Near HP Petrol Pump ,Atwal Real Estate, OT Road, Inda, Kharagpur, Paschim Medinipur Pin 721305. , e mail: cckgpsam@pnb.bank.in

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Punjab National Bank under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of Powers conferred under Section 13 read with the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a demand notice dated calling upon the borrowers and Mortgageors to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being with further interest within 60 days from the date of notice/date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower/ guarantor, and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules on the below mentioned dates. The borrower's /guarantor's /mortgagor's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets. The borrower/guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Punjab National Bank for an amount with interest thereon.			
Sl. No.	a) Name of The Borrower / Guarantor b) Branch Name	Description of the Immovable Property	a) Date of Demand Notice b) Date of Possession c) Amount Outstanding
1.	a) Borrowers and Mortgagors Harekrishna Dhal & Upasi Dhal b) BO: Bagasthi (068220)	Residential Individual House, 0.0475 acres, Land & Building at Mouza: Kusumpur, JL No: 30, LR Khatian No: 440, LR Plot No: 97 under PS Keshiary, ADSR: Kharagpur, Paschim Medinipur, West Bengal, 721101. Bounded By: - North:Concrete Road, South:property of Mrs Tapati Singh, East:Basu Land on Plot No 1080, West:Property of Mrs. Draupadi Singh, Ownership:Guarantor Document No:8681, Document Date:22.05.2013	a) 29.06.2026 b) 18.09.2026 c) Rs. 33,06,185.93 (Rupees Thirty-Three Lakh Six Thousand One Hundred Eighty-Five and Ninety-Three Paise Only) with interest thereon.
Date : 18.09.2026 Place : Kharagpur, Paschim Medinipur		CO SAM, Kharagpur, Authorized Officer, Punjab National Bank	

Rowers threaten to go on ‘strike’ after last-minute crew changes



Balraj Panwar (above) was moved from quadruple to single sculls. FILE

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 21

LEADING INDIAN men's rowers have threatened to go on strike at the Asian Games and not train on Tuesday after the team management's decision to change crews on Monday.

The changes were made two days before the rowing competitions at the Asian Games are scheduled to begin on September 23. The events were originally scheduled to start on Sep-

tember 20 but were postponed due to the impending typhoon Dujan along the Pacific coast.

According to a source, the team management made several changes to the entries after Monday morning's training session, with rowers moved between events and a reserve player brought into the team.

"Some of the rowers said they would go on a strike. There are efforts going on right now to sort out the situation and ensure the practice session takes

place as scheduled tomorrow," a source said. "It is a risk to change crews so late, but whatever decision the team management has taken, it is to ensure that best teams are entered into the competition."

Navdeep Singh and Kulwinder Singh, who were entered in the men's doubles sculls, were moved to the quadruple sculls. Salman and Satnam, who were part of the quadruple sculls, were moved to the double sculls.

Balraj Panwar was moved from the quadruple sculls to the single sculls, while Arvind Singh was moved out of the single sculls and into the quadruple sculls. Vipul Ghurde was moved from the men's pair to the coxless four, with reserve Saurav Kumar dropped from the event. Jasmail Singh, who was a reserve, was brought into the coxless four.

Nitin Kumar and Jaswinder Singh, who had been part of the coxless four, were moved into

the men's pair. The changes came after India's performance at the World Championships immediately before the Asian Games.

A senior rowing official said 50 per cent of a crew can be changed in the event of a medical emergency. The rowers have questioned the changes made in the absence of such an emergency. India won five medals at the 2022 Asian Games, with two silver and three bronze.

An accidental marksman, now Asiad silver medallist

Himanshu tried wrestling for a few days, farmed rice in the Haryana heat, then picked up a rifle at his school range



Mihir Vasavda
Toyota City, September 21

WRESTLING WAS supposed to be Himanshu Dhillon's inheritance. Farming was what his father thought might teach him the value of hard work. Shooting, he chose because it looked easy. None of it turned out quite as expected.

On Monday, after a roller-coaster final in which he moved from outside the medal positions to the top of the standings, slipped to bronze and recovered to finish with silver at the Asian Games, Himanshu discovered just how wrong that first impression had been. "When you stand there and your mind starts running, it gets intense," he tells *The Indian Express*. "I realised this the very day I went there for shooting. Only then did I see how it really is."

Himanshu, who celebrated his 21st birthday on Monday, had seen his uncle wrestle at the Rio Olympics in the 98kg Greco-Roman category. Hardeep Singh Dhillon's Olympic journey had inspired his younger brother Shamsher, who hoped his son could take the family's wrestling story one step further. So Himanshu gave wrestling a shot. He, however, lasted a few days. "The sore muscles and, his ear got slightly injured," Shamsher recalls. "Because of that, he felt, 'No, wrestling is not for me.'"

Himanshu laughs about it now. "It was a bit hard, so I left it." His father soon gave him another perspective. During the Covid lockdowns, Shamsher began taking him to their farmland. There was rice farming to be done, *jiri*, as they call it in Haryana, and fields

to clear in the afternoon heat. "We worked in the afternoon heat around 1 or 2pm and then came back. So that's why I chose this today!" Himanshu jokes.

The joke only goes so far. Shooting would demand its own form of endurance. There was no family shooting tradition. The beginning was almost accidental.

Himanshu was studying at a Gurukul in Kundri, near his home. The school had a shooting range, and he went there

with his friends simply for fun. His first shot on target, he remembers, was a forgettable 1. In a sport that demanded precision, and where medals are decided by decimals, a 1 was a brutal introduction.

At that point, shooting was not something he imagined doing for a living. Within five or six months, however, he had covered ground that took other children a year or more. Coach Kuldeep Nehra saw something and called Shamsher. "We need to buy a rifle," he told him.

The price was Rs 3 lakh. Shamsher, a manager with an agriculture company and the family's sole earning member, was stunned. "I said, 'That expensive?' I came from a middle-class family and work a private job, so that wasn't easy."

He borrowed money from a local arthia, or commission agent, bought the rifle and repaid the loan after the harvest. The investment continued. Shamsher shifted from Karnal to Kaithal, where Himanshu

trained, and began living in a rented house. He says he has put his life's savings into his son's career. "I had been continuously investing everything in him for six to seven years," he says.

There were moments when he wondered how long it could continue. Last year, with Himanshu still without a job, Shamsher wanted him to find employment partly to ease the financial burden. The family is joint, with four children, his parents and his brother also living together.

Help eventually came from MP Naveen Jindal, who supported Himanshu with a 14-month scholarship, and later from Olympic Gold Quest. "That was crucial," Shamsher says.

For Himanshu, the pressure, too, increasingly became internal. "I kept thinking about the Asian Games all day long. There were fears, doubts. I wondered if I actually was good enough to compete at this level," he says. In those moments, he turned to his coach Neha Chavan and psychologist Shivam Dwivedi. "They have more confidence in me than I do in myself," he says. "They say, 'You'll nail it, don't worry, we have full confidence in you.' Seeing their confidence makes me feel good, and I feel, 'Yeah, I can do this.'"

At home, Shamsher sent him a motivational video almost every day. On Monday, it was a birthday greeting and a simple wish: win a medal. "Don't be concerned about the colour, get a medal," his father told him. He did. But the medal is only part of what Himanshu is chasing. He wants to leave behind a name that means something to those who come after him.

His inspiration is Virat Kohli, who once spoke about wanting to become the kind of player who made others say, "I want to become a player like him." "I remember those words he said. And I want people to say, 'I want to be a player like Himanshu,' rather than saying, 'Some player named Himanshu came and went.'"

"I kept thinking about the Asian Games all day long. There were fears, doubts. I wondered if I actually was good enough to compete at this level"

HIMANSHU DHILLON,
ASIAN GAMES SILVER MEDALLIST



2018 World Champion Rudranksh Patil had to be content with a bronze medal on Monday. PTI

Patil turns tears and near misses into belated bronze

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 21

"I HAVE cried a lot in the last 12 months."

Rudranksh Patil says it with a smile, almost as a matter of fact, as two medals — a 10m air rifle team silver, and an individual bronze — hang around his neck. The first time was after the 2025 World Championships, where he failed to make the 10m air rifle final. "I wanted to win it twice, but couldn't," says the 2022 world champion. He cried again after finishing fourth at the World Cup Final in Doha.

Then came the National Sports Awards, where Patil expected his body of work to count for something. His name wasn't there. "One of the reasons Gukesh got the Khel Ratna was because he became the youngest (Chess) world champion. I was the youngest in 2022, too, and I saw my other teammates who won a bronze getting it."

Testing times

At the Asian Championships this year, there was a moment when his own practice left him questioning where he was headed. "I was seeing my pathetic state of practice, and I was like, I can't do shooting like that. I need to do something about it."

So he did.

The disappointments became fuel. The fourth places, the awards omission, the bad practice sessions — he could only keep working, stay patient and wait for the results. On Monday, at the Asian Games, one finally came — a bronze he was delighted to have. "Very happy," he said. "A lot of things could have gone wrong, but all of the things worked well. And I would like to look at the positive side compared to the negative."

For long stretches of the 10m air rifle final, Patil looked capable of doing much more than settling for bronze. Like Elavenil Valarivan, who won the women's silver on Sunday, he started strongly. And like Elavenil, he could not sustain that momentum as the final wore on. Himanshu Dhillon's fortunes were even more volatile, swinging from medal-threatening lows to gold-medal hopes and back again.

Patil seized the early lead and refused to let go. Behind him, the Chinese, Koreans and Mongolians scrambled for position until the fight for the podium narrowed to three: Patil, Dhillon and China's Sheng Lihao, who was about to turn his chase into theatre.

There was barely any room for error, and even less room to breathe. Decimals separated the top three, and the standard was so high that on the 11th shot, four shooters — Sheng, Dhillon and South Korea's Shin Minki and Park Hajun — all produced 10.9s. "I haven't seen anything like that," Dhillon sighed.

For a moment, it looked as if the Indians might take over. Dhillon's 10.9 on the 15th shot lifted him into second and brought the prospect of an Indian gold-silver finish into view. It lasted barely a minute.

Sheng had begun quietly, posting 104.9 in his first 10 shots. Not bad, but Patil had been better. Then the 21-year-old began to catch up. Not frantically or spectacularly, but with the cold consistency that has already made him one of the defining rifle shooters of his generation. He had won silver at the Tokyo Olympics aged 16 years and 233 days, becoming the youngest Olympic shooting medallist in history. Three years later, he was Olympic

champion in Paris. He had also won the individual title at the last Asian Games.

Gold chase

He was not about to surrender this one easily. After 16 shots, Sheng had moved back in front, a position he would not relinquish. What followed was almost mechanical. While the Indians searched for a way back, Sheng kept finding the smallest possible margins inside the 10-ring. His next six series all tallied 21.4, a remarkable show of consistency when the stakes were high. Across those 12 shots, he averaged almost 10.7. Shooting from the left corner, he showed no emotion as high 10s kept appearing beside his name one after another.

The Indians had thrown the challenge at him. Sheng simply kept stretching the gap until the Indians wobbled at different junctures. Dhillon's 9.8 and, soon after, Patil's 9.7 gave Sheng the opening he needed. The gold that had seemed within India's grasp was suddenly moving away. The contest had changed again. Sheng was no longer being chased for gold. The last few shots became a study in different kinds of pressure: Dhillon trying to hold off his teammate, Patil refusing to let him get away, and Sheng calmly closing the door on both.

Eventually, the scoreboard settled after 22 shots. Dhillon cemented the second spot, a silver on his Asian Games debut, with a total of 231. Patil pocketed the bronze with a tally of 230.9. He had spent much of the evening chasing a medal of a different colour. In the end, one-tenth was the margin between silver and bronze. But after everything the last year had thrown at him, Patil wasn't complaining.

BRIEFLY

Thai shuttler tests positive at Asiad for furosemide

PITCHAMON OPATNIPUTH has been provisionally suspended at the Asiad after her out-of-competition sample taken on 17 September returned an Adverse Analytical Finding for furosemide, a diuretic. "Furosemide is prohibited under the WADA prohibited list as a S5 diuretic and masking agent. It is prohibited at all times in and out of competition and classified as a specified substance. It can be used by athletes to excrete water for rapid weight loss," an OCA update said. Opatniputh was provisionally suspended pending resolution. She can request the B-sample to be tested and also challenge the provisional suspension. ENS

PACE ISSUES

Why Indian shooters struggle to convert favourable positions into gold medals

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, September 21

IT'S EASY to look at the 10.1 final shot that Elavenil Valarivan hit on Sunday, and the 9.7 that blurted out of the rifle of Rudranksh Patil in the men's event today and diagnose both those attempts with the oft-used, but rarely understood word, pressure.

India's wait for a 10m air rifle gold continued as the medals kept flowing but that elusive yellow metal was not found. Both shooters were in gold-medal winning positions but ended up not hitting the calibre of shots that they were producing through qualification and the finals.

What went wrong in those final eight shots for Ela and Rudranksh?

The answer might be down to how some top Indian shooters pace themselves during a final. Both Elavenil and Rudranksh started off lightning quick in the finals, registering scores of 106 in their first ten shots. To average 10.6 over the first ten shots in the final of a multi-sport event is an incredibly good base. But keeping that same pace, and the concentration it requires, especially in a high-stakes event, is often unsustainable. The result is that while enough has been accumulated for a medal, fighting for gold becomes a matter of just how much is left in the tank.

After her finals, Ela spoke about some of the things that went sideways in her gold quest. "I mean, I could have been a little more patient in taking my shots and possibly worked a little more



Rudranksh Patil with his Asian Games medal. PTI

on my breathing." Later when elaborating on what she needs to work on, she added, "I think finding my pace of shooting in the finals is something that I am still working on. And that is some-



Elavenil Valarivan led the women's 10m air rifle final for 22 shots, before the final two attempts of the day turned sour. PTI

thing that I really want to learn and tune it down more."

There is also the quality of the shooters chasing them. Both Elavenil and Rudranksh lost out on gold to generational

Asian Games performers by Japan's Hinata Taichi and China's Sheng Lihao.

Lihao, at 21, has already established himself as one of the best shooters to ever have

emerged from China. He is an all-weather, freak talent who will win most of the events he finds himself in. His chasedown of Rudranksh was spectacular. After starting 'slow' with 104.9 in his first ten shots, Lihao went nuclear. His next six series of shots — 21.4; 21.4; 21.1; 21.4; 21.4; 21.4 — displayed absurd, almost robotic ability, to thread the barest of margins. His ability to hit the highest 10s at clutch has given him Olympic championships, as also the last Asiad title.

Lihao averaged near 10.7 in that series of twelve shots and finished the finals with a score of 254.2. His final shot average: 10.59. Essentially, every shot that Lihao landed was close to a 10.6 — which is the kind of consistency that's rare for all shooters to achieve, barring himself. India's best showing in individual air rifle has come

through Gagan Narang before Elavenil and Himanshu Dhillon matched him. But the gold has been elusive.

But it was the position that Lihao was in that helped as well. Shooters who start slow but chase down the leading marksman have the advantage of momentum on their side. The shooter leading has to switch their mindset from trying to keep the lead to suddenly finding themselves attempting to win gold with a shot or two to decide the outcome. Usually in those situations, the result goes in favour of the person wielding the momentum of the final.

Psychology of the chase

There is also the format of the final where the first ten shots are taken in two stages of five shots each. And then the next fourteen shots till the final are two at a

time, followed by a break, until the final. Every two shots, a shooter is eliminated.

Stylistically Indian shooters seem to work better when there are five shots with a set time on the board for them. It mirrors their approach to the qualification format and there seems to be a causality between the intense domestic competition that has shaped the psyche of an Indian shooter to be better at qualification and the last fourteen shots of a final where a few decimal points lost end up being the difference.

If a comparison has to be made, Lihao is as good as making two shots in a row with an interruption following, as the Indians are at making five in a row with an interruption following after. But like a home straight sprint of a 1500m race, Lihao canter past a fading Indian.

75 YEARS OF DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS

Japan's Pakistani and Kiwi sons to face India in one-off match

Reo Sakurano-Thomas and Ibrahim Takahashi left Japan but returned; now they play the reigning world champions

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 21

IN JAPAN, first came love, then came cricket.

Many would cross continents for a glimpse of Mount Fuji, that towering mix of snow and lava. Around 1996, Tayyab Rabbani travelled more than 6,000 kilometres to see Japan's highest peak.

It would not be the only meeting of value. Somewhere along the way he met Tomoko Takahashi, then a student of nutrition and a private tutor besides. They found common ground in abundance, none richer than a zeal to explore the world and a shared penchant for hospitality.

Tayyab invited Tomoko to the Rabbani home in Islamabad, and she went. There she fell for his younger brother, Umar, and made him her companion for life.

In those same years, a New Zealander was making a journey of his own. Garth Thomas travelled roughly 9,160 kilometres, from Waikato to Toyama on Japan's western coast. He had a job teaching conversational English at Toyama University, a good salary, and every reason to think the move would be easy. Or so he thought.

Toyama, he soon discovered, was no Tokyo or Osaka, and few there could make sense of his Kiwi accent. Yuko Sakurano, a student at a neighbouring university, was among the fortunate few who could. She found him, and they fell in love.

Neither Tomoko nor Yuko, raised in Japan, knew much of a sport called cricket. It was,

however, part of life in Islamabad and Waikato, and Umar and Garth hoped their children would pick up the bat one day.

On Tuesday, those children will play for Japan against India, the reigning 20-over world champions. Ibrahim Takahashi and Reo Sakurano-Thomas have been named in the squad for the historic one-off fixture at the Sano Cricket Ground.

"I was born in Japan, in a city called Gotemba in Shizuoka Prefecture, right next to Mount Fuji. I lived there for the first eight years, before moving to Pakistan," Ibrahim tells *The Indian Express* from Japan.

In Pakistan, Umar looked after his ailing father. Ibrahim found cricket.

"All of my cousins played cricket, so I started playing with them. Among my earliest cricket memories is watching the 2007 T20 World Cup final. I remember Misbah-ul-Haq hitting that scoop, and all of us started jumping around, thinking it would be a six. But then, Sreesanth took that catch and all of us were heartbroken.

"I started playing for a local team called Junoon. Cricket has been my passion, though I never envisaged I would make it to the international level."

Reo moved to his father's Waikato at five. He found other pastimes, but none held him like cricket. He played U-19 cricket for Northern Districts.

"I played cricket all throughout my high school. The region I grew up in has given New Zealand some of its biggest stars: Kane Williamson, Mitchell Santner, Trent Boult."

For Ibrahim, a Shoaib Akhtar fanatic, the bat gave



All-rounder Reo Sakurano-Thomas (middle) with his Kiwi father and Japanese mother. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Ibrahim Takahashi's father hails from Pakistan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Neither Tomoko nor Yuko, raised in Japan, knew much of a sport called cricket. It was, however, part of life in Islamabad and Waikato, and Umar and Garth hoped their children would pick up the bat one day.

coming up, so I threw my hat into the ring. Luckily enough, I was selected."

Reo, who grew up idolising Brendon McCullum, came back for reasons of his own.

"I came back in 2022, after finishing my graduation in New Zealand. There were two main reasons: I got a job with the Japan Cricket Association, and I had ambitions of playing for the national team."

Today, he does both, and coaches Japan's U-16 and U-19 teams for the JCA.

Ibrahim now lives in Bris-

bane, where he went for his cricket and found his wife.

"I came to Australia on a tourist visa just to play grade three cricket and improve my skills. But along the way, I met my wife Zunerah, who also has her roots in Pakistan."

He cannot wait for the match against India. Neither can Umar.

"My dad is so excited that his son would be playing against the world's best cricket team. Jasprit Bumrah, my favourite bowler. Abhishek Sharma, from whom I learn fearlessness. All these guys are in Japan, it is surreal."

Reo says the same.

"Even in my wildest dream, I would not have imagined that the opportunity of playing against the world champions would arrive. My dad comments on Japan's matches. He probably won't get this particular gig, but I know he will be super proud that his son is playing against India."

JAPAN VS INDIA, T20I: 9:30 am, Live on FanCode and Star Sports Network

Suchika misses chance to fight for gold — all down to 700 grams

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, September 21

BEING 700 grams heavier than Hui Hoon Teo of Singapore in the semifinals cost India's MMA fighter Suchika Tariyal a place in the 60 kg final. This was despite her MMA bout being declared a draw after India protested the initial decision of the referee, which went in favour of the Singaporean.

In the case of a draw, MMA rules state that the heavier of the two fighters will progress. Thus Suchika's fate was sealed based on the weigh-in on the morning of the bout.

"I don't agree with the decision. I won in my view we can't do anything about it right now," Suchika told the media after the medal.

Suchika fought tooth and nail during the overtime — Teo's last-minute attack was nullified by the Indian's take-down. Both fighters were celebrating after the bout ended.

Despite the disappointment, the bronze is India's first medal in mixed martial arts (MMA), a sport making its debut at the Asian Games. Her first major medal also spoke volumes of the 36-year-old's desire to keep going. Suchika represented India in judo at the 2022 Commonwealth Games and in kurash at the 2023 Asian Games but had returned empty-handed. On Sunday, she took down Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalmaa 2-0 to enter the semifinals of the women's traditional MMA to confirm at least a bronze medal for India.

"This is more than my life. I will never forget that I came to Japan and got a medal for my country. I can now happily die," she told *PTI*.

At the end of the semifinal, which went into overtime, when Hoon Teo was declared the winner, Suchika refused to approach the ring referee. She eventually went in after her coaches coaxed her and when the referee raised her opponent's hand, she fell to her knees and broke down. Her opponent approached her for a



MMA fighter Suchika Tariyal protested the weigh-in decision. ASIAN MMA

handshake, but Suchika did not reciprocate. Finally, one of her coaches came to the mat and led her away.

"In our view, Suchika had won the bout. Anyone who saw the bout knows this. However, once the result was against us, we decided to protest the challenge. It cost us 1000 USD but it was worth the shot," Nikhil Kunder, who is president of the MMA-SFI — the national federation — told this paper. "There are no regrets about taking that call."

As a 12-year-old, Suchika picked up judo after a groping incident at a unisex salon left her helpless. "I went to a unisex salon and the barber touched me inappropriately," Suchika had told this paper earlier in an interview. "I felt that I should have something for my own defence. I should have some fighting skills with which I can fight back."

A few months later, she joined judo classes at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, close to the government quarters where she lived. Before she knew it, Suchika began winning age-group medals and, within a few years, became a junior national medallist. She went on to become an eight-time national champion in judo. She transitioned from judo to kurash to ju-jitsu to mixed martial arts now.

Suchika's husband, Kapil Hooda, who has supported her financially through this jour-

MMA fighter Sanyal says he had to cut weight by himself

MMA FIGHTER Varun Sanyal was forced to withdraw from the Asian Games after he passed out before his weight cut and was declared medically unfit. He was exhausted and dehydrated.

"I came here on two weeks' notice, I found out relatively late. I obviously had a bunch of accommodation issues, and then I was all by myself on a weight cut.

"In retrospect, that was quite foolish of me to do I had no choice but to do it by myself. That's a question, to be honest, I would like the public to ask, why was I alone? But, you know, things happen, life goes on," Varun told *PTI*.

He was ranked fourth in Asia and entered the continental showpiece as one of the medal contenders. *PTI*

ney, hopes that this medal will bring more exposure to the sport of MMA. "I don't want to dwell on what happened there. The bronze medal is a historic one and I think this will bring more and more recognition for combat sports like MMA and the athletes who pursue it."

Zaheer Khan appointed CSK head coach

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, September 21

CHENNAI SUPER Kings have named former India pacer Zaheer Khan as head coach, filling the role left vacant when Stephen Fleming parted ways with the franchise after 18 years. The 47-year-old was with Mumbai Indians between 2018 to 2022, first as director of cricket operations and then as global head of development before joining Lucknow Super Giants in 2024 as mentor for one season.

The Indian Express understands Zaheer has been given a one-year contract, open to extension. "We are pleased to confirm Zaheer Khan as the Head Coach for Chennai Super Kings. Zaheer's distinguished playing career and proven ability to nurture young talent make him a valuable addition to our setup. We are confident that his guidance will help strengthen the core of this franchise," CSK owner Rupa Gurunath said.

Zaheer, on his appointment, said: "It's an honour to be a part of one of the most successful teams in the history of the IPL. As a cricketer, I have faced CSK on the field and have thoroughly enjoyed the contests. The atmosphere created by the Superfans at Chepauk make it even more special. I can't wait to join the legacy franchise with such a rich history."

Hemang Badani was among those in contention, but there was a question mark over whether the candidates would accept the terms and conditions. After Fleming stepped aside, the franchise wanted an Indian coach and spoke to several candidates over the last couple of months before narrowing it down to Zaheer.

"It was MS who suggested Zaheer, and the cricket management team, comprising Rupa and Rituraj Gaikwad, agreed that he fits the role. He has previous experience of working in the IPL with MI and LSG, and given that, we felt he is the right choice," CSK managing director Kasi Viswanathan told *The Indian Express*.

In TT, players exchange handshakes and smiles as India beat Pakistan

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 21

A LIGHT nod of the head, followed by tapping of palms with your opponents, their coach and the umpire. Table tennis' post-match rituals, though subtler than other racket sports, are evident and consistent. The nod symbolises mutual respect and the handshake (or tap) acknowledges fair play.

The nod-tap routine has been part of the game all along. It doesn't get sacrificed amid personal differences. It didn't get sacrificed amid political ones too on Monday, when India faced Pakistan in the women's and men's team events of the Asian Games.

The Indian women — Sutirtha Mukherjee, Sreeja Akula and Syndrela Das — lined up

next to their Pakistani counterparts — Aleena Khan, Fatima Khan and Kalsoom Khan — before the Group F tie began. They shook hands with the match officials as well as the Khan trio, as is customary.

They did it again at the end of each match, concluding with Sreeja's win against Fatima. After shaking hands with Sreeja and umpires Mari Koda and Sanae Kobayashi, Fatima walked up to the Indian bench. Polite smiles were exchanged. The trend continued in the men's tie. There were warm handshakes.

Towards the fag end of the first match, Pakistan's Muhammad Khan attempted a laboured backhand flick against Harmeet Desai's serve. The shot sank in the net. Muhammad beamed at Harmeet,



India's Syndrela Das (R) shakes hands with Pakistan's Kalsoom Khan after their match in the women's team competition. SCREENGRAB/SONYLIV

amused with his over-ambitious stroke. Harmeet smiled back.

Later, once the tie ended,

while both camps went on with the post-match formalities, Muhammad patted Payas Jain's back.

• NERVES COME INTO PLAY

Chess Olympiad: Nihal blunders from a winning position, and takes India down with him

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 21

FOR MUCH of the four hours, the air inside the playing hall in Samarkand was thick with tension. It was the high-profile India vs Uzbekistan clash. The defending champions against the hosts. The top two boards had already drifted into draws, but on Board 3, a storm was brewing. Nihal Sarin and Nodirbek Yakubboev were locked in a battle so absorbing that D Gukesh and his opponent, Shamsiddin Vokhidov, abandoned their running game on Board 4 and were glued to the adjacent one. If the remaining games fizzled into draws, Budapest would repeat itself in Samarkand, and India would live to fight another day.

Then Yakubboev blundered, and the moment landed like a thunderclap. Nihal wasted no time seizing the advantage. Gukesh, sensing what had happened on the nearby board, immediately offered Vokhidov a draw. Vokhidov ac-



A distraught Nihal Sarin (R) after making a blunder. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

cepted. Yakubboev instantly knew what that meant. Gukesh loves to fight; he does not offer draws. For him to extend his hand now could only mean one thing: Nihal had a winning position. Everything was going according to India's plan.

And then, in the cruelest twist of the evening, the plan shattered almost instantly. With 30 minutes still on his clock and a nearly +2 advantage

in his grasp, Nihal collapsed. Three moves, that was all it took to turn a seeming triumph into disaster for both Nihal and India. Yakubboev, who had been staring into the abyss moments earlier, suddenly found himself staring at a miracle.

It didn't take long for the confirmation to arrive. Nihal battled on for a while, but there was nothing he could do to save his and India's day. From what

was looking like a 2.0-2.0 draw at first and then, for a moment, a 2.5-1.5 win, India eventually slumped to a 1.5-2.5 defeat against the home side and the crowd favourites. With Uzbekistan already ahead on game points before the clash, this crushing loss just before the rest day has left India's title defence hanging by a thread.

Vidit Gujrathi, the fifth member of the Indian team, simply couldn't believe what he saw. "Is it possible to miss this? He had time... he had time!" said a dejected Vidit while commenting live on Chessbase India.

Chess is a cruel sport, where one misstep can cost you everything. And when Yakubboev laid the trap in an inferior position, it isn't every day that someone falls into it. At the top level, brainfade moments don't happen that easily or that often. "You give him this position, wake him up at 5 AM, and he'll find the move," said Vidit.

So how can an elite Grandmaster go so wrong in just one

move? "It's all nerves," Vidit explained.

"It's a pity. He played a great game, a fantastic game... that is chess. I am only feeling bad, and I am sure he must also be feeling the same... that he rushed into the move. That was excitement. I have been in his shoes many times and felt what he is feeling. You sense it's winning, and then the nerves take over and you play something like this. Otherwise, there's no chance Nihal misses this. It's all nerves. It's not about the tactics," he added.

Grandmaster SP Sethuraman, who had travelled to Samarkand as Nihal's new second, perfectly encapsulated what chess is all about. After Nihal's heartbreaking loss, he wrote on X, "You prepare hard, go in with full ambition, play brilliantly, put your opponent under pressure throughout the game, and then one momentary lapse can turn everything around."

"That's why chess is so brutal."

Savitha, Vantika keep Olympiad medal hopes alive with win over USA

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, September 21

THE INDIAN women's Olympiad team bounced back from a defeat to Poland in the fifth round with a solid victory over the fifth-seeded US team, thanks to the form of their bottom two board players, Savitha Shri and Vantika Agrawal. The victory keeps their medal chances alive and also keeps the door ajar on them being in the frame for a gold medal, just like they did in Budapest.

While India decided to rest Vaishali against the US after her loss on Sunday, Divya Deshmukh and Koneru Humpy took draws in the sixth round. India won the tie thanks to Savitha prevailing over Rose Atwell in 47 moves and Vantika defeating Grandmaster Irina Krush.

Both International Masters have had a great Olympiad for India, emerging as a reliable backbone of the team. While Vantika has had a draw in the

five games she has played, 19-year-old Savitha - playing in her first over-the-board Olympiad for India - has won all five games. Incidentally, in the only contest in which the team decided she should rest, India suffered a defeat against Poland. Savitha's five wins also mean she's India's best player in terms of form in Samarkand across the two Indian teams contesting.

"I was a little nervous coming into this round because we had lost to Poland yesterday, and if something went wrong, there would be no chance of us winning a medal," Savitha said on the ChessBase India live stream during a brief visit after her win.

The Indian team has sterner tests lying in wait over the next five rounds: sides like Georgia (seeded second), Kazakhstan (third) and China (fourth). But the form of Savitha and Vantika gives them hope that they could still try their luck at a gold medal chase, irrespective of how tough the task is now.